# Parties' responsiveness to political protests in Western Europe

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# Abstract

This doctoral thesis explores *whether*, *how*, and *under which conditions* political parties are responsive to street protests. While the link between political parties and voters has been weakening over decades, people continue to turn to the streets to voice their demands and partake in the democratic process. Whether political parties are responsive towards protests has important implications for the health of democracies. Political protests are conceptualised as a specifically powerful signal of public opinion, and political parties are assumed to be rational, goal-oriented actors who are democratically responsive to changes in public opinion due to possible electoral repercussions or potential electoral gains. Consequently, the thesis assumes that protests might well have an agenda-setting effect on parties. However, the electoral incentive of parties to respond to protests is expected to depend on the electoral context, the party's characteristics, and the protest's characteristics. Chapter 2 reviews existing literature on research on protest outcomes, party competition and the intersection of the two fields. Chapter 3 outlines the central theoretical argument of the thesis. Chapter 4 studies three questions; i) whether environmental and radical-right protests have an agenda-setting on political parties' parliamentary agendas; ii) whether parties respond to radical-right protests with questions on far-right violence and radicalism, and; iii) the extent to which the parliamentary entrance of an institutional ally affects parties' responsiveness to protests. Using a regression discontinuity in time design, the chapter analyses protests and parliamentary questions in Germany from 1975 to 2019. The results show that protests rarely have an agenda-setting effect of parties - regardless of the parliamentary presence of institutional allies. However, parties do respond to

radical-right protests with questions on far-right violence. Chapter 5 examines the effect of the Fridays for Future protests on regional parties' press releases in Germany. The chapter investigates; i) whether opposition parties are more responsive than governmental parties; ii) whether parties which faced electoral losses in the most recent elections are more prone to respond to protests; and iii) whether parties are more responsive when elections draw near. Using a difference-in-difference and matching approach, the analysis produces similar results to Chapter 4. Parties are rarely responsive to protests, and only parties who faced major electoral losses respond with increased attention on the environment following protests. Finally, Chapter 6 explores whether voters punish or reward parties' responsiveness to protests. Using a survey experiment in Germany, the study finds that voters care little about how parties respond to protest mobilisation. The results and their implications are discussed in the conclusion. Overall, these findings have important implications for our understanding of the political consequences of non-institutionalised political participation and to parties' democratic responsiveness.

# Zusammenfassung

Diese Doktorarbeit erforscht, ob, wie und unter welchen Bedingungen politische Parteien auf Proteste reagieren. Während die Wählerbindung an politische Parteien in den letzten Jahrzehnten immer schwächer wurde, greifen Menschen weiterhin auf Proteste zurück, um ihre Forderungen zu äußern und am demokratischen Prozess teilzunehmen. Ob politische Parteien auf Proteste reagieren, hat wichtige Implikationen den Zustand von Demokratien. Politische Proteste werden als ein starkes Signal der öffentlichen Meinung konzeptualisiert; politische Parteien als rationale, zielgerichtete Akteure, die aufgrund potenzieller Konsequenzen an der Wahlurne auf Veränderungen in der öffentlichen Meinung reagieren. Infolgedessen ist die Kernannahme der Doktorarbeit, dass Proteste durchaus einen agendasetzenden Einfluss auf Parteien haben können. Allerdings wird erwartet, dass der Anreiz von Parteien, auf Proteste zu reagieren, von dem politischen Kontext, Merkmalen der Partei und Merkmalen der Proteste abhängt. Kapitel 2 schafft einen Überblick für die vorhandene Literatur zu Forschungen zu den Konsequenzen von Protesten, zum Parteienwettbewerb und zum Schnittpunkt der beiden Felder. Kapitel 3 skizziert das zentrale theoretische Argument der Arbeit. Kapitel 4 behandelt drei Fragen: i) ob Umwelt- und rechtsradikale Proteste eine agendasetzende Wirkung auf die parlamentarischen Agenden politischer Parteien haben; ii) ob Parteien auf rechtsradikale Proteste mit Anfragen zu Gewalt und Radikalismus der extremen Rechten reagieren; und iii) inwieweit der parlamentarische Eintritt eines Institutional ally die Responsivität der Parteien auf Proteste beeinflusst. Die Analyse setzt ein Regressionsdiskontinuitätsdesign ein und analysiert Proteste und parlamentarische Anfragen in Deutschland von 1975 bis 2019. Die Ergeb-

nisse zeigen, dass Proteste in der Regel keine agendasetzende Wirkung auf Parteien haben, unabhängig von der parlamentarischen Präsenz von Institutional allies. Allerdings reagieren Parteien auf rechtsradikale Proteste mit Anfragen zur Gewalt der extremen Rechten. Kapitel 5 untersucht die Auswirkungen der Fridays-for-Future-Proteste auf Pressemitteilungen regionaler Parteien in Deutschland. Das Kapitel untersucht: i) ob Oppositionsparteien responsiver sind als Regierungsparteien; ii) ob Parteien, die bei den letzten Wahlen Verluste erlitten haben, eher auf Proteste reagieren; und iii) ob Parteien responsiver sind, wenn Wahlen bevorstehen. Das Kapitel verwendet einen Differenz-von-Differenzen-Ansatz und eine Matching-Methode und bestätigt die Ergebnisse in Kapitel 4. Parteien reagieren selten auf Proteste, und nur Parteien, die große Wahlniederlagen erlitten haben, reagieren mit verstärkter Aufmerksamkeit auf Umweltthemen nach den Protesten. Schließlich untersucht Kapitel 6, ob Wähler Parteien für ihre Reaktionen auf Proteste bestrafen oder belohnen. Mit einem Umfrageexperiment in Deutschland kommt die Studie zu dem Ergebnis, dass Wähler wenig Wert darauf legen, wie Parteien auf Proteste reagieren. Im Abschluss werden die Ergebnisse und ihre Implikationen diskutiert. Insgesamt haben diese Erkenntnisse wichtige Auswirkungen auf unser Verständnis der politischen Konsequenzen nichtinstitutioneller politischer Partizipation und der demokratischen Responsivität von Parteien.

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# Chapter 1

# Introduction

*Everyone has the right to freedom of peaceful assembly and association.*

- Article 20, Universal Declaration of Human Rights

Recent decades have witnessed extensive academic debate on the decline of political parties' representative function in democracies (Bardi et al., 2015; Mair, 2013). Political parties have faced a steady decrease in membership (Biezen and Poguntke, 2014), reduced citizen participation in traditional democratic process (Hooghe and Kern, 2017) and increasing levels of electoral volatility (Dalton et al., 2002). The link between political parties and civil society has been weakened, with voters identifying less with parties (Dalton, 2002) and generally displaying low trust in them (Marien, 2011). In contrast to this decline in citizens' engagement with traditional political institutions, less traditional forms of participation such as street protests are becoming increasingly popular (Giugni and Grasso, 2018) as a means of voicing grievance and influencing the democratic process (Dalton, 1988; Quaranta, 2015). The perception of protests has also changed: Once considered a political anomaly associated with riots and revolutions (Goodwin and Jasper, 2015), protesting has now established itself as a legitimate channel of political expression (Norris, 2002; Barnes et al., 1979). Given their dwindling influence as political institutions, one might expect parties to be highly responsive to political demands voiced by citizens via non-

traditional channels such as protest. This doctoral thesis establishes whether this is the case by exploring political parties' responsiveness to political protests and evaluating the effectiveness of street mobilisation as a form of political participation.

With parties in apparently terminal decline, one might wonder why they need to be studied at all. Why should we care about their responsiveness? But despite their troubles, parties remain core institutions of political representation which structure and orchestrate the political process (Powell, 2019; Dalton et al., 2011). Moreover, while the perception and significance of unconventional political participation has evolved, protesters remain outside the realm of institutional politics and are dependent on sympathetic political elites to actually implement their policy demands. Ultimately, if the success of democracy is "largely measured by the public's participation in the process and responsiveness of the system to popular demands" (Dalton, 1988, p.7), then understanding the nature of political parties' responses to protests' demands - and determining whether they respond at all - could reveal useful insights into parties' role in society and the health of democracy as a whole.

Considering the importance of this question, it should come as no surprise that scholars have gone to great lengths to establish exactly what makes political protests successful. Multiple studies have concluded that protests do indeed have an agenda-setting effect (Schumaker, 1975; Baumgartner and Mahoney, 2005; King et al., 2007; Johnson, 2008; Olzak and Soule, 2009; Johnson et al., 2010; Vliegenthart et al., 2016; Walgrave and Vliegenthart, 2012; Hutter and Vliegenthart, 2018). However, existing studies have only paid limited attention to the political contexts and electoral incentives which might affect parties' responses to protests. Furthermore, prior studies have faced numerous methodological challenges which have often limited the research to correlational studies, small-N studies, or empirical focus on single movements. The result is five gaps in the literature (explained in more detail below) which this thesis seeks to address by combining insights from research on political parties' behaviour and party competition with innovative methodological approaches based on rich, fine-grained data. In so doing, this thesis contributes to our un-

derstanding of party responsiveness to street protests and the role of protests in today's democracies.

## The main argument of the thesis

The central goal of this thesis is to develop our understanding of the party-protest relationship by establishing the extent to which political parties' responses to protests are influenced by party competition. While scholars of party competition broadly agree that political parties are rational, goal-oriented actors who are democratically responsive to changes in public opinion due to possible repercussions or potential gains in subsequent elections (Stimson et al., 1995), the field has yet to fully explore parties' responsiveness to protests in particular. At the same time, research into protest mobilisation has confirmed its capacity to set the overall political agenda, but has yet to fully explore the incentives of individual parties. This thesis attempts to bridge this gap by determining how various elements of party competition affect parties' responses to protest, and whether their response in turn influences voter behaviour.

Protests are defined as a "none-routine way of affecting political, social and cultural processes" (Della Porta and Diani, 2006, p. 165) which constitute an act of "challenging, resisting, or making demands upon authorities, power-holders, and/or cultural beliefs and practices by some individual or groups" (Goodwin and Jasper, 2015, p. 3). Protests represent a specific signal of public opinion. By taking to the streets with signs, slogans and banners, protesters engage in a public 'performance' which communicates their claims and grievances to policymakers and broader society. Protesters cannot achieve their political objectives directly, as they do not have access to established political institutions. Consequently, the sympathy, support, and attention of political elites are crucial for protests' success (Della Porta and Diani, 2006).

While democratic responsiveness can take many forms from introducing new policies to acknowledging voters' concerns in speeches and parties' manifestos, this thesis focuses on party responsiveness at the agenda-setting stage of policymaking. Democratic responsiveness in the form of issue attention may not

always translate into concrete policy outcomes, but a shift in the attention paid to a political issue is considered to be the precondition for any policy change (Baumgartner and Jones, 1993; Jones and Baumgartner, 2005). Political parties' electoral and ideological incentives to respond to protest mobilisation are shaped by a range of contextual factors including the extent to which protests represent a threat or a potential gain for parties. While responding to protests might appeal to the protesters as voters, and to members of the public who sympathise with the protest's causes, not responding may also entail electoral repercussions, mobilising voters sympathetic to the protest against the non-responsive party and motivating them to vote for other parties within the system such as the protests' institutional allies. The characteristics of the party and the nature of the protest's cause might also be expected to influence a party's ability and willingness to engage with the protests' grievance. By exploring *how* and *under which conditions* political parties respond to street mobilisation, the thesis goes beyond the question of *whether* parties respond in order to enrich our understanding of parties' democratic responsiveness and the political consequences of non-institutionalised political participation.

## The research design

The thesis explores political parties' responsiveness to protests in the context of Western Europe using the case of Germany. Western European countries are all established democracies with relatively homogeneous cultural, political and historical heritage (Quaranta, 2015), and Germany is a representative case for both party politics and protest mobilisation in Western Europe. Beyond its generalisability, Germany is an especially interesting case for studying protest mobilisation. Despite lagging behind other Western European countries in terms of protest mobilisation in the first decade following the Second World War, Germany soon caught up (Karapin, 2007) and has developed a vibrant protest culture on both the Right and the Left. Moreover, Germany's relatively stable party system has seen the entrance of two new political parties emblematic of the changing political landscape and the emergence of a new socio-cultural cleavage in Western Europe since the 1970s.

The thesis' empirical analysis encompasses legal demonstrations, marches and street protests. Chapter 4 covers all media-reported environmental and radical-right protests in Germany from 1975 to 2019 using data sources from the Prodat project (Rucht and Teune, 2010) and the Protest-Monitoring data set from the *Monitoringsystem und Transferplatform Radikalisierung* (MOTRA) project (Hutter et al., 2023). Chapter 5 examines one of the most mobilising environmental movements in recent times - the Fridays for Future movement - and uses self-reported protest data collected by Valentim (2023). Shifting the focus onto voters' reception of parties' responsiveness to protests, the experiment conducted in Chapter 6 uses hypothetical examples of environmental and economic growth demonstrations.

The protests covered in this thesis were selected for a number of reasons. Firstly, Chapter 4 includes all protests in Germany from the 1975 - 2019 period regardless of size or location in order to avoid skewed outcomes that might arise by focusing exclusively on large, well-known and well-organised protests. Secondly, the environmental and radical-right protests covered in Chapter 4 allow the thesis to explore issues which cut across the traditional left-right cleavage and are thus relevant for all political parties across the spectrum. Thirdly, Chapter 5 focuses exclusively on protests from one movement so that movement characteristics are held constant.

To measure parties' responsiveness, Chapter 4 utilises data on parliamentary questions which were collected and classified using a supervised machine learning approach - resulting in over 26,000 parliamentary questions. Chapter 5 employs data on political parties' press releases at the regional level which was collected by Kittel and Wegemann (2023) and coded into relevant policy fields using a classifier developed by Erfort et al. (2023). This extensive and rich data source was analysed using a regression discontinuity in time design (Hausman and Rapson, 2018) in Chapter 4 and a mixture of matching and difference-in-difference approach developed by Imai et al. (2023) in Chapter 5. Chapter 6 employs a survey experiment with text vignette treatments to causally estimate the effect of parties' responsiveness towards protests on voting behaviour.

## The contribution of the thesis

This thesis contributes to the literature on political parties, protest mobilisation, and democratic responsiveness by exploring whether, how and under which conditions political parties respond to street mobilisation in Western Europe. The thesis identifies and addresses five gaps in the literature on protests' outcomes.

First, existing studies on the link between protests and parties have not explored how the parliamentary entrance of a new political party which supports a protest's cause can affect established parties' responses to that protest. However, research into the emergence of new parties has found them to have wide-ranging effects on the policy position and issue salience of existing parties (Abou-Chadi, 2016; Abou-Chadi and Krause, 2018; Van Spanje, 2010; Spoon et al., 2014; Meguid, 2008). Chapter 4 addresses this gap by analysing political parties' responsiveness to environmental protests and radical-right protests in Germany. The chapter also explores whether this responsiveness changed after the entry of the Green Party and the populist radical right party, AfD, into parliament.

Second, existing research on parties' responsiveness to protests and social movements has only explored a limited number of factors which might make parties more or less responsive to protests. These includes parties' opposition status or their ideology. However, research on the democratic responsiveness of political elites has identified numerous other factors which condition elites' responsiveness. Chapter 5 studies individual parties' electoral incentives for responding to Fridays for Future protests in Germany beyond their opposition status, and investigates how electoral vulnerability and the electoral context affects political parties' responsiveness to protests.

Third, scholars of social movements have often complained over the singular focus on actors on the Left. This has involved scholars often limiting their analytical focus both to protests on the Left and political elites on the Left. Consequently, research on the political outcomes of protests on the Right or the responsiveness of political elite on the Right is limited. This thesis addresses this gap by including parties from across the political spectrum and by analysing

the political consequences of radical-right protests in Chapter 4.

Fourth, while research on political elites' responsiveness to protest mobilisation is growing, we know little to nothing about the potential electoral consequences of this responsiveness. Chapter 6 moves away from parties as the dependent variable and shifts the focus to voters' preferences, evaluating whether parties have anything to gain or to lose electorally by responding to protest mobilisation.

Finally, despite extensive study of the political consequences of protests and social movements, many of the existing studies face numerous methodological difficulties in causally estimating the true effect of mobilisation. This thesis addresses the methodological challenges prior studies have faced by using extensive, rich data sets and innovative methodological approaches to causally estimate the effect of protest events on parties' political agendas.

Overall, the analysis finds that political protests have a very limited agenda-setting effect, rarely triggering any kind of response from political parties. Some exceptions are evident, with Chapter 5 indicating that parties do respond to protest mobilisation if they have experienced a substantial electoral loss in the most recent election, and Chapter 4 suggesting that parties respond to radical-right protests with an increase in parliamentary questions on far-right violence and far-right groups. Shifting the focus from parties to voting behaviour, one might expect voters to punish parties for the non-responsiveness evident in Chapters 4 and 5. However, Chapter 6 reveals that this is not the case, finding that a party's level of responsive to protests has no effect on voter behaviour. The potential implications of these findings are discussed in Chapter 7.

## The structure of the thesis

Chapter 2 provides definitions and theoretical discussions of the central concepts, and reviews the existing literature on political parties' behaviour, democratic responsiveness, and the political consequences of political protests. The chapter also details the central contributions of this thesis. Chapter 3 elaborates

on the central theoretical relationship between political parties and political protests. The empirical analysis of the thesis is covered in Chapter 4, Chapter 5, and Chapter 6. Finally, the implications of the findings are discussed and contextualised in Chapter 7. Although the right to demonstrate and protest is entrenched in most democratic constitutions, it seems that established political parties pay little heed to the grievances of political protests. The thesis contributes to our understanding of the political consequences of unconventional political participation and our existing knowledge of political parties' responsiveness to public opinion.

# Chapter 2

# Literature review

This chapter reviews existing research on parties and protests as well as defining their core characteristics and roles within the political system. Studies on the intersection between protests and parties are also discussed covering three different strands of research - the political opportunity approach, the contentious politics approach, and the agenda-setting approach. The final section of the chapter outlines how this thesis contributes to the literature by drawing on insights from existing research on party competition and democratic responsiveness to bridge the gap between research conducted on parties, and research conducted on protests.

## What are political protests?

Before delving into the literature, it is essential to clearly define the core concepts of the thesis; protests, political parties, and democratic responsiveness. Only by doing so can we understand and contextualise existing research on the topics, and establish why political protests and parties need to be studied in unison. For the purposes of this thesis, protests are defined as a "non-routine way of affecting political, social and cultural processes" (Della Porta and Diani, 2006, p. 165). They are a "collective action of individuals aimed at achieving their goal or goals by influencing decisions of a target" (Opp, 2009, p. 38) and they constitute

an act of "challenging, resisting, or making demands upon authorities, power-holders, and/or cultural beliefs and practices by some individual or groups" (Goodwin and Jasper, 2015, p. 3).

While protests can differ in many ways, this thesis will draw on Tilly's (2008) work on contentious politics and focus on protests which exhibit the three following characteristics of being; contentious, collective, and political. Additionally, to clearly delineate the protests studies in this thesis, a fourth characteristic - their public nature - is included. The rest of this sub-chapter will elaborate on these four points.

The first important characteristic of protests is their *contentious* nature. Unconventional political participation - whether it take the form of protests, social movements or revolutions - has at its heart the act of *contentious collective action*. In this context, protests are defined as "contentious" because they are initiated by actors who lack regular access to institutions and power (Tarrow, 1998). They are frequented by a collection of 'ordinary people' making "claims that bear on someone else's interest" (Tilly, 2008, p. 5) - most often power holders such as elites, authorities, and institutions. In its simplest form, contention always involves a subject - the protesters - an object - e.g. the government - and a claim - which if realised would positively affect the subject's interests (Tilly, 2008). Conceptualising protesters as actors who lack regular access to institutions and powers means that they are located outside the realm of policy making. However, while the distinction between the 'insiders' and 'outsiders' of polity has been central in scholars' understanding of extra-institutional mobilisation like protests (Tilly, 1978; Gamson, 1990), the meaning of these terms has become increasingly blurred with changing times: Protest movements like the civil rights movement and the women's movement were organised by people who had been systematically, politically, and legally discriminated against and demanded the full rights of citizenship. They did not only lack *regular* access to institutional politics, but they lacked access entirely, as they were often granted neither active nor passive suffrage. By contrast, subsequent movements like the environmental movement would rather focus on cultural and political issues, and are driven by citizens who already have the right to vote and participate

by institutional means (Goodwin and Jasper, 2015). Consequently, an actor's status as an 'insider' or 'outsider' no longer depends on their access to institutional means, but on their pursuit of actions outside of established political institutions like courts, legislatures or executives (Della Porta and Diani, 2006).

The second important characteristic of contentious actions like protests are their *collective* nature: They are created when groups united by a common claim take to the streets (Opp, 2009; Tarrow, 1998). In order to attract like-minded individuals, protests require a degree of coordination between participants. While some forms of contentious actions and protests are not collective - for example hunger strikes - the thesis focuses on street mobilisations such as marches and demonstrations. This type of protest requires multiple individuals to be considered contentious action, as a single person's "march" would likely attract little attention from the media, public, and policymakers.

The third characteristic of protests is that they are *public*. They take place in public squares and streets, thus making the claims of the participants public. Tilly (2008) sees contentious action as the product of learned and historically grounded public performances. Protesters perform their claims publicly through their actions, and by doing so link their claims to their object (e.g. the government). Moreover, protesters tend to employ a repertoire of public claim-making anchored in historical precedent. This limits their actions to public demonstrations, meetings and press statements, and restricts them from engaging in actions that are not accepted as established protest repertoires like suicide bombing and hostage-taking. This is an important element for the definition of protests included in this thesis, as it limits the sample to protests that take a socially acceptable form.

Fourth, the contentious actions investigated in this thesis are *political*. The protests engage in a political confrontation, and their claims and messages are directed towards authorities, power-holders, and/or cultural beliefs (Goodwin and Jasper, 2015). They seek to alter political issues and processes such as political representation, public policies, or the relationships between citizens and the state (Jenkins and Klandermans, 1995).

Briefly summarising, the protests included in the thesis are contentious, collective, public and political with claims focusing on the environment and concerns about immigration. By taking to the streets, protesters publicly 'perform' their claims to policymakers and broader society. The protesters thereby send a signal of their grievances and communicate their claims. While a protest's goal might be to alter certain political issues, protesters cannot achieve this directly, as they do not have access to established political institutions. Consequently, the sympathy, support, and attention of political elites are crucial for protests' success (Della Porta and Diani, 2006). Questions around the extent to which protests successfully influence political elites have received much scholarly attention and will be discussed in the following sub-chapter.

## Successful protests?

Scholars have long been preoccupied with the question of what makes political protest 'successful' in affecting political outcomes. A plethora of studies has contributed to our knowledge on the political outcome of protests, ranging from their effect on political elites' agendas, public policies, and public opinion. Perhaps the most promising avenue for studying protests' outcomes has been the policy agenda approach. Originating in Kingdon's (1984) work on policy windows and policy entrepreneurs, and Schattschneider's (1960) work on the expansion of the scope of the political conflict, the policy agenda approach assumes that "agenda foreshadows outcomes" (Riker, 1993, p. 1). According to the approach, all political decisions require political attention. This attention can take the form of resources, time, personnel etc. (Baumgartner and Jones, 1993; Jones and Baumgartner, 2005) - making the outcome of the approach very versatile ranging from budget spending, the founding of committees, hearings, speeches, non-legislative parliamentary activities, to parties' and MP's political communication. The central premise of the policy approach is that a shift in the attention paid to a political issue is the precondition for any policy change (ibid.).

When investigating protests' political outcomes via the policy agenda approach, scholars assume that protest movements raise awareness of political

issues through their collective action, provide frames for policy-making debates, and inform lawmakers of new issues. In turn, they increase public awareness and political attention on the issue under contention (Giugni et al., 1999). Following the approach, protests are considered successful when they result in political elites paying increased attention to 'their' political issue - without a focus on the final policy outcomes. The numerous studies exploring the agenda-setting power of protests has found demonstrations and social movements' activities to increase the attention paid to their issue in the US Congress (Schumaker, 1975; Baumgartner and Mahoney, 2005; King et al., 2007; Johnson, 2008; Olzak and Soule, 2009; Johnson et al., 2010) and across number of parliaments in Western Europe (Vliegenthart et al., 2016; Walgrave and Vliegenthart, 2012; Hutter and Vliegenthart, 2018). Studies have also found that representatives change their discourse around political issues in their online communication (Barrie et al., 2023; Berker and Pollex, 2021) and refer to protest movements on social media following protest events (Schürmann, 2023). While numerous studies demonstrate the agenda-setting effect protests can have, there are also studies which have found very limited evidence of a direct effect of protests on political elites' agendas (Giugni, 2004; Barrie et al., 2023; Uba, 2009; Amenta et al., 2010). One can only speculate what might explain the mixed findings, as these studies cover a wide range of protests and a wide range of agendas which can be affected (online communication, parliamentary debates, parliamentary questions etc.).

However, beyond the range of studies on the agenda-setting power of protests, empirical evidence on direct policy outcomes of protests is scarce. Although studies have identified a link between protests mobilisation and legislators' roll call behaviour (Gause, 2022; Burstein and Freudenburg, 1978; McAdam and Su, 2002; Gillion, 2012), this effect does not seem to translate into favourable policy outcomes. In fact, most scholars struggle to identify any direct effect of protest movements and the passing of a favourable law (Amenta et al., 2010; Johnson, 2008; Olzak and Soule, 2009), and conclude that protests and social movements only have an effect on policies when public opinion is highly favourable (Agnone, 2007; Bernardi et al., 2021; Giugni and Passy, 1998; Kane, 2003). Puzzled by the discrepancy between the agenda-setting power of protests

and their lack of direct policy outcomes, scholars have sought to explain it based on varying accessibility of different policy stages. The agenda-setting approach to protests' outcomes focuses on the early stage of the policy process, where new ideas are being introduced (Kingdon, 1984), issues are being defined (Baumgartner and Jones, 1993), and protests can provide new information to lawmakers by highlighting a policy problem. However, as the protests' issue travels from the agenda-formation stage to policy formulation and decision-making (Fischer et al., 2007), there will be more contingencies, complexities, and stringent requirements (King et al., 2007).

In addition to the question of *whether* protest movements have political consequences, numerous studies have explored *which* characteristics constrain or facilitate protests in affecting political elites and garnering public support. The size of a protest has been underlined as a crucial factor for gaining the attention of policymakers and signalling that a large section of society supports their cause (Lohmann, 1993). Analysis by McAdam and Su (2002) of the anti-war movement in the US showed that large demonstrations were associated with higher monthly counts of war-related congressional roll calls, and Johnson (2008) found that the size of environmental movements' protests in the US determined their agenda-setting power in the US Congress.

Scholars have also examined movement tactics. Despite disruptive and extreme tactics being able to attract more media attention and increase pressure on policymakers (McAdam and Su, 2002; Jennings and Saunders, 2019), they have been persistently found to decrease public support for the protest movements (Feinberg et al., 2020; Wouters, 2019; Selvanathan and Lickel, 2019; Simpson et al., 2018; Wasow, 2020). By contrast, unity among protesters (Wouters, 2019; Wouters and Walgrave, 2017) and a coherent, clear message (Fassiotto and Soule, 2017) is associated with higher support for the protesters and lawmakers' responsiveness towards the movement. Finally, scholars have increasingly favoured dis-aggregated analyses of social movement's political consequences, which have linked local protest events with individual politicians' roll-call behaviour in the US Congress (Gillion, 2012, 2020) and local politicians' online communications in Germany (Schürmann, 2023).

So far, this literature overview has demonstrated that a multitude of research exists on the political outcome of protest mobilisation. Furthermore, research has identified numerous protests' characteristics which moderate protests' agenda-setting effect. While existing research provides invaluable insights, it has generally focused on protests rather than political parties. Consequently, little attention has been paid to parties' varying electoral incentives for responding to protests, and the moderating effect which various party characteristics might have on this response. However, research on political parties - which has not paid much attention to protests - highlights the importance of the political landscape and party competition in order to explain parties' policy positions and their issue attention. The next sub-chapter will provide an overview of party research, the definition of political parties, and the role they play in today's democracies.

## What are political parties?

In order to understand why and how political parties can be expected to respond to protests and, in turn, why that responsiveness is essential for protests' goals, this sub-chapter outlines what political parties are, what motivates them, and how they fulfill their representative role in democracies.

As a central channel of representation in today's' democracies, political parties perform a multitude of crucial tasks. Understanding parties' responses to protests is thus crucial in determining protests' final outcomes. Reduced to their most essential function, political parties are defined as "any political group identified by an official label that presents at elections, and is capable of placing through elections (free or non-free), candidates for public office" (Sartori, 2005, p. 63). This definition not only highlights the differences between political parties and interest groups or social movements, but also alludes to political parties' roles and functions in today's democracies. Large-scale modern democracies are made possible through political representation for which political parties are the main organisational vehicle, and thus play an indispensable role in today's democracies. In fact, political parties' emergence in the early twentieth century is so deeply intertwined with the representative model of democracy, that the

latter is almost unthinkable without the former (Schattschneider, 1942; Strom and Müller, 1999). Consequently, it is of no small importance to protests that their claims be heard and acknowledged by parties.

Political parties fulfil their role as the primary linkage between political outcomes and voters in various ways. For example, when it comes to elections, political parties play an important organisational role. This involves the recruitment, training, and political socialisation of party leaders and candidates for political office. Political parties are also the main organisers of electoral campaigns. Before elections, political parties develop coherent political manifestos to reduce the policy complexity for voters, educate citizens, and aggregate the political interests of their supporters. Beyond offering policy platforms, parties mobilise citizens to electorally participate, and in turn voters base their choices on the policy alternatives political parties offer (Dalton et al., 2011).

However, the important role fulfilled by political parties is not limited to organising elections. Once voting has finished, political parties are also a crucial part of government formation. This involves coalition negotiations between parties and allocating ministerial positions. When in government, political parties are responsible for implementing policies, while opposition parties are responsible for holding the government to account and scrutinising policy (Dalton et al., 2011).

The multitude of crucial tasks fulfilled by political parties in today's democracies illustrate that they are one of the central channels of representation, and that their responsiveness to protests is crucial to protests' final political outcomes. Representing voters and delivering or scrutinising policy objectives are complex tasks which require parties to be strategic and goal-oriented in order to provide effective governance or opposition, gain votes and ultimately gain or remain in office. Scholars differentiate between three different models of party behaviour in achieving these goals: office-seeking, policy-seeking, and vote-seeking (Strom and Müller, 1999; Strom, 1990). According to the office-seeking model, political parties' primary goal is to gain control over political office (Riker, 1962) - may that be out of intrinsic or instrumental motivation (Budge and Laver, 1986). By contrast, the policy-seeking model assumes that

political parties strive to maximise their effect on public policy (Strom, 1990). Finally, parties can be seen as sheer vote-maximisers. Originating in Downs' (1957) work on parties, the model assumes that "vote-maximising is the basic motive underlying the behaviour of parties" (Downs, 1957, p. 159). While each of these approaches has received individual criticism for being overly simplistic, together they provide an overarching structure for research into parties, who are assumed to pursue some combination of all three goals and make various trade-offs to achieve this balance (Strom and Müller, 1999; Strom, 1990).

This sub-chapter has so far outlined the central tasks political parties fulfill in modern democracies: They are the primary organisational force in elections and parliaments, and link voters to policy outcomes. They are also considered to be rational, goal-oriented actors who have incentives ranging from gaining office to maximising their vote share and implementing their policies. The crucial role of political parties in representative democracies highlights why their responsiveness is essential for political protests' goals. The following sub-chapter provides an overview of the empirical research on political parties' behaviour and party competition. While political protests are completely absent from this strand of research, it enhances our understanding of political parties and illuminates why and how parties can be expected to respond to protests.

## Research on party competition

Research on party competition has been dominated by two central approaches: the spatial approach and the theory of issue competition. Developed by Anthony Downs (1957), the spatial model assumes that voters can be located in a unidimensional policy space - usually conceptualised as the left-right axes. Parties, in turn, seek to maximise their votes by positioning themselves in ideological proximity to the median voter and adjusting their position in response to any changes in the voters' position. According to the spatial model, political representation and democratic responsiveness are primarily defined through issue congruence between voters and parties. Downs' work would lay the foundation for the lion's share of empirical work on party competition and democratic responsiveness. However, this line of research has provided mixed results - with

some studies finding that parties adjust their left-right ideological position to changes in public opinion (Adams et al., 2004, 2006; Adams and Somer-Topcu, 2009), while other studies found no such link once taking a more nuanced analytical approach to different issue dimension (O'Grady and Abou-Chadi, 2019). Furthermore, scholars have not only applied the spatial model to study the link between parties and public opinion, but also to how parties' positions are interlinked, finding that parties adjust their policy position relative to other parties' policy positions (Adams and Somer-Topcu, 2009).

The spatial approach has received a fair share of criticism for its simplicity and the lack of analytical merit for issues that fit poorly onto the left-right dimension. Theories of issue competition were born from this line of criticism. Moreover, theories of issue competition reflect the idea that parties do not only compete for votes through position-taking, but also by providing attention to a specific issue. This theory was first introduced by Stokes' 1963 work on valence issues where he criticised the spatial logic of Downs and its assumption of a unidimensional political space. Stokes was interested in issues that did not contain a set of two alternative poles, resulting in parties being unable to compete spatially on them. This included issues such as the environment, unemployment, or corruption. While Stokes acknowledged that a positional logic lurked behind many of these valence issues, it did not define the debate around them, as voters and parties were all striving towards the same goal, i.e. improved environmental sustainability, low unemployment or reduced corruption. Introducing the concept of valence issues shifted the focus from the spatial logic of party competition and representation onto the relationship between the political issues voters find important and parties' emphasis on these issues, as well as their competence in dealing with them. This would pave the way for further theoretical models which were united by their assumption of party competition being defined by parties' attempts to emphasise issues which would be electorally beneficial to them.

Following the logic of issue competition, political parties can be considered democratically responsive to their voters when they emphasise issues that are currently perceived as important by their electorate. Numerous studies

have also empirically demonstrated this link and found that parties listen to the issue concerns of citizens and emphasise issues prioritised by their voters both in their manifestos (Spoon and Klüver, 2014) and in their press releases (Klüver and Sagarzazu, 2016). However, scholars do not expect parties to be completely unconstrained in this endeavour. One important aspect of issue competition is that some issues are more electorally beneficial to certain parties than others. Voters perceive parties as competent in dealing with certain issues, based on the parties' reputations and historical legacies. Consequently, parties are considered by voters to 'own' certain issues. In turn, this issue ownership affects parties' behaviour and degree of responsiveness. Parties are expected to place greater emphasis on their own issues in order to increase the salience of these issues, while they are expected to avoid issues their political rivals own (Budge and Farlie, 1983; Petrocik, 1996).

Similar to the spatial model, theories of issue competition have also received their fair share of criticism. Their critics point out that parties are not able to exclusively emphasise issues that are advantageous to them. Rather, scholars have demonstrated that parties are often forced to engage in a dialogue with other parties on issues which are not advantageous to them, or they have to respond to changes in salience due to external shocks, the media, or changes in public opinions - resulting in issue emphasis being a rather contagious process (Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2015, 2010). Moreover, scholars have also pointed out that - as with the spatial model - focusing on issue competition alone provides only half of the story. Meguid's (2005; 2008) work combines the two approaches to understanding how mainstream parties attempt to affect the issue ownership of niche parties by increasing or decreasing the salience of an issue while taking an accommodative or an adversarial position on it.

What have we learned so far about how political parties compete with one another and so represent voters? One the one hand, political parties can be considered to compete with one another by presenting different policy positions to voters. On the other hand, parties can be considered to compete for votes by emphasising issues which voters find important. This thesis will primarily focus on democratic responsiveness to protests in the form of issue attention -

meaning that parties are considered responsive to protests if they increase the emphasis on the issue the protesters are trying to raise the salience on. While focusing only on issue attention tells us little about actual position-taking - and the party might be taking either an adversarial or accommodative position on the issue in question - it provides an effective analytical tool for investigating if, how, and why parties should respond to protests. There are two reasons for this: First, through their collective, contentious, and public actions protesters are trying to expand the scope of the conflict - meaning that there is a heightened visibility, intensity and scope of conflict involving more actors than before (Schattschneider, 1960). Second, scholars have argued that parties' positions are much harder to change, as they reflect the parties' historical origins and public identity, and are central to the parties' ideological core. As a result, sudden and erratic changes in position are hard to reconcile with a party's past and lack credibility in the eyes of voters. By contrast, issue attention is more dynamic and often requires swift responses from parties if they are to keep up with changes in public mood (Green-Pedersen, 2019; Wagner, 2012). This reasoning explains why a researcher seeking to demonstrate party responsiveness to protests might first look for signs of increased issue attention, assuming that this will likely be followed by an increasing number of political actors joining in on the debate, and subsequent changes in parties' policy positions.

While this literature review of party research provides a crucial understanding of their roles, the reader might have noticed the absence of protests in the literature. The following sub-chapter will bridge this gap between protest and party research and review existing studies on the intersection between protests and parties.

## Research on protests and parties

The preceding literature review has defined the core characteristics of protests and parties, and discussed research which establishes that protests can have an agenda-setting effect on political elites, but that this effect is moderated by the protest's characteristics. Research on political parties has also been discussed, and it indicates that parties interact both with one another and with

public opinion. However, the two strands of research have remained mostly separate (McAdam and Tarrow, 2010; Piccio, 2016). Consequently, research on protests has paid limited attention to how the realities of electoral politics can also shape political elites' responsiveness to protests. Addressing this gap, scholars have shifted the focus to electoral dynamics and the political context of protests in an attempt to better understand their outcomes. Hutter, Kriesi and Lorenzini (2018) have identified four different strands of literature on the relationship between social movements and political parties. These are; i) the political opportunity approach; ii) the cleavage approach; iii) the contentious politics approach; and iv) the agenda-setting approach. While being primarily focused on social movements and not just specifically on protests, three of these approaches are considered relevant for the subject of the thesis and will be discussed in further detail below.

## The political opportunity approach

The political opportunity approach (also known as the political process approach) - which was first introduced into social movement research by Eisinger's (1973) study of inner-city riots in the US in the 60s - explicitly focuses on the broader political context in explaining the goals, strategies, and tactics of movements. Accordingly, political parties are primarily contextualised as the alliance or conflict structure in which movements find themselves (Hutter et al., 2018). With parties conceptualised as potential allies and part of the broader political context, the approach has emphasised the role of ideologically close parties and their government participation for movements' activities. With this in mind, researchers in the US context have included the presence of the Democratic party as an important ally (Gillion, 2012; Johnson et al., 2010; Johnson, 2008; Olzak and Soule, 2009) or district-level competition (King et al., 2007; Soule and Olzak, 2004) as control variable into their analysis of protests' influence on political agendas. In the multi-party systems of Europe, scholars have rather focused on the extent to which the number of political parties (Kitschelt, 1986) and/or the constellation of parties on the Left might determine the prevalence and success of protests in different political systems (Kriesi et al., 1995, 1992).

While the political opportunity approach has provided a plentiful source of inspiration for scholars of unconventional political participation, it has attracted considerable criticism (Meyer, 2004). First, the approach has been criticised for including too wide a range of factors as important aspects of social movements' environments - making the institutional context all encompassing. "Used to explain so much, it may ultimately explain nothing at all" (Gamson and Meyer, 1996, p. 275). Second, scholars also question the usefulness of the approach as it seeks to explain everything from emergence and mobilisation to final outcome (Goodwin and Jasper, 2003; Goldstone, 2004b). Third, while political parties are considered to be important by the political opportunity approach, they are only a part of the broader political context leaving little room for their agency.

### The contentious politics approach

Second, the contentious politics approach developed by McAdam and Tarrow (2010; 2013) hypothesises a link between social movements and elections which can shape both the dynamics of protest mobilisation and the outcomes of elections. These contentious interactions between protests and elections can occur when protests seek to influence electoral campaigning either through proactive or reactive electoral mobilisation, when they can join electoral coalitions or turn into parties, or when social movements internally polarise political parties. McAdam and Tarrow's call for more research exploring the link between social movements and electoral politics has resulted in scholars increasingly shifting the focus to how protests can affect electoral outcomes. For example, Bremer, Hutter and Kriesi (2020) have explored the effect of anti-austerity protests on economic voting and found that protests in times of heightened economic grievances can contribute to an electoral punishment of incumbent parties. Studies on the US context have shown how movement activists from the civil rights movements in the 1960s and the Christian Right since the 1970s have radicalised both the Democratic and the Republican party (Schlozman, 2015; McAdam and Kloos, 2014; Abramowitz, 2011). Similarly, Weisskircher, Hutter and Borbáth (2023) have shown how the anti-Hartz IV and PEGIDA protest mobilisations in Germany triggered internal strategic realignment for

the Left Party and the AfD, resulting in competitive advantages, opportunities to mobilise the protests' grievances and heightened public discourse around their issue.

The contentious politics approach offers a complex picture of the dynamics between protests and electoral politics. The existing studies adopting the approach indicate that despite the gap between the two research strands, a considerable overlap exists between the two in the real world. The findings of these studies underline the importance of studying protests and parties in relation with one another, as protests can affect electoral outcomes, while parties' responsiveness is helpful for drawing the public's attention to protests' claims.

### The agenda-setting approach

While the agenda-setting approach was discussed in the previous section, it is important to highlight that the majority of studies on the agenda-setting effect of protests have primarily analysed the issue attention of parliaments, governments or the US Congress as unitary actors - thus leaving little room for the incorporation of parties' electoral incentives to respond to protests and the electoral context. With few studies having disentangled the agenda-setting effect of protests, Hutter and Vliegenthart (2018) address this gap with their study of political parties' responsiveness to protest mobilisation in Western Europe. The study moves away from the parliament as a unitary actors and explores individual parties' responses. The authors find that in line with theories of issue competition, issue responsiveness in parliament is contagious. Moreover, while the ideological placement of parties had little effect on their willingness to raise parliamentary questions on the issue of the protesters, a party's opposition status did seem to correlate with responsiveness in the form of parliamentary questions. The study shows that individual party characteristics and party competition do, in fact, play a role in the extent to which protests achieve an agenda-setting effect.

Similarly, Berker's and Pollex's (2021) descriptive study of German parties' responsiveness to Fridays for Future protests in parliamentary debates and on social media underlines the importance of including aspects of party

competition in the analytical framework. Their study finds not only the Green party to be especially supportive of the movement, but the AfD to be particularly hostile towards it. In addition to these two studies, Wouters et al. (2019) explore which parties are more likely to respond with increased issue attention to pro-immigration protests in Belgium, and find that parties on the Left - who have both electoral and ideological incentives to respond - are, in fact, more likely to do so.

The findings of the studies which have adopted the agenda-setting approach and have individual parties as their dependent variable show how important it is to include a broader set of parties' electoral incentives than the political opportunity approach does, as parties' responsiveness to protests is affected by additional factors beyond the number of political parties in a system and a party's governmental status. Furthermore, by using a well defined outcome - agenda change - these studies shift the focus from explaining mobilisation to explaining outcomes. Finally, by focusing on the political agenda, studies adopting this approach allow for a strong link to existing research on issue competition. The theoretical and empirical merits the agenda-setting approach offers are also the reason this thesis will adopt it to study parties' responsiveness to protests.

## What have we learned?

Scholars of protests and social movements are paying increased attention to the interaction between political parties and protest movements. While the political opportunity approach considers parties as part of the broader political context, only few studies have made them the dependent variable (Piccio, 2016). Those which have done so (Hutter and Vliegenthart, 2018; Berker and Pollex, 2021), have showcased the importance of incorporating theoretical insights from party research in order to gain a better understanding of when and why parties respond to protest mobilisation. Moreover, while the contentious politics approach suggests a complicated interaction between protest mobilisation and electoral outcomes, studies investigating this link show that protest mobilisation can, in turn, have an effect on the electoral prospects of parties. The existing findings underline the importance of exploring party protest interaction in more depth

to enhance our understanding of protests' role in the political process and the behaviour of political parties.

However, having reviewed the existing research on party competition and parties' behaviour, one might also note that many aspects of parties have been only partially addressed by scholars of protests. Further aspects of party competition and parties' behaviour thus require further study in order to fully understand their responsiveness to street protests. The following sub-chapter will outline the gaps this thesis has identified in the literature on protests, political party responsiveness, and the intersection of both.

## New political actors and and changing political landscape

The first gap identified in existing literature on the intersection between political protests and parties is its limited consideration of political parties' interconnectedness. The literature on political parties indicates that political parties adjust policy positions (Adams and Somer-Topcu, 2009) and issue attention based on the actions of their political opponents (Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2015). The interconnected nature of parties has been especially important for research on new political parties such as the populist radical Right and the environmental parties - who have been found to affect existing parties' agendas. Several authors have detected a contagious effect of immigration policies of the populist radical Right (Abou-Chadi, 2016; Abou-Chadi and Krause, 2018; Van Spanje, 2010). While some studies show that this does not hold to the same extent when it comes to green parties due to their strong issue ownership (Abou-Chadi, 2016), other authors find that the effect of green parties on other parties' policy positions depends on the electoral threat they pose and the extent to which the political and economic context reinforces the environmental issue (Spoon et al., 2014).

Existing research on political parties shows that while parties are responsive to public opinion, they are also interconnected. Although scholars of social movements have often highlighted the importance of political parties

in the form of institutional allies for the success of protest mobilisation - albeit with mixed empirical evidence (Almeida and Stearns, 1998; Giugni, 2004; Olzak et al., 2016; Valiente, 2007; Olzak and Uhrig, 2001; Soule and Olzak, 2004) - they have rarely considered how the emergence of new institutional allies might affect other established parties' responsiveness towards protests. Addressing this gap, Chapter 4 explores whether political parties are responsive in their parliamentary agenda towards radical-right protests and environmental protests in Germany from 1975 to 2019. Moreover, building on findings from party research, the chapter investigates whether the parliamentary entrance of the Green Party and the populist radical right party, AfD, as institutional allies to the protests affected the responsiveness of other parties to the protests.

## Democratic responsiveness of parties

The second gap in the literature addressed by this thesis is the absence of factors beyond parties' opposition status and their ideological placement in explanations of why parties can be expected to be more or less responsive to protests. However, research on political parties' responsiveness to public opinion has identified numerous other factors which drive variation in political elites' responsiveness. Drawing on insights from this strand of research, this thesis incorporates new factors in order to explain parties' responsiveness to protests. As the majority of studies on political elites' responsiveness has been focused on public opinion in the form of opinion polls (Klüver and Spoon, 2014; Hobolt and Klemmensen, 2008; Bonafont and Palau, 2011; Jennings and John, 2009) and referendums (Giger et al., 2020), protests as a public opinion signal have been broadly ignored. Consequently, we know very little about how and if these factors apply to parties' responsiveness to protest mobilisation.

Research on parties' responsiveness has underlined the importance of party characteristics and the electoral context. Party size (Abou-Chadi and Orlowski, 2016; Klüver and Spoon, 2014) and type - i.e. mainstream party or niche party (Adams et al., 2006; Ezrow et al., 2010; Meyer and Wagner, 2013) - have accounted for some of the variations in party responsiveness. Similar to findings on parties' responsiveness to street mobilisation, party researchers

have found some empirical support for opposition parties being more responsive to public opinion in comparison to governmental parties (Klüver and Spoon, 2014).

Moving beyond individual party characteristics, a plethora of studies have focused on parties' electoral context and electoral pressure. While scholars agree that the institutional context plays a crucial role in shaping both parties' and individual representatives' responsiveness (Immergut and Abou-Chadi, 2014; Spoon and Klüver, 2014; Hobolt and Klemmensen, 2008; Wlezien and Soroka, 2012; Bevan and Jennings, 2014; Bonafont and Palau, 2011; André et al., 2015), empirical evidence for the effect of narrow electoral margins are mixed (Kuklinski, 1977; Giger et al., 2020; Brunell and Buchler, 2009; Griffin, 2006; Gay, 2007). Outside of the US context and its single-member district voting system, scholars have rather analysed the effect of electoral loss and volatility as an indicator of electoral pressure. While dependent on the length of time between elections, Somer-Topcu (2009), found that parties shift their positions if they lost votes in the last election. Similarly, Dassonneville (2018) found that high electoral volatility and voter de-alignment increased European parties' responsiveness towards the mean voter. In addition to electoral pressure in the form of volatility and high competition, the effect of the electoral cycle has received some empirical attention with scholars finding some support for parties being more responsive closer to elections in the European context (Spoon and Klüver, 2014), while failing to do so in the US context (Giger et al., 2020).

Addressing this gap between research on the outcome of political protests and that on parties' democratic responsiveness, Chapter 5 analyses parties' responsiveness to the Fridays for Future protest movement in Germany on the regional level. Drawing on insights from research on democratic responsiveness, the chapter not only tests the moderating effect of factors which have been identified by prior protest scholars such as opposition status, but also explores how parties' electoral vulnerability and the temporal proximity to elections moderates the agenda-setting effect of these protests. In so doing, the chapter provides crucial insights for protest research and enhances our understanding of parties'

responsiveness to public opinion.

## Actors and mobilisation on the Right

The third gap in the literature on protests' outcomes identified by this thesis concerns coverage of protests and actors on the Right. The political landscape of Europe is changing. While unimaginable in the first decade following the Second World War, far-right and populist radical right parties are now an ingrained part of today's politics - may it be through their parliamentary success, their participation in governments (or even leading the government like currently in Italy and Hungary), and voters' increasing acceptance of them as legitimate political actors (Valentim, 2021).

Scholars of protests and social movements are catching up with the growing importance of far-right actors and expanding their analysis to encompass both institutionalised and non-institutionalised actors on the Right. Studies which have explored the phenomenon of right-wing mobilisation have shown that existing theoretical determinants of social movements also apply to mobilisation on the Right (Castelli Gattinara et al., 2022) and illustrated a fluidity and connection between street mobilisation and institutionalised actors (Caiani, 2019; Gattinara and Pirro, 2019; Hellmeier and Vüllers, 2023). Moreover, scholars have found that neither mobilisation nor responsiveness towards street mobilisation is limited to the Left. Berker and Pollex (2021) exploration of German parties' response to the Fridays for Future movement showed that both the Green Party and the populist radical right party - AfD - reacted to the movement, albeit differently. Heinze and Weisskircher's (2022) study of pariah protest in Germany illustrated that all parties in the German parliament felt compelled to respond in some way to the protests. More importantly, their study shows that research on new political parties provides an important framework for understanding the interaction between parties and protests, and illustrates the increasing importance of far-right actors for protest and movement studies. For these reasons, this thesis will include political actors both on the Right and the Left. Chapter 4 - which explores the effect of institutional allies on the agenda-setting power of protests in Germany - includes both radical-right

protests and environmental protests, exploring the potential differences these protests might have on parties' parliamentary agendas. Moreover, in contrast to many of the prior studies on political outcomes of protests, Chapter 4 and Chapter 5 explore the responsiveness of parties across the political spectrum. In so doing, the thesis not only contributes to the growing literature on far-right actors in the street and their role in today's democracies, but also allows for a more all-encompassing approach which is crucial when exploring the effect of electoral competition on parties' responsiveness to protests.

## The electoral consequences of protests

The forth gap in the existing literature on the intersection between protests and electoral politics identified by this thesis is the lack of research on the electoral impact of political elites' responsiveness to protests. Specifically, the thesis seeks to establish whether responding to protests makes parties more or less attractive to voters, thus influencing electoral outcomes. A growing number of scholars have started to explore the potential effect of protests on individuals' political behaviour and attitudes. Existing studies have found protest mobilisation to have a long-term effect on individual-level political and social attitudes (Mazumder, 2018) and linked protest mobilisation to an increased vote-share for certain political parties using macro-level data (Madestam et al., 2013; Gillion and Soule, 2018; Wasow, 2020; Valentim, 2023). Beyond being primarily located within the US context and in a two-party system - apart from Bremer et al.'s 2020 study on economic voting and protest mobilisation during the economic crisis in Europe - the existing studies linking protests to electoral outcomes do not provide the full picture of how protest mobilisation can affect voting behaviour, as they focus solely on how the presence of a protest changes the electoral prospect's of a given party - without considering the nature of that party's response to the protest. Existing research on protests' electoral impact thus leaves out the extensive body of work on political responsiveness to protest mobilisation in its analysis.

As was illustrated earlier in this chapter, numerous studies find that political representatives are responsive to protests' demands. Most of the liter-

ature on the political consequences of protests shares an underlying assumption that representatives' responsiveness to protests is driven by some electoral considerations. Protests are thought to pose an electoral threat, and political elites respond to protest mobilisation out of fear of electoral repercussion or in the hope of electoral gains (Lohmann, 1993; Burstein and Linton, 2002; Uba, 2009; Luders, 2006). Although studies on electoral outcomes and protest mobilisation hypothesise a link between between responsiveness to protests and voting behaviour, this has yet to receive any empirical scrutiny. Consequently, we do not know whether a party's responsiveness to protest mobilisation might counter the effect of protests on voters. To address this gap, Chapter 6 explores whether parties' responsiveness to protest mobilisation truly has any electoral consequences by conducting an experimental survey in Germany.

## Methodological challenges of measuring protest outcomes

Finally, this thesis contributes to the literature on parties' responsiveness to protests by using cutting-edge, innovative methodological approaches to assess the causal effect of protests on parties' agendas. Literature on the political consequences of protests and social movements may be extensive, but many existing studies face numerous methodological difficulties in causally estimating the true effect of protests. First, due to data constraints, many earlier studies are limited to small-N studies, descriptive analysis, or qualitative analysis of single movements and single issues (Amenta, 2014; Amenta et al., 2010; Bosi et al., 2016; Giugni et al., 1999; Uba, 2009). The lack of comparative nature of these studies has questioned the generalisability of the results - a problem aggravated by the fact that the majority of these studies were conducted n in the US (Walgrave and Vliegenthart, 2012). Moreover, the small-N studies and single movement analyses face serious sampling bias, as they often select the largest, best-known movements (Amenta et al., 2010).

However, with ever-increasing data availability and scholars' impressive efforts to collect data on protest mobilisation and political outcomes (See

e.g. Kriesi et al., 2020; Hutter et al., 2023; Erfort et al., 2023), comparative, quantitative studies are growing in number. While many of them rely on a simple multivariate regression - with all the potential problems of simultaneity and auto-regression - agenda-setting approach scholars have used time-series methodology with close temporal connections in an attempt to address some of these problems (Walgrave and Vliegenthart, 2012). Additionally, the agenda-setting approach allows for a standardisation of both the independent variable and the outcome. This acknowledges the criticism directed at earlier studies which often had a wide array of potential outcomes defined as success and thus suffered from loosely defined causal mechanisms in explaining the relationship between mobilisation and outcomes (Giugni et al., 1999).

The methodological advances heralded by the agenda-setting framework have been consolidated by scholars introducing more fine-grained, disaggregated spatial analysis (Gause, 2022; Gillion, 2012, 2020); innovative methodological approaches which overcome the potential omitted-variable bias and stringent assumptions of standard regression analysis (see e.g. Madestam et al. (2013) use of instrumental variable approach); and extensive data collection of potential outcomes from social media platforms where political elites are able to express their views more freely than they might in parliament (Schürmann, 2023; Berker and Pollex, 2021; Wouters et al., 2022).

This thesis joins a growing field within protest research which uses extensive, fine-grained data sets combined with an innovative methodological approach to estimate the causal effect of protests on parties' parliamentary agendas. All three empirical chapters showcase extensive data collection providing new, fine-grained data. Chapter 4 combines newspaper data on protests from 1975 to 2019 (Hutter et al., 2023; Rucht and Teune, 2010) with automatically collected data which was coded via supervised machine learning, resulting in the classification of over 26,0000 parliamentary questions in Germany. Chapter 5 combines three new different data sources: data on regional party press releases (Kittel and Wegemann, 2023) and coded into issues using BERT classifier (Erfort et al., 2023); geocoded data on Fridays for Future protests (Valentim, 2023); and data on electoral outcomes and government composition on the local

level collected via web scraping methods. Finally, Chapter 6 explores the causal effect of parties' responsiveness to protests on voters' propensity to vote for the party, using a survey experiment with 2500 respondents in Germany. Drawing inspiration from the latest methodological developments in political science, the thesis implements a regression discontinuity in time design (Hausman and Rapson, 2018)(Chapter 4), a mixture of matching and difference-in-difference approaches (Imai et al., 2023) (Chapter 5), and an experiment (Chapter 6) to causally estimate the relationship between protests, parties' political agendas, and electoral outcomes.

## Summary of the literature overview

This chapter reviewed the existing research on political protests, parties and the intersection between the two. In so doing, the chapter identified five gaps in the literature, and outlined this thesis' contribution to our understanding of parties' responsiveness to protests. Furthermore, the chapter provided a definition of protests and parties, and an overview of their core characteristics and roles. The next chapter will combine the insights gained while drawing on theories of parties' democratic responsiveness to create a theoretical framework for understanding the protest-party relationship and provide a conceptual foundation for the subsequent empirical chapters.

# Chapter 3

# Why should parties respond to protests?

Having reviewed the existing research and defined the characteristics and functions of protests and parties, this chapter will outline the theoretical links between the two and argue why political parties can be expected to be responsive to protests. The theoretical assumption underpinning most scholarship on the political consequences of party responsiveness is that it is rooted in electoral considerations (See e.g. Lohmann, 1993; Burstein and Linton, 2002; Uba, 2009; Luders, 2006). This chapter outlines how protests - as a public opinion signal - can be expected to interfere with parties' goals and electoral strategies. This chapter seeks insights from theories of democratic responsiveness, anticipatory representation and combines it with the agenda-setting approach. First, the chapter links protests directly to parties' vote-seeking incentives and argues that protests can influence these in numerous ways. Second, the chapter argues that parties' might have policy-seeking incentives to respond to protests. This theoretical argumentation provides the framework behind the agenda-setting hypothesis which is tested in Chapter 4 and Chapter 5. Having outlined the general argument for why parties might be expected to respond to protests, the mechanism through which parties are informed of protests is discussed. Finally,

the second half of the chapter moves beyond the general agenda-setting effect of protests to give a brief overview of additional factors which can be expected to influence parties' electoral incentives to respond to protests. Drawn from theories of issue competition and democratic responsiveness, the factors provide a more nuanced approach to understanding how parties' responsiveness can be expected to depend on the party landscape (Chapter 4), protests' characteristics (Chapter 4) and vary between parties (Chapter 5).

## Why protests should matter for parties

Why can we expect political parties to be responsive to protests? With political protests being collective, contentious, public, and political, they can be understood as a signal of public opinion. They draw the attention of policy-makers and other citizens to issues which have not been sufficiently addressed by politicians, or to emerging issues deserving of attention. Politicians might be expected to take these signals of public opinion very seriously for a number of reasons. First, political protests are a costly form of political participation. They are time and resource-intensive, require substantial coordination and can be plagued by free-rider problems like other forms of collective efforts (Lohmann, 1993; Olson, 1971). Taking to the street is therefore considered a strong signal of commitment to a certain issue. Second, protests are contentious: Citizens take to the streets because their issues have not been sufficiently addressed through institutional means like voting (Kitschelt, 1993). There could be many reasons for this - the composition of the government may not mirror the specific vote choice of the protesters, campaign promises might have been broken, or the electoral cycle might preclude the dynamic responsiveness the issue requires. Whatever the reason: Protests provide a signal to political parties beyond the information provided by electoral outcomes. Third, protests' single-issue focus, public nature and size allow them to present unambiguous and clear information on public attitudes towards an issue (Vliegenthart et al., 2016; Wouters and Walgrave, 2017). Understanding political protests as a strong and clear signal of public opinion underlines their potential value to political parties. In a world brimming with signals, inputs, and information for politicians, uncertainty and

ambiguity are everywhere (Jones and Baumgartner, 2005). But unlike many other signals, protests can communicate unequivocal information on an issue and its position and prominence in the public discourse.

As political parties are assumed to be rational, strategic, and goal-oriented actors, they can be expected to first process the signal of public opinion provided by the protests in order to assess whether responding might be beneficial and ignoring detrimental. In the words of Stimson, "politicians are keen to pick up the faintest signals in their political environment. Like antelope in an open field, they cock their ears and focus their full attention on the slightest sign of danger" (Stimson et al., 1995, p. 559). It should however be noted that this responsiveness applies to the whole electoral cycle in accordance with theories of retrospective voting and anticipatory representation. While elections deliver representation by allowing voters to vote for parties based on their electoral promises, the chain of representation does not stop there. Rather, voters can be expected to hold politicians accountable for their past performance. In turn, political parties anticipate what citizens want in order to avoid being electorally punished in subsequent elections (Mansbridge, 2003; Andeweg and Thomassen, 2005; Stimson et al., 1995).

Through this anticipatory representation, responding to protests by addressing the issue of the protesters might be a beneficial vote-maximising strategy. The electoral potential of protests is two-fold.

First, protesters themselves might go to the ballot box. While protesters take to the streets because their grievances have not been properly addressed via institutional means, it does not make them any less likely to participate in 'conventional' politics. Scholars have argued that the boundaries between institutional and non-institutional politics are permeable and that unconventional political participation is not an exclusive form of participation, but should rather be considered complementary to electoral politics (Goldstone, 2004a). Protesters are often highly active in a whole range of conventional and unconventional politics, making them even more likely to vote than the general public (Goldstone, 2004a; Meyer and Tarrow, 1998) - a claim which has found some empirical support (Rosenstone and Hansen, 1993). Protesters' propensity to

vote is one reason why responding to their claims may have a vote-maximising effect (Kriesi, 2008).

Second, protests can be considered to have a dual signalling function. Their public nature not only allows protesters to communicate their grievances to policymakers, but also to the broader public - and an important goal of contentious politics is to persuade, inform, or mobilise other citizens (Lipsky, 1968; McAdam and Su, 2002; Della Porta and Diani, 2006). This, in turn, can mobilise support for the issue and add to the electoral pressure the protesters themselves represent. Political parties, anticipating what this pressure might mean for their electoral prospect in the next elections, might be expected to adapt to these changes in the public mood. By responding to protests and increasing the salience of the issues at stake, parties can try to cater both to protesters as voters, and the broader public which might be persuaded by the protesters.

In addition to protesters being potential voters or potentially persuading voters of the importance of their issue, some protests are directly staged in attempt to influence electoral outcomes. They might either do this in a pro-active or a re-active way. Protests which try to influence voters prior to elections can be understood as a proactive electoral mobilisation. This is when protesters either openly endorse certain parties or seek to heighten the salience of their issues and grievances during a campaign period (McAdam and Tarrow, 2010). A recent example of this is, for example, when Friday's for Future posed a global climate strike on the 26th of September 2021. Two days prior to the German parliamentary elections, protesters took to the streets criticising the shortsightedness of prior climate policies and the inadequacy of politicians to deal with climate change while highlighting the importance of the elections for the future of the environment (FFF, 2021). While the movement did not endorse a specific party, the message encouraged citizens to 'vote for the climate' which can be easily interpreted as an open support for the German the Green party.

In a similar fashion, protesters can also take to the streets in a reaction to electoral outcome or where protests actively try to mobilise against

certain parties. These protests engage in a re-active mobilisation, focusing their criticism on political actors with whose political agenda the protesters don't agree (Amenta et al., 2010; McAdam and Tarrow, 2010). A recent example of this is the 'Last Generation' campaign - an environmental movement that has gained global attraction for its radical protest form. Recently, the activists smeared oil over the entrance of the Liberal Party's (FDP) headquarters in Berlin to protest against the party's car-friendly and environmentally harmful policies (K., 2023). This potential of protesters taking to the streets if they do not agree with parties' policies or if they find that the parties are not responsive towards their demands underlines the potential blackmailing potential protests can have. Non-responsiveness can thus be a risky strategy for parties, as it might ultimately encourage protests against them. Moreover, non-responsiveness towards protests can provide political opponents with ammunition (Sulkin, 2005). This is especially the case with opposition parties, which might side with the protesters and openly criticise governmental parties' policies and non-responsiveness towards the mobilisation.

Finally, parties might also have policy-seeking incentives to respond to protests. If parties agree ideologically with the protesters, the protests not only provide legitimacy to the policy aims of the party by showing public support for the issue but also increase the public salience of an issue the party already deems important - which can, in turn, be electorally beneficial to the party. This would result in the party and the protests mobilising simultaneously in the two different channels of participation - the institutional and the non-institutional channel - sharing the same goal.

## How are parties informed about protest mobilisation?

It is worth outlining through which mechanisms political parties learn of protest mobilisation. Most scholars agree that for the broader public and decision-makers to receive the signal from protests, the protests need to be covered by the media. The media serves a crucial gate-keeping role and scholars have argued

that media mediates the encounters and interactions between decision-makers, the public and protests, as it creates "discursive opportunities" for protesters (Koopmans, 2004). Media coverage of protests brings them to the attention of public and disseminates their message (Gamson and Wolfsfeld, 1993). In turn, politicians' primary source of information on protest mobilisation is expected to be through the media. Politicians are expected to be well informed and have an array of staff to keep themselves up to date with what is happening in the world. While other mechanisms of information flow are certainly not to be completely excluded - such as the protests taking place near government buildings or parties' headquarters or protesters flooding social media with hashtags and posts - scholars have stressed that if no effect can be established by media-covered protests on political parties, even less chance exists of unravelling an unmediated agenda-setting effect of protests which have not been covered by the media (Hutter and Vliegenthart, 2018). Consequently, the thesis primarily focuses on news-mediated protests or assumes that protests mainly reach political parties via media coverage.

## Scrutinising the link between political parties and protests

The theoretical argument embeds protests into the electoral considerations of parties and delineates the general relationship between protests and parties. The theoretical chapter has so far concluded that political parties have electoral incentives to be responsive towards public opinion signals like protests and they are expected to respond by increasing the attention they pay to the protests' issue. However, the chapter does not account for a variation between political parties' incentives to respond based on the parties' profile or the protests' characteristics. Moreover, the chapter does not consider a scenario where party responsiveness to protests might involve electoral risk or have a detrimental effect on the parties' prospects. Rather, the theoretical chapter only outlines why protests could have an agenda-setting effect on parties. This sub-chapter provides a brief overview of the conditions and factors which are expected to make parties more or less responsive to protests. The theoretical argument of each

factor will subsequently be laid out in more detail in the empirical chapters.

Chapter 4 studies how political parties' incentives to respond to protests are affected by the entrance of a new political party which is ideologically close to the protests. New political parties not only bring new issues into the political arena, but their parliamentary entrance intensifies the competition of other parties for votes. Established political parties can engage in a competition with the new contender and seek to attract voters with their policy position on the issue (Downs, 1957), their capability in dealing with the issue, or the importance they place on the issue (Budge and Farlie, 1983; Petrocik, 1996; Meguid, 2008). However, that strategy might fail, and parties can risk strengthening the new party by raising the issue salience of an issue which is not electorally beneficial for them. Consequently, political parties might rather ignore the issue of new political parties and seek to keep it off the political agenda (Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2015, 2010; Meguid, 2008). If the entrance of a new political party affects the issue attention and policy position of established parties, the entrance of a new party which is ideologically close to the protest - also known as an institutional ally - can also be expected to affect parties' strategic calculations when it comes to protest mobilisation. Consequently, political parties might be more or less motivated to respond to a protest mobilisation once a new political party - who would benefit from the protests' issue - enters parliament. Chapter 4 studies if this effect is positive - with other established parties responding more to protests after the parliamentary entrance of an institutional ally - or if the effect is negative - with parties responding less to protests out of issue avoidance.

Beyond changes in the political landscape, individual parties' calculation on whether to respond to protests is likely to vary considerably. Chapter 5 studies the extent to which party responsiveness depends on parties' opposition status, their electoral vulnerability, and the temporal proximity to the next elections. All of these conditions are expected to make parties more responsive to protests, with opposition parties and parties who experienced vote losses in recent elections being expected to having a higher electoral incentives to respond to protests. Furthermore, all parties are expected to be more responsive

to protests when elections are close.

Drawing on theories from protest research, some protests' characteristics affect public support and identification with the protesters. Charles Tilly (See literature overview and operationalisation in Wouters and Walgrave, 2017; Wouters, 2019), for example, theorised that protests' success depends on their worthiness (i.e. credibility), unity, numbers and commitment. This idea of worthiness and the use of violence is expected to reduce parties' incentives to respond to protests by raising the protests' issues. Furthermore, parties can even be expected to denounce protests based on their tactics and ideology. These unintended consequences of protests is studied in relation with radical-right protests in Chapter 4.

## Parties' responsiveness and voting behaviour

The theoretical assumption outlined in this chapter is that parties' responsiveness is primarily rooted in their electoral considerations. Following this logic, voters should either punish or reward politicians for their responsiveness to protests. While Chapter 4 and Chapter 5 study how parties' incentives to respond to protests might vary, Chapter 6 investigates whether responsiveness of parties to protests truly affects voters. Chapter 6 thus shifts the focus of political parties as the outcome variable onto voters. For this reason, the theoretical assumption of Chapter 6 will not be illustrated in the summarising graph of the theoretical argument, but will be elaborated on further in the chapter itself.

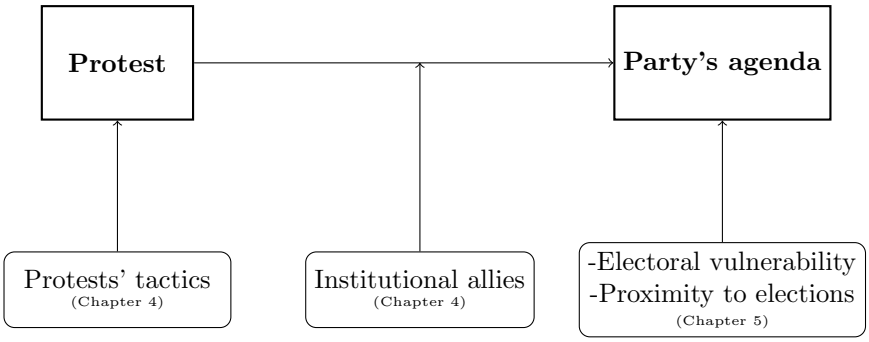
## Summary of the theoretical argument

To briefly summarise, political parties are assumed to be rational, goal-oriented actors who are democratically responsive to changes in public opinion due to the possible repercussions of non-responsiveness in the next elections. This means that parties are expected to be responsive during the whole electoral cycle and not just around elections. Political protests are considered to be a specific signal of public opinion that indicates the importance of an issue to lawmakers. Moreover, with political parties being the central channel of representation and

decision-makers in modern democracies, their attention to protests is crucial for the protests' cause.

Political parties can have electoral and ideological incentives to respond to protest mobilisation. However, the incentive to respond to protests will depend on numerous factors and to what extent protests constitute a threat or potential gain for parties. While responsiveness to protests can appeal to the protesters as voters and sympathisers of the protests, non-responsiveness can also entail electoral repercussions, as protests can both mobilise voters against the parties or vote for other parties within the system, for example, for their institutional allies. Numerous party characteristics and the characteristics of the issue raised by the protests are expected to influence parties' ability and willingness to engage with the protests' grievance. The graph below summarises the theoretical argument visually and displays which factors will be analysed in the empirical chapters.

Overview of the theoretical assumptions



# Chapter 4

# Changing political landscape and new parties

The previous chapters defined political protests as a strong signal of public opinion, and established that political parties' central role in representative democracies is to link voters' demands and public opinion to political outcomes (Dalton and Wattenberg, 2002). The central theoretical assumption emerging from the literature review and theoretical framework is that parties are expected to respond to protests with increased attention to the protest issue - an effect known as agenda-setting. This chapter examines the influence of environmental and radical-right protests on parties' parliamentary agendas in Germany from 1975 to 2019. Beyond confirming the existence of agenda-setting, the chapter also seeks to explore the extent to which it is affected by the entrance of a protests' institutional ally, and assess whether some protests - specifically those organised by the radical Right - may inadvertently draw attention to issues unrelated to the protest's claims. The chapter will therefore answer three concrete questions: Does the share of parliamentary questions on protests' issues increase in the days following protests, suggesting the existence of an agenda-setting effect? Alternatively, do parties respond to radical-right protests with questions on other issues such as far-right violence, potentially as a result of

protests' common use of violence and anti-liberal ideology? And finally, how is party responsiveness to environmental and radical-right protests affected by the parliamentary entrance of the Green Party and the AfD?

In addition to studying the effect of a changing party landscape and protest characteristics on party responsiveness, the chapter introduces a methodological innovation to causally identify the effect of protest mobilisation on parties' parliamentary agendas. The analysis uses data on environmental and radial-right protests mentioned in the *Süddeutschen Zeitung* and over 26,000 parliamentary questions (*Kleine Anfragen*) which have been coded via supervised machine learning approach into three policy issues - environment, immigration, and far-right violence. This rich and fine-grained data was analysed using a regression discontinuity in time approach (RDiT) (Hausman and Rapson, 2018). The method assumes continuity in all other contextual factors which might affect the outcome. By using a narrow time frame and weekday fixed effects, the approach isolates the causal effect of protest on the parliamentary agenda of parties.

The empirical analysis reveals mixed findings for the responsiveness of political parties to environmental and radical-right protests. While environmental protests result in a very limited change in the parliamentary agenda of parties, radical-right protests do provoke a change in parties' parliamentary agendas. However, this effect is not an example of classic agenda-setting, with the protest's claim garnering attention. Rather, radical-right protests seem to have the unintended consequences of parties raising questions on far-right violence (rather than immigration for example) following radical-right protest events.

Moreover, the results do not provide a clear answer to the question of whether institutional allies help or harm the cause of their allies on the streets. Just as the entrance of the Green Party was followed by the cessations of responsiveness from other parties to environmental protests, the entrance of the AfD was also marked by other parties' not raising questions on far-right violence in response to radical-right protests - an effect which can be considered both positive and negative for the protests: the protests are not being criticised but they also receive no attention at all. Consequently, while the results provide empirical

evidence for a negative effect of institutional allies in the case of the Green Party, the same only partly applies to the entrance of the AfD.

The chapter contributes to a growing field bridging party research with research on protests and social movements. As well as applying an innovative methodological approach, the chapter explores new potential factors conditioning the relationship between protests and parties. The findings have important implications for our understanding of the political context of protests' consequences. Moreover, the findings of the chapter underline the need for scholars to investigate the unintended consequences of protest mobilisation in future studies.

The chapter proceeds as follows. First a theoretical section outlines the hypothesis of the chapter. The case selection and research design are then presented, followed by the results and discussion.

## Why do protests matter for parties?

To explore parties' responsiveness to environmental and radical-right protests, the chapter first investigates whether these protests have an agenda-setting effect on parties. To re-cap: The agenda-setting approach assumes that political protests send a signal to policymakers and other citizens about which issues have not been sufficiently addressed, who is to blame, and which new issues need to be addressed by lawmakers. Scholars also consider this signal particularly valuable for political elites, as protest mobilisation is a costly form of political participation and represents unambiguous and clear information on public opinion (Hutter et al., 2018; Lohmann, 1993; Vliegenthart et al., 2016; Wouters and Walgrave, 2017). Assuming political parties are rational, vote-seeking actors, they should respond to changing tides and clear signals on citizens' preferences by addressing the issue of the protesters. Following this theoretical assumption, the chapter tests the baseline hypothesis:

**Agenda-Setting Effect - HY1:** *Political parties respond to protest mobilisation by paying increased attention to the protests' issues in parliament.*

## The unintended consequences of protests

Protest mobilisation can often have unintended consequences (Suh, 2014; Giugni et al., 1999). While the theoretical framework of this thesis considers protests to be a signal of public opinion, their perceived legitimacy based on the claims, tactics and participants must also be taken into account. Charles Tilly (See literature overview and operationalisation in Wouters and Walgrave, 2017; Wouters, 2019), for example, theorises that protests' success depends on their worthiness (i.e. credibility), unity, numbers and commitment. Protests lacking worthiness and employing violent repertoires might end up setting a very different agenda than they intended - especially in the case of radical-right protests.

There are two reasons why parties' responses to radical-right protests might subvert the traditional agenda-setting effect. First, the radical Right has a high proportion of violent repertoires involving the burning of asylum seekers' homes and physical attacks on immigrants and ethnic minorities (Koopmans, 1996; Karapin, 2007). The data set used for this analysis included 422 protest events categorised as 'political violence' from the radical Right in comparison to 72 protest events on the environment.[1] Scholars have underlined how the use of violent tactics and threatening behaviour by protesters negatively affects public support for the protests' cause (Feinberg et al., 2020; Selvanathan and Lickel, 2019; Simpson et al., 2018).

Second, while radical-right protests are primarily focused on immigration as an issue, they are also opposed to liberal democracy more generally. The radical Right "accepts the essence of democracy, but opposes fundamental rights, rule of law, and separation of powers" (Mudde, 2019, p. 7). This positions the radical right in direct opposition to the aims of the new social movements - which often criticised the political establishment but strove for more pluralist and participatory democracy (Rucht, 2003). Moreover, the historical legacy of the Second World War has made far-right ideologies socially undesirable for many decades (Rydgren, 2005). Although the entrance of a populist radical right-wing party into parliament can serve as a legitimising factor for right-

[1] Events involving severe damage to property, scuffles, injuries, manslaughter and murder were categorised as political violence.

wing ideologies (Valentim, 2021), studies of political elites' responses to pariah street protests or anti-Islamic protests reveals that their reactions are primarily negative and exclusionary in nature (Allchorn, 2020; Heinze and Weisskircher, 2022).

For these two reasons, any increase in the salience of immigration actually achieved by radical-right protests could well be accompanied by additional unintended issues appearing on parties' agendas. Political parties can be expected to highlight the violent behaviour and the perceived threat right-wing protests pose to liberal democracies and minority groups. To explore this potential unintended effect of right-wing protests on the parliamentary agenda of parties, the empirical analysis will distinguish between parliamentary questions on immigration issues and questions on far-right violence and test the following hypothesis:

**Unintended consequences - HY1b:** *Political parties respond to radical-right protest mobilisation by paying increased attention to far-right violence in parliament.*

## Institutional allies – The positive effect

How can the parliamentary entrance of an institutional ally be expected to affect other parties' responsiveness to protest mobilisation? Institutional allies are defined as political actors who – in contrast to protests – are located within the institutional arena of politics, have an ideological affinity with the protests, and share a set of similar goals. This does not necessarily require the actors to coordinate their actions, but they may act simultaneously in different arenas (Rucht, 2004). Scholars of unconventional political participation have emphasised the importance of institutional allies for the success of protests. They have long argued that movements and protests are embedded in a web of relations and that their political and social consequences are highly dependent on those relationships (ibid.).

If institutional allies strive for the same goals and act simultaneously in a different arena than the protests, their entrance into parliament could be

beneficial for protests through two different mechanisms.[2]

First, the entrance of an institutional ally might encourage other parties to respond to protests. Political parties do not exist in a vacuum; their behaviour is influenced by the position, strength, and behaviour of other parties (Adams, 2012; Adams and Somer-Topcu, 2009; Green-Pedersen, 2019; Green-Pedersen and Mortensen, 2015) and cannot be reduced to a party-voter relationship. Once they are aware of a protest, political parties - as rational actors - will evaluate the potential benefit or the potential threat the protest poses. However, the entrance of an institutional ally into parliament might change this rational calculation. While political protests can raise the attention of an unaddressed issue and mobilise voters, they only pose an indirect threat to political parties, as they do not participate in elections or compete for votes. However, if political protest's agenda-setting power is coupled with institutional allies who have demonstrated their electoral viability by overcoming the electoral threshold and entering parliament - and for whom voters can be motivated to vote - the threat becomes more tangible for established parties. Consequently, this parties might be expected to increase their responsiveness to protests for fear of electoral repercussions and potential loss of votes, or in an attempt to co-opt the position of the institutional ally or preempt coalition options. On the other hand, parties wishing to compete with the institutional ally may also respond in order to signal their adversarial position on the issue and offer voters an alternative position.[3] Regardless of whether party responses are negative or positive, the presence of the institution ally increases issue salience and thus amplifies the agenda-setting power of the protest.

The second mechanism by which institutional allies might support protests' agenda-setting effect relates to their issue ownership. For the institutional allies

[2]While the founding of a party already poses a threat to other existing parties in some cases, it is assumed that entering parliament - which requires new parties to overcome a 5 per cent electoral threshold in Germany - signals a much more tangible threat to parties than just the founding of a new party which may never overcome the electoral threshold.

[3]Partly applying Meguid (2008, 2005) theoretical framework on mainstream parties' strategies for niche parties in this context of the joint effect of institutional allies and political protests.

analysed in this chapter – a populist radical right party and an environmental party – their single-issue focus is their raison d'être. They are issue entrepreneurs who bring new issues onto the political agenda which have not been previously addressed by the established parties (De Vries and Hobolt, 2020). For institutional allies, responding to protests therefore brings policy-seeking and vote-seeking benefits, while the existence of protests provides an important and vocal legitimacy to their cause outside of the legislative arena. Driven by protests, increasing issue salience benefits the institutional allies as the issue they are perceived to own is pushed to the top of the political agenda, potentially boosting their electoral prospects. Institutional allies might therefore be expected to respond more emphatically to protests compared with established parties. Scholars of the political consequences of protests have primarily focused on this second mechanism. However, due to the strong ideological and often organisational link between the protest movements and the institutional allies, the chapter will exclude the institutional allies' responsiveness from the analysis and shift the analytical focus to the allies' effect on other parties' responsiveness.

**The positive effect of institutional allies – HYP2a:** *Political parties are more responsive to protests following the entrance of an institutional ally into parliament.*

## Institutional allies – The negative effect

While institutional allies could be beneficial for protests' causes by raising the issue in parliament and forcing other parties to address it, they could also negatively impact other parties' responsiveness to protests. As institutional allies are usually clear issue owners of the topics raised by protests, they are also the most likely parties to benefit from increased attention on the issue. This might result in other parties opting for a different response to protest in the presence of an institutional ally: issue avoidance. From an issue competition theory perspective, parties are most likely to emphasise issues that are beneficial to them and avoid issues other parties are considered to own (Budge and Farlie, 1983; Petrocik, 1996). This is an especially important strategy regarding new issues

and a new challenger party (De Vries and Hobolt, 2020; Meguid, 2008). According to theories of issue avoidance, parties seek to downplay the importance of an inconvenient issue on which they lack ownership. The joint effect of salient political protests and an institutional ally thus represents a threat to political parties which they counter by ignoring the issue, rather than addressing it and risking strengthening the institutional ally. This potential negative effect of the presence of an institutional ally is especially important for the Green Party and environmental protests. Not only is the Green Party considered to be the clear issue owner of the environment issue – making it difficult for other parties to co-opt their position – but parties also struggle to take an adversarial position on the issue (Abou-Chadi, 2016). The environment is often regarded as the archetype of valence issue i.e., issues that are considered favourable goals in and of themselves, and are not dimensional (Stokes, 1963). Consequently, institutional allies cannot always be expected to help the cause of protests. Although institutional allies are expected to be hyper-responsive, this might do more harm than good if they mute all other parties' responsiveness. This theoretical consideration results in the final hypothesis:

**The negative effect of institutional allies – HYP2b:** *The responsiveness of political parties to protests is lower after the entrance of an institutional ally into parliament.*

# Research design

## Case selection

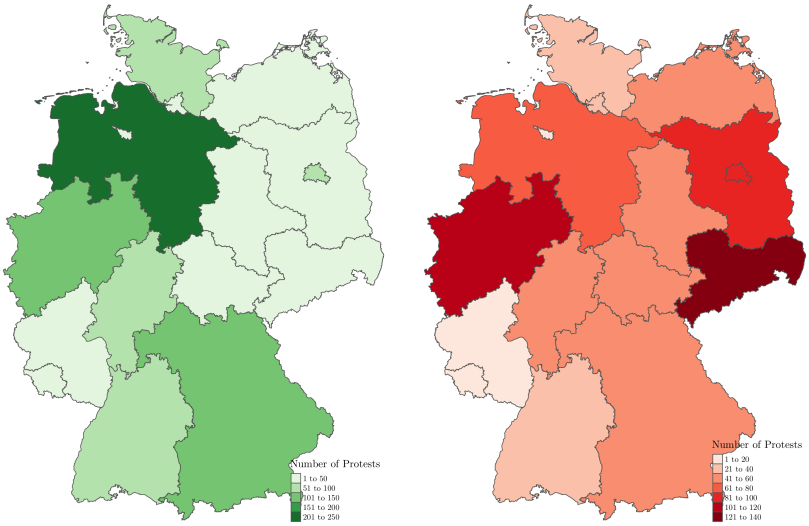
Environmental protests entered the scene in Germany in the early 1970s and reached new heights in the 1980s. The overall environmental movement is considered to have won over many supporters and carried out numerous large protests.[4] The environmental movement has undergone a substantial transition since its emergence in the 70s. Part of the transition involved institutionalisation and moderation of some of the more radical standpoints (Rucht and Roose, 1999). Despite partial institutionalisation, environmental movements still take

[4]Referring to general environmental and anti-nuclear mobilisation.

to the streets and environmental protests have remained an important element of protest mobilisation in Germany. Recently, environmental protests have gained new relevance with the emergence of Fridays for Future in 2018, a movement which has been particularly active in Germany (Wahlström et al., 2019).

Radical-right protest mobilisation in Germany has come in waves. The two largest waves have received the most scholarly attention. The first wave was defined through anti-foreigner violence and citizen initiatives opposed to immigration following the unification of West and East Germany in the 1990s and was especially strong in the Germany's new eastern states (Karapin, 2007). The second wave mobilised around the period of increased inflow of refugees in 2015 following the civil war in Syria. This wave of street demonstrations was initiated by the PEGIDA movement (Patriotic Europeans against the Islamisation of the Occident), a movement that originated in Dresden in the winter of 2014-2015. The movement staged multiple protests and attracted up to 25,000 demonstrators with a clear anti-immigration stance and saw growing support amidst the growing street mobilisation, far-right violence, and a heated political debate on immigration (Vorländer et al., 2018).

Figure 4.1: Distribution of protests across German states




(a) Environmental protests (b) Radical-Right protests

**Note:** *The figures display the distribution of environmental and radical-right protests across the 16 German states for the whole analytical period. Darker colours indicate a higher number of protests within the state.*

The emergence and success of the two institutional allies in this analysis - the Green Party and the populist radical right party AfD - are tightly connected with protest mobilisation (Weisskircher et al., 2023; Rootes, 2003) and emblematic of the change Western European democracies have undergone in the last few decades. Since the 1970s, Western European party systems have undergone radical restructuring driven by two waves of mobilisation around cultural issues. In the postwar period, party competition and voters' alignments followed a single-dimensional political cleavage primarily revolving around the question of economic redistribution and the welfare state. However, societal changes such as expanded educational provision, increased middle-class and a growth in liberal values have seen culture play an increasing role in political discourse. This cultural dimension was initially expressed through people taking to the streets as part of new social movements - protests demanding increased civil liberties and environmental protection. This first wave of cultural issues would herald the

onset of structural transformation of the European party system - exemplified through the parliamentary entrance of green parties in multiple Western European democracies. The second wave of cultural mobilisation is often seen as a counterrevolution to the first wave. Driven by social conflicts around the question of globalisation and the role of the nation-state, the second wave attracted conservative voters who were mobilised by newly emerging populist radical right parties (Bornschier, 2010; Kriesi et al., 2006).

The rise of the Green Party (die Grünen) in the 1980s, its internal ideological disputes, and its electoral struggles in the German elections of the 1990s fundamentally shaped research on the green phenomenon in Western Europe for years to come. The development of green parties development is linked to the emergence of the new social movements in the 1960s, and the parties share their post-materialist values and ecological critique of continuous growth. The German Green Party should thus be viewed in relation to the anti-nuclear movements and broader environmental protests. The Green's participation in electoral politics started on the local level in the late 1970s in West Germany and the official party was formed on the national level in 1980. Despite performing poorly in its first national elections, it continued to gain seats on the local and the federate state level. The party experienced its electoral breakthrough in 1983, but would almost lose its parliamentary presence in the 1990 elections after the reunification of Germany. The West- and the East Green parties did not merge before the elections, and while the West-German Green Party did not pass the 5 % electoral threshold, the East German party entered parliament with 1.2 % votes - due to a waiving of the 5 % threshold for the parties of Eastern Germany. Following the electoral loss in 1990, the two parties merged and underwent numerous organisational and strategic reforms. Against the will of the party's more fundamentalist and radical wing, the Greens developed a more pragmatic political position which established the party as a potential coalition partner for the SPD and the Christian Democrats (Burchell, 2002).

The Alternative for Germany (AfD) was founded in 2013 as a neo-liberal, anti-European Union party. Multiple far-right parties already existed in Germany (e.g. the Republikaner and the NPD), but the AfD was the first to over-

come the 5 % electoral threshold and enter the German Bundestag. Following a change of leadership and a shift to the Right in 2015 (Rosellini, 2019), the party achieved representation in multiple state parliaments and went on to win 12.6 % of the vote in the 2017 national elections. Since its founding in 2013, the AfD has been characterised by internal party conflict and ever-increasing right-wing and anti-establishment rhetoric.

The German Green Party and the AfD can be considered ideal examples of institutional allies. Both parties are especially strong issue owners on their respective issues, and both have deep ties to street mobilisation. However, the relationships between the parties and their respective protest movements are not the same. While the Green Party originates from the new social movements and often publicly embraces environmental activists' protests, this is not the case for the AfD. Prominent members of the party may have collaborated with PEGIDA and openly encouraged further mobilisation (Schwörer, 2019), but the AfD has not officially endorsed such movements. It has also distanced itself from far-right violence, despite sharing the fundamental goals and anti-immigration stance as the right-wing protests in Germany. This difference in the parties' official stances on street mobilisation needs to be considered when interpreting this chapter's results, as do the divergent tactics and publicly perceived legitimacy of environmental protests and far-right protests.

## Data

The chapter uses written parliamentary questions (*Kleine Anfragen*) as a measure political party responsiveness to protests. The parliamentary questions were retrieved directly from the website of the German parliament using the tidybundestag package in R (Guinaudeau, 2021) and were collected from 1975 to 2019.[5] The analytical period coincides broadly with the coverage of the Com-

[5]Instead of using the publishing date of the questions provided by the documentation system of the German parliament, the signature date of the question was used. The date from the parliament's archive often varies considerably from the date the questions were signed by the parliamentarians. While the publishing date and signed date lined up for over 42 per cent of the 29,576 questions, over 19 per cent had a delay within a week and the rest considerably longer.

parative Agenda Projects database for Germany (Breunig et al., 2021).

The approach of using parliamentary questions has numerous advantages. First, parliamentary questions capture the dynamic behaviour of parties over the whole electoral cycle. This is particularly useful for the analysis of protests, which occur sporadically and do not follow the schedule of elections.

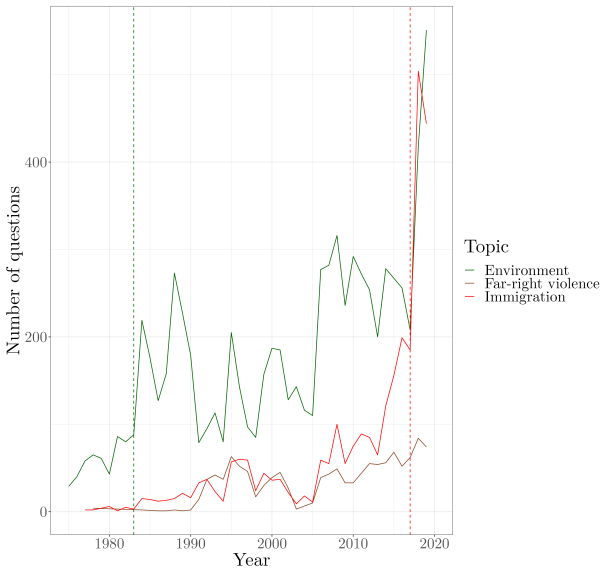
Second, parliamentary questions can be considered a 'symbolic' political agenda (Hutter et al., 2018). This means that while questions enable parties to highlight important issues, they do not have direct political consequences and can be considered 'cheap' (Walgrave and Van Aelst, 2006). Consequently, parliamentary questions can be regarded as the 'most likely case' for responsiveness and offer a useful first step in analysing the relationship between institutional allies, protests and parties' responsiveness.

Finally, parliamentary questions are especially valuable in exploring the dynamics of agenda-setting; they are quick and easy instruments to implement. Each MP can individually ask four written questions each month. If posed by a group, the written questions only require signatures from 5 % of the parliamentarians (Bundestag, 2011). This means that the questions do not require too much coordination, and parties are able to ask them relatively spontaneously. A survey of German MPs in 2003 showed that while the questions are seen as an important tool in gathering information from the government, 88 % of parliamentarians agreed that the questions were important instruments for attracting the media's attention to an issue and 57 % believed the questions displayed a support for non-parliamentary activities (Kepplinger, 2008). While it is clear that technically demanding questions and those requiring the expertise of numerous consultants and parliamentarians will take considerable time before they are signed, questions which could be considered a response to protest mobilisation can be expected to be quick and dynamic if the parties want to address the media attention the protests have gathered.

However, using parliamentary questions also entails some disadvantages. Parliamentary questions are often considered the instrument of the opposition. This pattern is reflected in the German parliament with the majority of ques-

tions being asked by opposition parties (Breunig and Schnatterer, 2019).[6] This means that responsiveness might be driven by opposition parties. However, this is not problematic for this chapter as the analytical focus is not on opposition-governmental dynamics.[7]

Figure 4.2: Parliamentary questions over time




**Note:** *The figure displays the distribution of written parliamentary questions on the environment, immigration, and far-right violence in absolute numbers across time. The dotted lines indicate the parliamentary entrance of the institutional allies.*

A supervised machine learning approach was used to classify the questions into relevant policy fields for the analysis. Responsiveness to protests was measured by looking at changes in the daily share of questions on the environment, immigration, and far-right violence. By using a mixture of dictionary coding, hand-coding, and existing coding from the Comparative Agenda Project (Bre-

[6] See table A.1 in the appendix for an overview of the number of questions asked by each party.

[7] Parliamentary questions have two temporal aspects which need to be considered: 1) The number of parliamentary questions varies drastically between weekdays and weekends (See table A.2 in the appendix).; 2) the questions might be affected by the parliamentary summer break (usually from mid-July to August). However, the aggregation of questions over months does not display a substantial decrease in questions over the summer (see figure A.2 in the appendix).

unig et al., 2021), a training data set of 3,049 questions was constructed.[8][9] The data set was constructed into a corpus using the Quanteda package in R (Benoit et al., 2018) and processed according to standard procedures for text data processing.[10] A support vector machine classifier was trained and performed very well - resulting in precision ranging from 0.72 to 0.97.[11] Finally, the trained classifier was used to categorise the rest of the questions, which resulted in 2,803 questions on immigration, integration, and border control, 1221 questions on far-right violence, and 7,938 questions on environmental issues.

The dependent variable for the analysis is the share of questions on each of the issues. Table 4.1 displays the summary statistics for the dependent variable, and figure 4.2 illustrates the total number of questions over time. Note that the summary statistics in table 4.1 report the daily share prior to dealing with overlapping events (see table 4.2 in next sub-chapter).

Table 4.1: Parliamentary questions – Summary statistics

| **Share of parl. questions** | **Mean** | **Median** | **Std. Dev** |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Environment* | 0.302 | 0.250 | 0.275 |
| *Immigration* | 0.108 | 0.0357 | 0.163 |
| *Far-right violence* | 0.0448 | 0.000 | 0.125 |

**Note:** *The table displays the summary statistics for the outcome variable - daily share of par. questions - for each analysis. The samples include all events.*

For the explanatory variable - i.e. the protest event - data from the Prodat project (Rucht and Teune, 2010) and the Protest-Monitoring data set from *Monitoringsystem und Transferplatform Radikalisierung* (MOTRA) project (Hutter et al., 2023) was used. Both projects adopt protest event analysis to systematically code newspaper reports from the *Süddeutschen Zeitung* on protest mo-

[8] See detailed description of procedure in the appendix.

[9] The Krippendorff's Alpha between the two coders classifying the questions was 0.716

[10] See corpus processing steps in the appendix.

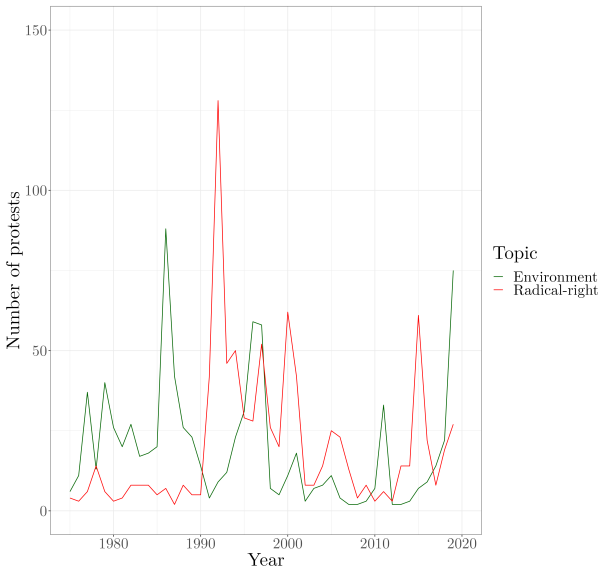
[11] See table A.5 in the appendix for the recall and precision for each class.

bilisation. Individual protest events are the unit of the coding.[12] The data distinguishes between separate protest events on a temporal, spatial, and form-of-action basis. This means that if a protest takes place over multiple days or on the same day in multiple cities around Germany, each event will be coded as a single event. Moreover, the form-of-action distinction means that a demonstration during which a small group of protesters engage in violence would be coded as two different events - one as a demonstration and one as a violent protest. The analysis includes protest events which were coded as demonstrative or confrontational. This includes demonstrations, public protest rallies, symbolic protests, and teach-ins as demonstrative protest events, whereas disturbances, hindrances and minor property damage are coded as confrontational. As this chapter seeks to focus on demonstrations with a reasonably high degree of public legitimacy, events involving political violence events such looting, scuffles, injuries and murder are excluding. However, for exploratory analysis, an additional variable was created to mark the days on which political violence events coincided with demonstrative or confrontational protest events.

Protests were coded as pro-environmental if they raised the issue of environmental protection or contested atomic energy. Protests were included as radical right in the analysis if they had been coded as nationalist, fascist/neo-fascist, having radical right/right-terrorist political orientation, involving the German National Party (NPD) or the far-right Republican Party as an actor. This resulted in 821 environmental protests and 917 radical right protests in total. While the media is expected to be the primary mediator of the protests' message, the date of the protests and not the publishing date of news articles was used for the analysis. This is because the analysis only uses one newspaper as a data source, and the possibility of parties learning of a protest earlier via other sources cannot be excluded.

[12]Protests are defined as being i) politically motivated actions which ii) go beyond routine actions; iii) are conducted by individuals and non-state actors; iv) take place in Germany or refer to Germany; v) have taken place or been announced; vi) are public (Grande et al., 2021).

Figure 4.3: Number of protests over time




**Note:** *The figure displays the distribution of environmental protests and radical-right protests in absolute numbers across time.*

## Estimation and identification strategy

When applying traditional regression analysis to estimate the consequences of protest mobilisation, scholars often face methodological problems such as endogeneity and omitted variable bias (Giugni et al., 1999). To address some of these potential problems, this chapter exploits the fine-grained panel structure of the data and the information on the exact timing of the protests and the signing of the questions, and uses a regression discontinuity in time design (RDiT) (Hausman and Rapson, 2018) which is an interrupted time-series approach. Regression discontinuity design (RDD) is considered a particularly promising empirical strategy to assess a treatment effect in the absence of randomised treatment assignment (Cattaneo et al., 2019).

A traditional RDD design usually exploits geographical boundaries or arbitrary rules in public policies or institutional settings to estimate the causal effect of the treatment in question. An example of a traditional RDD design is the

estimation of parliamentary entrance on some outcome of interest for parties. The so-called running variable (also known as the forcing variable) would be the vote share, whereas the cut-off would be the electoral threshold. Then the outcome for parties which just missed the threshold would be compared with parties which just passed the threshold - assuming that the parties do not differ in any other significant way (Cattaneo et al., 2019; Valentim et al., 2021).

Instead of using geographical boundaries or other cut-off points, RDiT uses an event as the cut-off and time as the running variable (Hausman and Rapson, 2018). In this case, days are the running variable and a protest event constitutes the cut-off, where the outcome in the days right before the protest is compared with the outcome in the days right after the protest assuming that the difference in the outcome is only explained by the protest event and nothing else. Consequently, the method assumes continuity in all other contextual factors which might affect the outcome. This allows for the isolation of the causal effect of protest on the parliamentary agenda of parties. Instead of using a single event like so many studies, this chapter uses over 800 environmental protests and over 900 radical-right protests to estimate the effect of these protests on parties' agendas.[13]

To facilitate analysis using RDiT, the protest data is constructed as a panel with the protest event as the main unit of analysis and the panel spanning from four weeks before to four weeks after the protest date. This means that for each event, the daily share of parliamentary questions on either environment, immigration or far-right violence - depending on the protests' issue - is measured in the month before and after the event. The regression discontinuity approach is then used to compare the average share of questions before and after protests. This means that the running variable – time $P_{i,t}$ ($i$ = the index of the protest, $t$ = the date) – marks the temporal distance from the protests, ranging from -30 to 30 and days are assigned into treatment if $P_{i,t}$ is >0. The construction of protest events as a panel results in 61 daily observations of the outcome variable – the share of parliamentary questions on the environment or on immigration

[13]The research design is inspired by Riaz et al. (Riaz et al., 2021), a study on the rise of hate crimes in Germany following crimes committed by immigrants which uses RDiT.

and far-right violence – for each protest event. The outcome variable $Y_{i,t}$ is a share of questions on these topics (three different dependent variables) of all questions asked that day. As the assignment into treatment is the result of a deterministic function of time, a sharp regression discontinuity is estimated with fitted local polynomials on each side of the cut-off point (i.e. the day of the protest) for the treatment. This results in an estimation of the local average treatment effect on the treated:

$$\tau = E[Y_{i,t}(1) - Y_{i,t}(0)|P_{i,t} = 0] \tag{4.1}$$

Constructing the days around protest events as panels for the analysis results in 29,524 observations - i.e. days - for environmental and 22,814 observations for radical-right protests. However, the effective sample size for each model is considerably smaller for three reasons. First, as the daily share of questions is the outcome of interest, days without any parliamentary questions are dropped from the analysis. Additional analysis re-runs the models with the outcome as a binary and count variable, where days without questions are marked with 0 (see appendix for this chapter for all additional model specifications). Second, as protests are often recurring events and come in waves, the study partly addresses the problem of overlapping events, i.e. events that occur within the control period of another event, by excluding events within a seven-day range.[14] Third, in RDD, the optimal length of the window, i.e. the amount of time around the cut-off, is selected to bias-variance and trade-off. This window, known as bandwidth, varies as a function of the sample size; while having a larger window, i.e. longer bandwidth, increases the sample size, it also includes observations far away from the cut-off as well as introducing bias by comparing observations which are temporally distant from one another and might differ substantially in other ways than being having just missed or passed the cut-off (Angrist and Pischke, 2015). The bandwidth length for each model is selected using a data-driven process. Consequently, the number of effective observations which fall within the bandwidth varies for each model. Table 4.2 reports the summary

[14]See the more detailed explanation in the appendix for information on how overlapping events were dealt with.

statistics for the dependent variables once excluding overlapping events.

Table 4.2: Dependent variable – Summary statistics

| **Dependent variable** | **Mean** | **Median** | **Std. Dev** |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Daily share of q. environment* | 0.288 | 0.00 | 0.38 |
| *Daily share of q. immigration* | 0.103 | 0.000 | 0.220 |
| *Daily share of q. far-right violence* | 0.0694 | 0.000 | 0.200 |

**Note:** *The table displays the summary statistics for the outcome variable - daily share of parliamentary questions - for each analysis. The samples exclude overlapping events.*

To test the hypotheses of this chapter, multiple separate models were estimated. First, to test the general agenda-setting effect of political protests, the whole analytical period was studied. Each dependent variable (daily share of questions on environment, immigration, and far-right violence) is analysed separately. The dependent variable always excludes the institutional allies' questions.[15]

To explore the effect of institutional allies on the responsiveness to protests and test hypotheses 2a and 2b, the analytical period was split up into subsamples – one period before the entrance of the Green Party and the AfD respectively, and one sample for the period after the parties' entrance. All the reported models have an MSE-optimal bandwidth, use a triangular kernel function and a local linear polynomial as suggested by Cattaneo et al. (2019), and include weekdays-fixed effects to account for clustering of protests on weekends and clustering of questions on weekdays. The reported estimates are robust bias-corrected standard errors.[16]

[15] Additional models including the institutional allies' questions can be found in the appendix.

[16] Please find additional methodological considerations in sub-section A.3 in the appendix for this chapter.

# Results

## Responsiveness to environmental protests

Table 4.3 presents the results from the regression discontinuity analysis for environmental protests. The first row displays the results for the whole period and includes the responsiveness of all parties except the Green Party. Contrary to the expectations of the agenda-setting hypothesis, the share of parliamentary questions on environmental issues does not significantly increase in the days following environmental protest events.

However, the analysis reveals that the parliamentary presence of the Green Party does coincide with a change in protests' effect on parliamentary questions. Before the Green Party entered the national parliament, the week following an environmental protest saw a 46 % increase in the share of questions on the environment. This effect becomes statistically insignificant for the period after the Green Party entered parliament.

Table 4.3: LATE for Environmental Protests

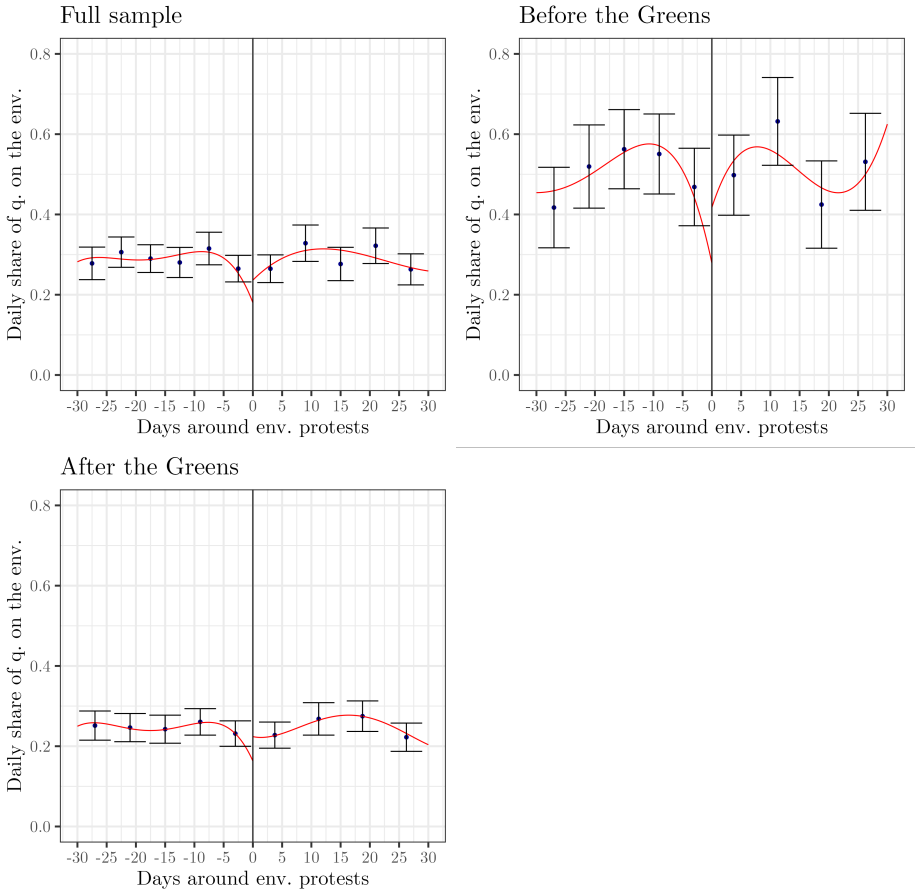
| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.102 | 0.071 | 8 | 1,152 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.127 | 0.116 | 10 | 1,311 | Quadratic | Full sample |
| 0.466∗ | 0.032 | 7 | 165 | Linear | Before Greens |
| 0.069 | 0.247 | 7 | 900 | Linear | After Greens |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily share of parliamentary questions on the environment as the outcome, excluding the Green Party's questions. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Figure 4.4 displays the RD-plots for the three different sample specifications

using the whole support of the data (30 days), while figure 4.5 displays the coefficients for each sample specification. As the visible change in the share of questions following environmental protests evident before the Green's entrance into parliament disappears after their entrance in 1983, there is no change in the questions on the environment for the whole period 1975 - 2019. For the period during which protests are seen to affect parliamentary questions, this effect is not instant. An increase in the share of questions can be seen about a week after the protests, but it then drops considerably. The plots also reveal that the share of parliamentary questions on the environment was generally higher in the period prior to the Green Party's entrance compared to the full sample and the period after the party's parliamentary breakthrough.

Figure 4.4: Regression discontinuity plots - Questions on the environment

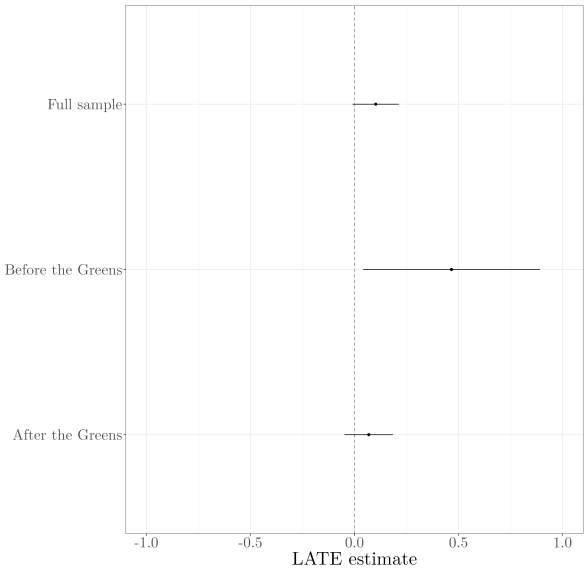



**Note:** *The figures display the daily share of parliamentary questions on the environment using the full support of the data (i.e. in the four-week period before and after the protest event), using day fixed-effects. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals. The bins represent local sample means, where each bin summarises between 4 and 6 days before the cut-off and 5 and 6 days after the protest event.*

The results do not provide wholesale support for the agenda-setting effect of protest on the parliamentary agenda of political parties. Rather, the responsiveness of parties is limited to the period prior to the Green Party's parliamentary entrance. While the Green Party's entrance was followed by a cessation in responsiveness to the protests on the part of other parties, the presence of an institutional ally which remains responsive to protests might still be helpful for their cause. However, if the Green Party's own questions are included in the

dependent variable then the results remain the same, indicating that protests may not even trigger a response from their institutional allies.[17]

Figure 4.5: LATE Plots Responsiveness to environmental protests - Sample differences

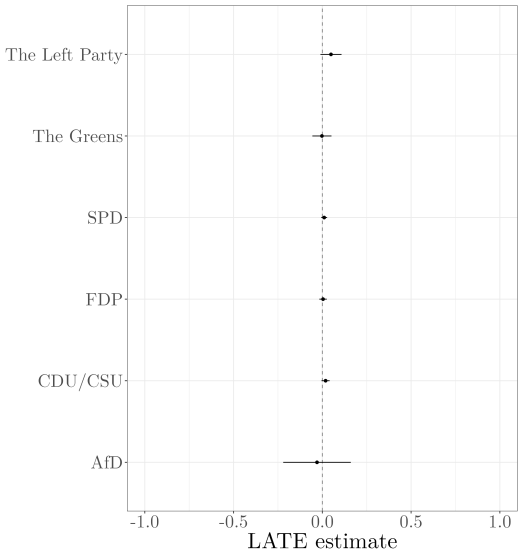



**Note:** *The figure shows the local average treatment effect on the treated estimated from the RDiT models. The outcome variable is the daily share of parliamentary question on the environment and displays the effect for the full sample and sub-samples. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.*

An examination of individual parties' responsiveness also suggests that the Green Party is not particularly responsive. Figure 4.6 shows the local average treatment effect of environmental protests for each party individually. Instead of the daily share of questions as the dependent variable, responsiveness is coded as a binary variable. i.e. if a party raised a question on the environment that day or not. The figure shows that compared to other parties, the Green Party is not more likely to raise a question about the environment following a protest. In fact, no individual party displays any statistically significant change in their questions on the environment following environmental protests.

[17] See table A.6 with the share of all parties' questions as an outcome variable in the appendix.

Figure 4.6: LATE Plots Responsiveness to environmental protests - Party differences




**Note:** *The figure shows the local average treatment effect on the treated estimated from the RDiT models. The outcome variable is the daily probability of the respective party asking a parliamentary question on the environment. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.*

So far the results show that while political parties were responsive to environmental protests before the Green Party's parliamentary entrance, this ceased to be the case in the period following the party's entrance - providing empirical support for hypothesis 2b on the negative effect of institutional allies on other parties' responsiveness to protests.

However, figure 4.5 reveals that the confidence intervals are relatively large for the period before the Green Party's entrance. To stress-test the results, multiple robustness checks were conducted. This included; i) an analysis with different bandwidth lengths (See tables A.7, A.8, and A.9 in the appendix for this chapter.); ii) a specification of the dependent variable as a binary outcome and as a count variable (see tables A.10 and A.11 in the appendix); iii) exclusion of days where confrontational and/or violent protest events took place (see figure A.3 in the appendix; iv) placebo tests moving the cut-off point by multiple days;

v) doughnut test which removes the observations around the day of the protest events; vi) different order of polynomials; vii) models with different fixed effects such as weekends or single weekdays.[18]

Generally, the additional models corroborate the main findings, i.e. that outside the period prior to the Green Party's entrance, political parties are not responsive to environmental protests. However, the findings are relatively sensitive to the inclusion of a longer time before and after the protest events i.e. different bandwidth specifications. Scholars caution against using an arbitrarily selected cut-off for the bandwidths (as is done in the robustness-tests) and encourage using the data-driven methods where the bias-variance is carefully balanced (Cattaneo et al., 2019). While the main reported findings represent the ideal balance between bias and variance, the lack of robustness for the results might underline the time-sensitive frame of responsiveness of parties to environmental protests.

Overall, the analysis provides very limited support for the agenda-setting effect of environmental protests. The only time in which protests affected parties' parliamentary attention to the environment was in the early days of the protests, prior to their institutional ally entering the parliament.

## Responsiveness to radical-right protests - Immigration

Table 4.4 displays the local average treatment effect of radical-right protests on the daily share of questions on immigration. Similar to environmental protests, radical-right protests are not generally followed by an increase in the daily share of parliamentary questions on their core issue - immigration.

[18] points iv. to vii. can be found in the two attached files in the supporting material.

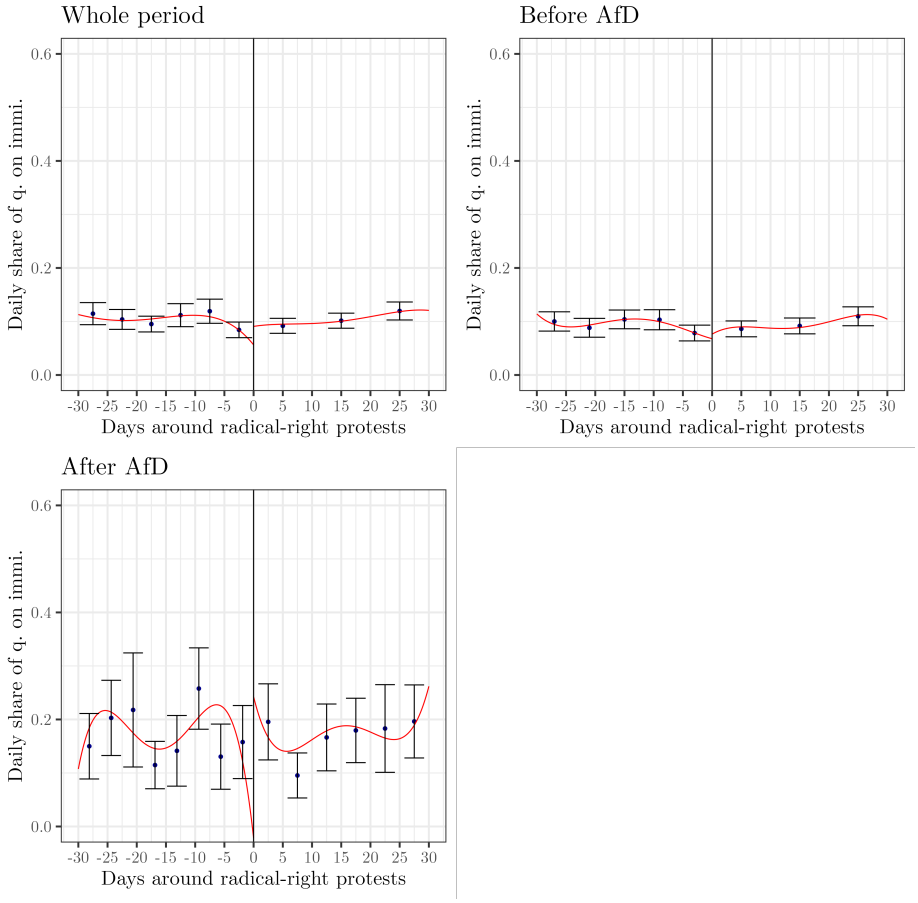
Table 4.4: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Immigration

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| -0.035 | 0.236 | 8 | 1,620 | Linear | Full sample |
| -0.087* | 0.046 | 8 | 1,486 | Quadratic | Full sample |
| -0.037 | 0.233 | 9 | 1,456 | Linear | Before AfD |
| -0.003 | 0.970 | 8 | 150 | Linear | After AfD |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily share of parliamentary questions on immigration as the outcome, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Figure 4.7 displays the regression discontinuity plots for the whole sample and the period before and after the AfD's parliamentary entrance using the whole support of the data. Figure 4.8 displays the coefficients of radical-right protests for each sample specification using the optimal bandwidth length. The figures indicate that radical-right protests do not have an agenda-setting effect, and this remain unchanged by the AfD entering parliament.

Figure 4.7: Regression discontinuity plots - Questions on immigration

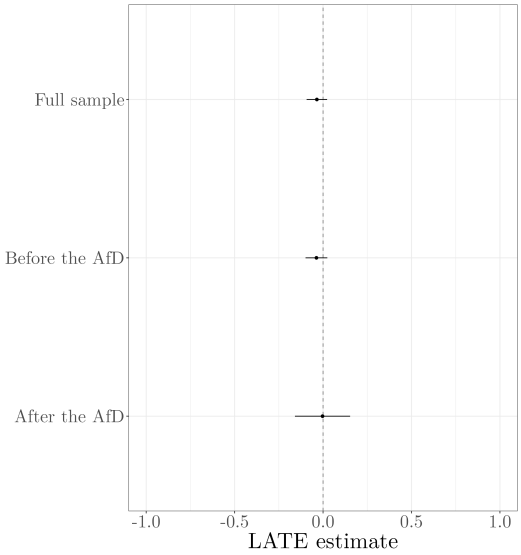



**Note:** *The figures displays the daily share of parliamentary questions on immigration using the full support of the data (i.e. in the four week period before and after the protest event), including day fixed-effects. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals. The bins represent local sample means, where each bin summarises 5 to 7,5 days before the cut-off and 6 to 7,5 days after the protest event.*

The RD-plot shows that for the whole period and the sample before the AfD's entrance into parliament, the share of questions is relatively continuously distributed with almost no change around the cut-off, i.e. the radical-right protest events. A small visual change can be seen around the cut-off after the AfD's entrance, but table 4.4 reveals that this effect is not statistically significant.

The only model specification which shows radical-right protests having a statistically significant effect on parties' parliamentary agendas - in this case a negative effect - is the quadratic specification. However, quadratic model specifications should be interpreted with care, as they are more sensitive to over fitting and boundaries (Cattaneo et al., 2019), and should rather be used to probe the robustness of the findings.

Figure 4.8: LATE Plots Responsiveness to radical-right protests - Sample differences




**Note:** *The figure shows the local average treatment effect on the treated estimated from the RDiT models. The outcome variable is the daily share of parliamentary question on immigration and displays the effect for the full sample and sub-samples. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.*

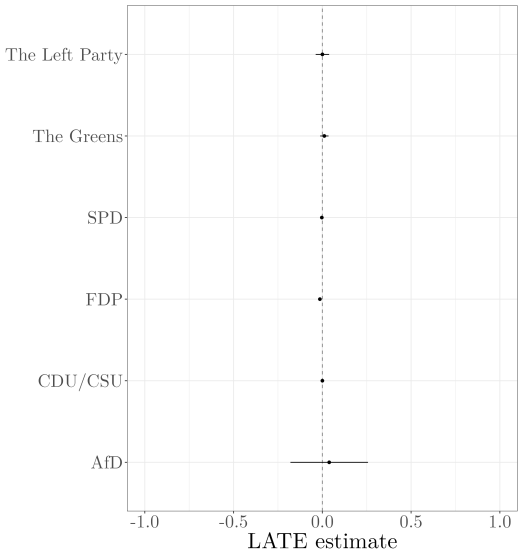
The results for radical-right protests provide further empirical evidence against the agenda-setting effect of protests (Hyp1a). Overall, parties do not respond to environmental protests or radical-right protests with increased parliamentary attention on the protests' issues. Furthermore, in the case of radical-right protests, the entrance of an institutional ally into parliament does nothing to change this. In contrast to the entrance of the Green Party, the entrance of the AfD was followed by no change in other parties' responsiveness to radical-right

protests - providing little evidence for or against the helpfulness of institutional allies to the cause of protests.

However, while the inclusion of the Green Party's questions into the dependent variable changed nothing from the main results, the inclusion of the AfD's questions does change the results for radical-right protests. If the AfD's questions are included, radical-right protests cause over an 19 % increase in the daily share of questions in the 8 days following the radical-right protests.[19] This might indicate that the responsiveness to radical-right protests is driven by the AfD's questions. However, the analysis of individual parties' responsiveness to radical-right protests reveal that this effect is not driven by the AfD's questions alone. Figure 4.9 displays the daily probability of the parties raising a question on immigration following radical-right protest events. As can be seen in the figure, while the AfD has a positive coefficient - i.e. is more likely to raise a question on immigration in the days following a radical-right protest - the effect is not statistically significant. In fact, the only party with a statistically significant effect is the FDP, the Liberal Party, which has a decreased daily probability in asking a question on immigration following radical-right protest events. The fact that most parties don't display a significant change in their daily likelihood of asking questions on immigration once analysed individually, might be explained by a too low variation in individual parties' daily probability to reach statistical significance and only by analysing all parties' questions together is enough variation provided to draw sound conclusions. These results thus suggest that the AfD's presence does amplify radical-right protests' agenda-setting power by provoking questions from other parties as well as asking questions itself, but that this is effect is only evident when all parties' questions are analysed together, and no one party is significantly more likely to respond to radical-right protests.

[19] See table A.12 in supplementary material.

Figure 4.9: LATE Plots Responsiveness to radical-right protests - Party differences




**Note:** *The figure shows the local average treatment effect on the treated estimated from the RDiT models. The outcome variable is the daily probability of the respective party asking a parliamentary question on immigration. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.*

The results on parties' responsiveness to radical-right protests are relatively robust for numerous different model specifications. The null findings on parties' share of parliamentary questions on immigration hold for varying orders of polynomials, specification of the dependent variable, and varying weekdays fixed-day effects - with the exception of linear models for 21 days bandwidth length. However, the results are partly sensitive to a different bandwidth length specification, especially for short bandwidth length [20]

Additional robustness check excluded days where violent or confrontational events took place, but this did not change the findings. This means that parties' silence on the immigration issues following radical-right protests is not driven

[20]See tables A.13, A.14 and A.15 for different bandwidth length specifications, table A.16 for the outcomes for a binary dependent variable, table A.17 for the outcomes for a count dependent variable, and the appendix_table file in the supplementary materials for this chapter for different fixed effects and order of polynomials.

by radical or violent events.[21]

### Responsiveness to radical-right protests - far-right violence

To test hypothesis 1b, the models for the radical-right protests were re-run with parliamentary questions on far-right violence as the dependent variable. Table 4.5 displays the results of the RDiT analysis. In contrast to the prior findings on radical-right protests' agenda-setting effect, there is a considerable and statistically significant change in parties' attention to far-right violence in the week following radical-right protest events. In the 8 days following radical-right protests, there was a 9 % increase in the share of parliamentary questions on far-right violence. This effect remains statistically significant for the period prior to the AfD's parliamentary entrance, but becomes statistically insignificant following the AfD's entrance.

Table 4.5: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Right-wing violence

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.093** | 0.003 | 8 | 1,486 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.106* | 0.018 | 9 | 1,863 | Quadratic | Full sample |
| 0.108** | 0.002 | 7 | 1,336 | Linear | Before AfD |
| 0.011 | 0.846 | 8 | 164 | Linear | After AfD |

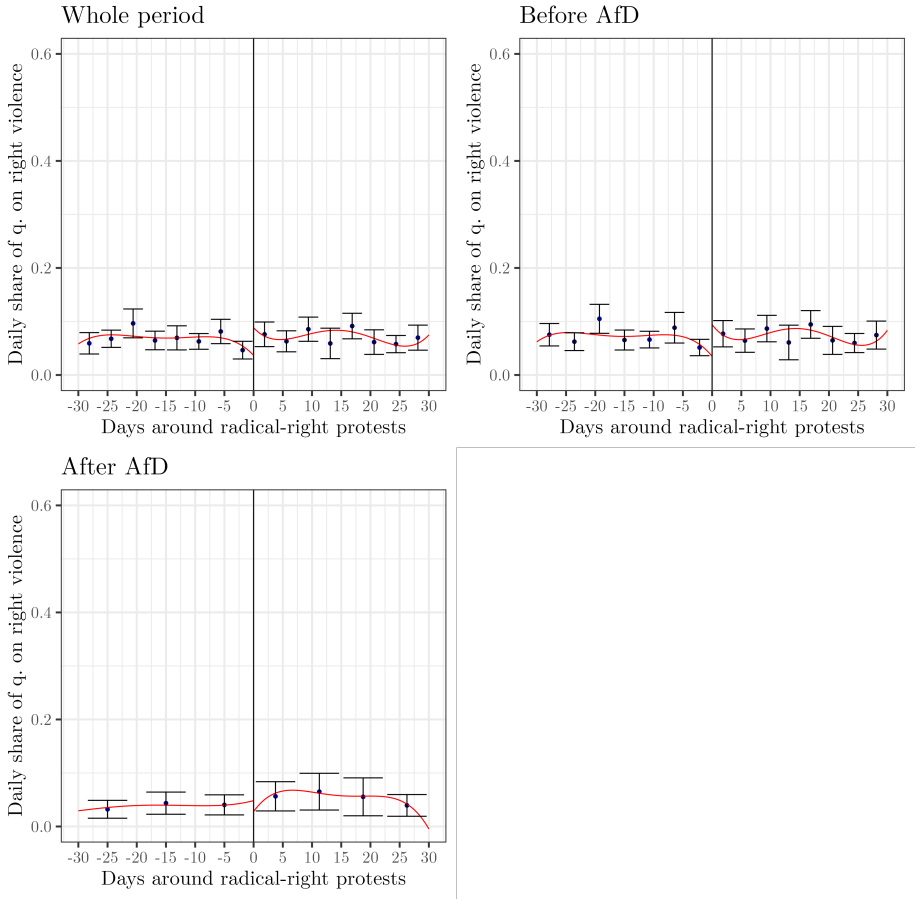
**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily share of parliamentary questions on far-right violence as the outcome, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Figure 4.10 displays the RD plots for the daily share of questions on far-right violence around radical-right protest events using the whole support of

[21] See figure and all model specifications for samples without violent and confrontational events in the attached file in supplementary materials for this chapter.

the data. Figure 4.11 shows the local average treatment effect for each sample specification. The two top RD-plots illustrate the results for the whole period and before the AfD's entrance. A small change can be seen in the share of parliamentary questions around the protest events. The inclusion of days fixed-effects ensures that the effect reported in table 4.5 and figures 4.10 is not driven by a particularity of the weekdays or the parliamentary schedule. The graph below displays the results for the period after the AfD's entrance, and shows that the days after radical-right protest events are not followed by any discontinuity in the share of questions on far-right violence.

Figure 4.10: Regression discontinuity plots - Questions on far-right violence

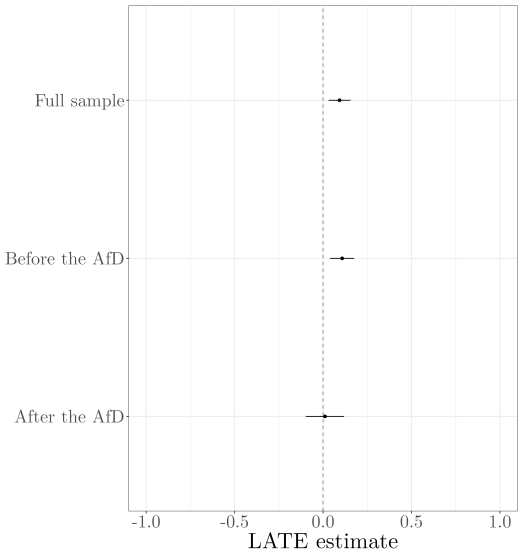



**Note:** *The figures display the daily share of parliamentary questions on far-right violence using the full support of the data (i.e. in the four-week period before and after the protest event), controlling for weekday effects. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals. The bins represent local sample means, where each bin summarises 3,75 to 6 days before the cut-off and 6 to 7,5 days after the protest event.*

The effect of right-wing protests on the share of parliamentary questions on far-right violence disappears once the AfD enters parliament. This can be tentatively interpreted as evidence for the positive effect of institutional allies. However, in this case a lack of issue ownership is not a rational reason for other parties to shy away from questions concerning far-right violence. Their reticence on this issue might rather be a tactical attempt to avoid alienating protesters and protest sympathisers - who now have an institutional ally to vote for - and

to deny the protests additional attention by avoiding the issue entirely.

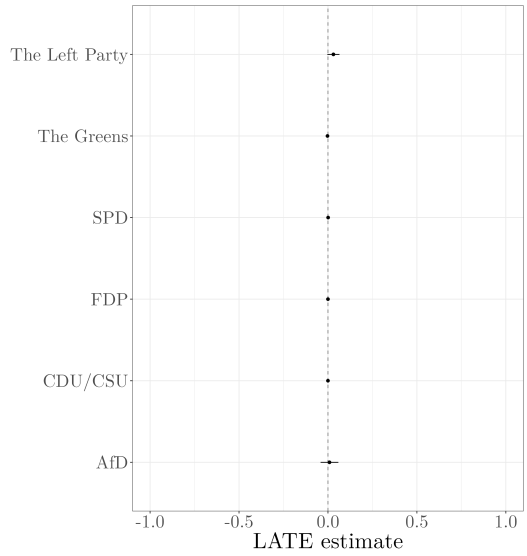
Figure 4.11: LATE Plots Responsiveness to radical-right protests - Sample differences




**Note:** *The figure shows the local average treatment effect on the treated estimated from the RDiT models. The outcome variable is the daily share of parliamentary question on far-right violence and displays the effect for the full sample and sub-samples. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.*

Figure 4.12 illustrates individual party's responsiveness to radical-right protest events. The figure uses the daily probability of the parties raising a question on far-right violence following radical-right protest events as the dependent variable. The figure illustrates that the radical-right protests have no statistically significant effect on individual parties' questions on far-right violence.

Figure 4.12: LATE Plots Responsiveness to radical-right protests - Party differences




**Note:** *The figure shows the local average treatment effect on the treated estimated from the RDiT models. The outcome variable is the daily probability of the respective party asking a parliamentary question on far-right violence. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.*

These results hold for different bandwidth-lengths (though not longer than 10 days bandwidths), different orders of polynomials and the inclusion of different fixed effects.[22] However, while the results hold for a count dependent variable, the same does not apply for a specification of the outcome as a binary variable.[23] This seems to indicate that while the number of parliamentary questions and the share of questions is affected by radical-right protest events, the same does not apply to the overall propensity of parties to ask a question. A potential explanation for this variation between the models could be that responsiveness is partly driven by a few particularly radical changes in the share and number of questions following only a few events. However, excluding radical events such as violent and confrontational events from the analysis

[22]See tables A.19, A.20, and A.21 in the appendix for outcomes for different bandwidth lengths. And all additional models can be found in the attached file in the supplementary materials.

[23]See tables A.22 and A.23 for the different models.

does not result in different results.[24] While a binary outcome variable might be less sensitive to radical changes in parties' responsiveness, the lack of statistical significance for this one outcome specification shows that it masks the effect radical-right protests can have.

## Discussion and Conclusion

This chapter set out to explore parties' responsiveness to protests in a changing political landscape and answer three central questions: Do environmental protests and radical-right protests cause parties to pay more attention to the environment and immigration in their parliamentary questions? Do parties respond to radical-right protests with questions on far-right violence? And finally, how and to what extent is party responsiveness affected by the parliamentary entrance of an institutional ally?

The chapter contributes to our understanding of the political outcomes of protest mobilisation while drawing on insights from party research and using an innovative method and rich data. Overall, the RDiT analysis of environmental and radical-right protests in Germany from 1975 to 2019 provides little empirical support for the theory that protests have an agenda-setting effect on parties' parliamentary agendas. However, radical-right protests do have the unintended consequences of parties raising questions about far-right violence in the days following the protest events. Interestingly, this effect is not driven by violent protests events - indicating that protests' anti-liberal ideology is the main driver of parties' negative responses to the protests.

The results suggest that institutional allies have a mixed effect on the responsiveness of other parties to protests. While parties were responsive to environmental protests prior to the Green Party's entrance, this effect disappeared once the Greens entered parliament. While this provides empirical evidence institutional allies' negative effect, the same does not apply to the entrance of the AfD, which was followed by a change in both the agenda-setting effect of radical-right protests and their unintended consequences. While established

[24] See figure A.5 in appendix.

parties responded to radical-right protests with questions on far-right violence prior to the party's entrance, this ceased after the AfD entered parliament. Furthermore, while political parties generally do not respond to radical-right protests with questions on immigration, the analysis including the parliament as a whole - i.e. including the AfD's questions - shows that after 2017, radical-right protests caused an increase in questions on immigration.

While this chapter set out with three simple questions, the results paint a complicated picture. Overall, protests do not have an agenda-setting effect. This stands in contrast to the many studies which have attributed agenda changes to protest mobilisation - especially the numerous studies which have made substantive claims about the impact of the environmental movement (Rootes, 2003; Rootes and Nulman, 2015). There are multiple potential explanations for the discrepancy between the findings of this chapter and those of prior research.

First, the research design of this study goes beyond correlational claims and includes not only large and well-organised protests but also small, regional protests. Former studies have often only focused on large, well-known protest movements which introduce a selection bias. Second, this chapter only includes two protest types - the environment and radical-right protests. The existing studies which have found an agenda-setting effect of protests have often included a wide range of protests' goals (Hutter and Vliegenthart, 2018; Vliegenthart et al., 2016). Third, prior research has often included a very long time-frame, while this study focuses on a short period around the protest events to rule out the effect being a result of incremental changes over time. Finally, social movement studies have often included a wide range of protest activities from marches to legal action and lobbying, and a wide variety of outcomes - and consequently have detected some effect of some of these activities on some of the outcomes (Olzak and Soule, 2009). While the discrepancy between this study's finding and those of prior research cannot be definitively established , future studies adopting the approaches used here could include more protests' issues to determine whether similar results would be produced.

While the findings show that protests have very limited agenda-setting effect, radical-right protests have the unintended consequences of parties rais-

ing questions on far-right violence. These results underline the importance of including the potential unintended consequences of protest mobilisation. Although protesters often have clear policy goals, their mobilisation can backfire. Studies have found violent tactics to decrease the public's support for the protests(Feinberg et al., 2020; Selvanathan and Lickel, 2019; Simpson et al., 2018). However, excluding days with violent events revealed that this effect was not driven by violent protest. While this might suggest that parties' negative responses are driven by the anti-liberal ideology of the protests, this might also highlight a weakness in the empirical approach of the study. While the protests are treated as isolated events, protests build up a repertoire of tactics and strategies. The fact that radical-right protesters more often use violence might affect the political consequences of radical-right protests overall -regardless of whether violence took place at the event or not.

Overall, the findings provide mixed evidence for the helpfulness of institutional allies for the cause of protests. While prior research has primarily focused on the responsiveness of the allies themselves, this chapter explored how their parliamentary entrance affected other parties' responsiveness. Drawing on insights from research on party competition provides us with a context to understand parties' (non-)responsiveness to protests. The lack of party engagement with environmental protests following the Green Party's entrance echoes some prior findings on parties' emphasis on the environment following the Green parties' entrance into parliament (Abou-Chadi, 2016). With the environmental issue being a strong valence issue, parties seem to have less leeway and electoral incentive to respond to environmental protests. Although the entrance of the Green Party posed a substantial threat to other established parties - especially on the left side of the political spectrum - their lack of response in the presence of the Green Party strengthens theories of issue avoidance.

In contrast to the changes in party responsiveness following the Green Party's entrance, theories of issue competition provide us with limited explanation of why party responsiveness to radical-right protests changed following the AfD's parliamentary entrance. This lack of response is not driven by traditional issue avoidance as might be the case if far-right violence were a particularly favourable

issue for the AfD. However, the lack of response could be the result of parties' concerns that addressing this issue might drive protesters, sympathisers and their votes toward the AfD. This study cannot tell us which one of these reasons is motivating the change in parties' responsiveness to radical-right protests, and future studies should more fully explore the party strategies decisions behind these changes.

Regardless of its methodological innovations and the inclusion of a crucial aspect in the form of political competition, this chapter has some limitations. First, the attempt to causally estimate the impact of protests limits the time frame and the potential outcomes studied. This means that no insights can be gained on the potential long-term effect of protests on the legislative agenda of parties. Second, by limiting the outcome to the parliamentary agenda, little can be said about responsiveness in other formats like social media or press releases, where politicians can perhaps express their support or disdain more freely. Third, prior studies exploring the political consequences of protests have found their effects depends on a plurality of contextual factors and the characteristics of the protests. However, in endeavouring to isolate the causal effect of protest on legislative behaviour, the scope of this chapter does not allow for considerations of the context of these protests; whether they were met with counter-protests or whether single events were a part of a larger wave of well-organised, highly public and salient protest. Fourth, some of the results are not robust once the standard robustness checks for regression discontinuity design in time are conducted. Finally, while the chapter addresses the methodological challenges of estimating the relationship between protests and parliamentary questions, the research design does not allow for a causal estimate of the effect of institutional allies' entrance into parliament on the responsiveness of other parties. Consequently, the entrance of the Green Party and the AfD might coincide with other factors which affect the relationship between protests and parties. Future studies should develop more innovative approaches to address methodological shortcomings in analysing driving factors and mechanisms for elites' responsiveness to protests.

Despite these limitations, the chapters' findings contribute to our under-

standing of party responsiveness to protests. Furthermore, this study has important implications for future research. First, the limited agenda-setting effect of protests detected in this chapter underlines the need of future studies to use careful research designs to precisely estimate the effect of protests. The field of quantitative research on protests' outcomes is rapidly growing, with scholars implementing advanced research designs which allow for the causal estimation of protests effects. Future studies need to continue down this path. However, on that note, this study would have benefited from a mixed-method approach to better explain and understand the motivations and the strategy of political parties. Consequently, future studies might advance the field of protest research further by combining innovative methodological approaches with their longstanding traditions of qualitative work.

The second important conclusion to draw from this chapter is that radical-right street mobilisation needs to be included in the analytical scope of future studies. Social movement scholars have often complained about the singular focus on protests and actors on the left (Hutter and Kriesi, 2013). These results suggest that right-wing protests are not only substantial in numbers and require further attention, but also that the reaction of parties is not limited to protests on the left. With right-wing protests representing a growing proportion of street mobilisation in Europe as seen in the period following the refugee crisis in 2015, parties on both the Right and the Left have electoral incentives to respond to them – negatively or positively. Moreover, the complicated effect of the AfD's entrance on party responsiveness to radical-right protests highlights the need of future research to further study the relationship between protests on the Right and their institutional allies, as scholars have increasingly started to do (See e.g. Caiani, 2019; Gattinara and Pirro, 2019; Hellmeier and Vüllers, 2023; Weisskircher et al., 2023).

Despite some drawbacks, this chapter contributes to the field linking protest mobilisation to democratic responsiveness by implementing an innovative methodological approach and using a very extensive data set. This chapter concludes that overall environmental protest and radical-right protests in Germany do not have an agenda-setting effect on the parliamentary agenda of political parties.

The limitations of this chapter open up new avenues for future research. While this chapter only explores environmental and radical-right protest - issues which are not easily located on the traditional left-right dimension and are accompanied by new political actors - future studies should investigate to what extent these results are generalisable to other more traditional political issues. Are political parties more prone to respond to protests which raise the salience of more traditional issues, such as the economy? Moreover, the form of unconventional political participation is undergoing dramatic innovation with a plurality of forms and modes emerging. Finally, this chapter only looks at the very traditional form of street demonstrations, and future research should apply the methodology of this study to new forms of protest movements which often take place on social media and on the internet.

# Chapter 5

# Electoral incentives and the electoral context[1]

While the previous chapter explored whether changes in the party system might affect parties' parliamentary responsiveness to environmental and radical-right protests in Germany, this chapter shifts the analytical focus from the party system level to individual parties' electoral incentives in responding to protests. With democratic responsiveness lying at the heart of representative democracy, it is no wonder that scholars have spent a considerable amount of time and resources explaining variations in elites' responsiveness. The lion's share of work on democratic responsiveness has been dedicated to the electoral context and electoral pressure. However, the majority of scholarly work on political elites' responsiveness has measured public opinion using questions on 'the most important issue' from public surveys (Spoon and Klüver, 2014; Hobolt and Klemmensen, 2008; Bonafont and Palau, 2011; Jennings and John, 2009) or public referendums (Giger et al., 2020), rather than taking political protests as a signal of public opinion. While research on party responsiveness to protest mobilisation has investigated parties' electoral incentives as a driving factor behind their responsiveness (Hutter and Vliegenthart, 2018; Berker and Pollex, 2021), the fo-

[1]This chapter builds on co-authored work with Violeta Haas and António Valentim (Bjarnadóttir et al., 2023). See documents in the submission for their declarations.

cus has primarily been on parties' ideological position and opposition status as the key motivating force behind parties' willingness to engage with protests' claims.

Taking the existing research as a starting point, while drawing on insights from research on parties' behaviour, this chapter investigates which party characteristics might condition regional parties' responsiveness to the Fridays for Future (FFF) protests in Germany. The FFF movement started out as a small protest of school-striking children in front of the Swedish parliament in 2018. Led by Greta Thunberg, the protests demanded that the Swedish government uphold the pledges of the 2015 Paris Agreement. The protests rapidly snowballed into a major global movement, organising "Global strikes" and calling for governments worldwide to fight global warming. One of these global strikes is estimated to have attracted over 6 million participants across 100 countries in one day in 2019 (Taylor et al., 2019). Being a large, peaceful, well-organised movement with substantial public support (Wahlström et al., 2019), FFF would seem perfectly placed to achieve an agenda-setting effect, and offers a unique opportunity to explore variation in parties' willingness to engage with the movement's issues. While the FFF movement has been of particular interest to scholars of social movements (See e.g. Barrie et al., 2023; Schürmann, 2023; Berker and Pollex, 2021), this study explores parties' electoral incentives and the electoral context as moderating factors.

Research on the democratic responsiveness of political elites has paid special attention to how incumbent status, temporal proximity to elections, and electoral vulnerability can affect elites' responsiveness to public opinion. This chapter studies the extent to which these factors apply to parties' responsiveness to protest mobilisation and tests four different hypotheses using a mixture of matching and difference-in-difference methods (Imai et al., 2023), and multiplicative interaction models to causally estimate the effect of FFF protests on the regional parties' press releases on the environment. First, the chapter explores the overall agenda-setting effect of the protests. Second, it investigates the moderating effect of individual parties' electoral incentives and analyses the difference in responsiveness between opposition and government parties and the

moderating effect of electoral loss. Finally, the chapter explores the conditioning effect of the electoral context and tests whether parties are more responsive to protests in the weeks leading up to the elections.

Using data on regional parties' press releases from August 2018 to November 2021 and geo-coded data of FFF protests from across Germany, the empirical analysis finds that while FFF protests do not have a general agenda-setting effect on parties' attention to the environment in their press releases, parties which experienced a particularly high electoral loss in previous elections are more likely to respond to the protest than other parties. However, contrary to expectations based on theory, neither parties' opposition status nor the temporal proximity to upcoming elections had any effect on the number or share of party press releases focusing on environmental issues. An investigation of alternative outcomes (press releases on the related topic of energy) and exploratory dictionary analysis (searching for press releases mentioning FFF) yielded identical findings. By exploring the effect of the electoral context on parties' responsiveness to FFF protests in Germany, the chapter contributes to the literature on democratic responsiveness while enhancing our understanding of the political consequences of protest mobilisation.

The chapter proceeds as follows. First, the theoretical considerations and the hypotheses derived from these considerations are presented. Subsequently, the case selection, data, and identification strategy are discussed. Following and explanation of the research design, the results are presented. Finally, the results are discussed in connection with existing research, followed by concluding remarks and avenues for future studies.

## Responsiveness to political protests

As in the previous chapter, the relationship between protests and political parties is explored by adopting the agenda-setting approach. Political protests are considered to send a signal to policymakers and other citizens about which issues have not been sufficiently addressed, who is to blame, and which new issues need to be addressed by lawmakers (Lohmann, 1993; Gillion and Soule, 2018).

Political protests can be a powerful and clear signal for political elites. They are a costly form of political participation and express a strong commitment among participants (Lohmann, 1993). Additionally, protests can be considered an unambiguous public opinion signal for their single-issue focus, and the size of the protest can convey information to politicians about the size of the segment of the population who cares about the issue (Vliegenthart et al., 2016; Wouters and Walgrave, 2017). For these reasons, political parties - understood as rational, vote-seeking actors - should be responsive to changing tides in public opinion and clear signals like protests on citizens' preferences. The agenda-setting effect on parties' attention to environmental issues is formalised in the following hypothesis:

**H1:** *Parties are more likely to put emphasis on the environment in their political communication in the weeks following a FFF protest.*

## Parties' electoral incentives

Despite increasing research interest in the political consequences of protests and social movements, few studies have shifted the focus from movements' characteristics to elites' electoral incentives and explored in detail which elites' characteristics contribute to their willingness to engage with protest mobilisation. The studies which have included individual parties' characteristics have primarily found empirical support for parties' opposition status as a source of variation in their responsiveness to protests and social movements (Hutter et al., 2018). From a theoretical standpoint, opposition parties have a higher electoral incentive to be responsive to public opinion signals such as protests in order to enter or re-enter government (Klüver and Spoon, 2014). Moreover, opposition parties stand to benefit from capitalising on protests' grievances and demands, as these are often targeted at the government (Piccio, 2016). Finally, opposition parties are less constrained than governmental parties by past legislative decisions, coalition agreements, or external economic factors (Klüver and Spoon, 2014; Hutter and Vliegenthart, 2018). For these reasons, this chapter explores the extent to which opposition parties are more likely to respond to FFF protests compared to governmental parties, and tests the following hypothesis:

**H2:** *Opposition parties are more likely to be responsive to FFF protests in comparison to governmental parties.*

Democratic theory has long been occupied with another factor which might affect parties' electoral incentives in responding to protests: electoral vulnerability. One strand of the literature has focused on how representatives who lost with small electoral margins need to be more attuned to their constituency in order to be re-elected - also known as the marginality hypothesis. While the marginality hypothesis has received ardent empirical scrutiny (Kuklinski, 1977; Giger et al., 2020; Brunell and Buchler, 2009; Griffin, 2006; Gay, 2007), scholars in proportional representation systems have rather focused on vote loss as a sign of re-election prospects for parties. In a similar vein, vote loss and uncertain re-election prospects are expected to make parties more attuned to public opinion. On the one hand, this is because vote loss is a clear signal of divergence between public opinion and parties' prior positions (Budge, 1994). On the other, parties who experienced a substantial decrease in their vote share in past elections need to be more attentive to public opinion to (re)gain office or ensure their future prospects. While protests are just one of many signals parties can listen to (Wouters et al., 2019), they might prove especially valuable for parties who experienced high electoral volatility. To investigate the moderating effect of vote loss on parties' responsiveness, the following hypothesis will be tested:

**H3:** *The higher the vote loss experienced by parties in the last local election, the more likely they are to be responsive to FFF protests.*

## Responsiveness and the electoral context

In addition to individual parties' electoral incentives, the electoral context can be expected to shape the agenda-setting effect of FFF protests. Scholars of democratic responsiveness have explored the extent to which temporal proximity to the next election affects parties' responsiveness (Giger et al., 2020; Spoon and Klüver, 2014). The theoretical assumption driving this line of research is that parties' electoral concerns are not stable across the electoral cycle. Rather,

the electoral pressure is expected to be higher in close proximity to elections, as electoral concerns become more salient and acute (Giger et al., 2020). Moreover, elections open up avenues for social movements to engage in proactive electoral mobilisation to advance their interests (McAdam and Tarrow, 2010; Blee and Currier, 2006) and although they do not necessarily openly endorse certain parties, their mobilisation can heighten the salience of their issue and underline their grievances. Friday's for Future climate strike on the 26th of September 2021 is an example of proactive electoral mobilisation. Only two days prior to the German parliamentary elections, protesters took to the streets criticising the shortsightedness of existing climate policies and the inadequacy of politicians commitment to dealing with climate change while highlighting the importance of the elections for the future of the environment. For these reasons, parties are expected to be more responsive to FFF protests when these occur closer to elections. This theoretical assumption is formalised in the final hypothesis of the chapter:

**H4**: *The closer the next elections, the more likely parties are to be responsive to FFF protests.*

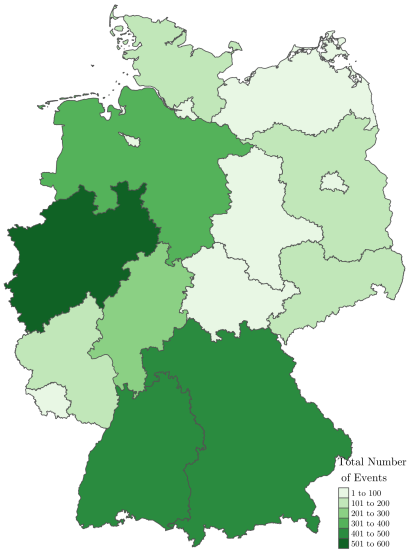
# Research Design

## Case selection

The FFF movement might have started out as a small protest of school-striking children, but its rapid snowballing into a large global movement with numerous protests across the world makes it a particularly interesting case for investigating party responsiveness. Moreover, although the FFF movement has exceptionally young participants who might not all be eligible to vote (Wahlström et al., 2019), their public support is widespread (Valentim, 2023) and studies exploring the movement's consequences have found that individual politicians refer to the movement on their social media accounts (Barrie et al., 2023; Schürmann, 2023). Zeroing in on a specific successful protest movement rather than the more general protest topics discussed in the last chapter offers numerous analytical advantages. First, the movement fulfils many of the criteria identified

by scholars for a successful protest movement. Consequently, parties can be expected to respond to FFF, and offers a good case for exploring variations in responsiveness. Second, focusing on one movement holds the protests' demands and many other characteristics constant. Third, the protests take place both frequently and across Germany - providing variation in treatment across time and place.

Figure 5.1: Fridays For Future Protests in Germany




**Note:** *The figure displays the frequency of FFF protests across the sixteen states of Germany.*

In addition to focusing on a large protest movement like Fridays for Future, the chapter also moves away from the national level. Instead, it focuses on parties and protests at the regional level. Beyond the analytical merit provided by increasing variation in treatment and outcome, there are three reasons for focusing on the regional level. First, scholars of protests have increasingly criticised research at the aggregated level, as it overlooks the specific social and political climate that exists on the regional level and can be important both for the mobilisation and outcome of protests (Gillion, 2012, 2020). This criticism of research on the aggregated level is especially important for the FFF movement that has emphasised the local dimension of climate politics and focused

their protest activities locally (Schürmann, 2023). Second, the regional level does not only hold importance for FFF but also for German national politics more generally. Scholars have emphasised the implications of regional coalition formations and electoral outcomes for the national parties. Moreover, governmental constellations at the regional level affect national politics by providing potential veto players in the Bundesrat - the upper house of the German parliament (Bräuninger et al., 2020). Third, while the regional political parties need to be more attuned to the regional political context, research has highlighted the strong policy overlap of the national and regional parties (Bräuninger et al., 2020; Haas et al., 2008). This means that while the regional level provides analytical merits over the national-level, it is also of great importance for national level politics, and the regional parties are not fundamentally different from the national-level parties.

## Data

This chapter moves away from parties' behaviour in parliament and focuses on parties' press releases to measure their responsiveness to FFF protests. Measuring responsiveness via political communication like press releases has numerous advantages. First, press releases allow for a better exploration of individual parties' incentive structures. This is because press releases are not tied to government-opposition logic like the parliamentary questions. Parliamentary questions are often considered the instrument of the opposition - a pattern which is also reflected in the German parliament with the majority of questions being asked by opposition parties (Breunig and Schnatterer, 2019). Second, in contrast to individual politicians' social media posts, press releases present parties as unitary actors in which they collectively communicate their agenda to the media and their voters. Finally, unlike parliamentary speeches, press releases are not tied to parliamentary agendas and allow for parties to respond spontaneously to real-world events (Erfort et al., 2023).

Data on regional parties' press releases was collected by Kittel and Wegemann (2023) from the parties' websites. The data collection effort resulted in over 155,000 entries. The entries were subsequently classified into issue areas

using a BERT multi-lingual base model developed by Erfort et al. (2023). The model was trained on classified national-level press releases from the PARTY-PRESS database where it reached an accuracy of up to 70.68% using a five-fold cross-validation and optimised parameters (ibid.). The classification resulted in 6841 press releases on the environment.[2]. Evaluation of the classifier's specific performance for predicting the environmental issue in Germany resulted in an F-score of 63.5 %. [3]. As a robustness check, the analysis is re-run for an outcome that includes questions on energy.[4] Parties' responsiveness will both be measured in the absolute weekly number of press releases on the environment and the weekly share of press releases on the environment. Similar to the previous chapter, parties are considered to be responsive if the absolute number or share of press releases on the environment increases following an FFF protest event.

Geo-coded data on FFF protests from August 2018 to November 2021 (Valentim, 2023) was used for the analysis. The data originates from an open-source repository of protests kept by their organisers, and from FFF organisers' own internal records. Additionally, the data set contains information on the reported number of participants, the time of the protest, and social media information. While the data is based on self-reporting and not media-reported protests, additional analysis will only include protests which took place in larger cities and thus are more likely to be covered by news reporting. The protest data was aggregated at the state level using a German state shape-file. States are considered treated if at least one FFF protest took place that week within the state.

Finally, to investigate how individual parties' electoral incentives and the electoral context affect parties' responsiveness to FFF protests, data on local parties' government status, vote share and seat share within legislative terms, and regional election dates were collected from Wikipedia using web scraping techniques.[5] To operationalise electoral vulnerability at the party level, parties'

[2]For press releases on the national level, the multi-lingual model reached 70.7 % F-1 score. See section G.3 in the supplementary material from Erfort et al. (2023) for further detail on accuracy, precision, and recall

[3]See section G.6 for an overview of issue-specific performance in Erfort et al. (2023)

[4]The classification resulted in 5732 press releases on energy.

[5]A list of sites used can be found in the supplementary materials.

gains or losses in terms of votes and seats were calculated. This was done by measuring the difference between a party's vote/seat share in the most recent election and the previous elections. To explore the effect of the electoral context, i.e. the electoral cycle on parties' willingness to respond to FFF protests, the time to the next election was measured in weeks. Combining the different data sources results in a sample with 13,453 state-party-weeks (unit of analysis) between August, 18th 2018 and November, 5th 2021. Table 5.1 provides the summary statistics for the data. As FFF protests are usually held on Fridays and subsequent response is expected to happen in the days and weeks following, the weeks are structured to start on Fridays.

Table 5.1: Summary statistics

| Statistic | Mean | St. Dev. | Min | Max |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Number of weekly press r. | 0.193 | 0.516 | 0 | 8 |
| Weekly share of press r. | 0.035 | 0.112 | 0.000 | 1.000 |
| Difference in seat share | −1.595 | 6.971 | −14.648 | 20.822 |
| Difference in vote share | −1.476 | 5.993 | −12.000 | 17.800 |
| Units experiencing protest | 0.169 | 0.375 | 0 | 1 |

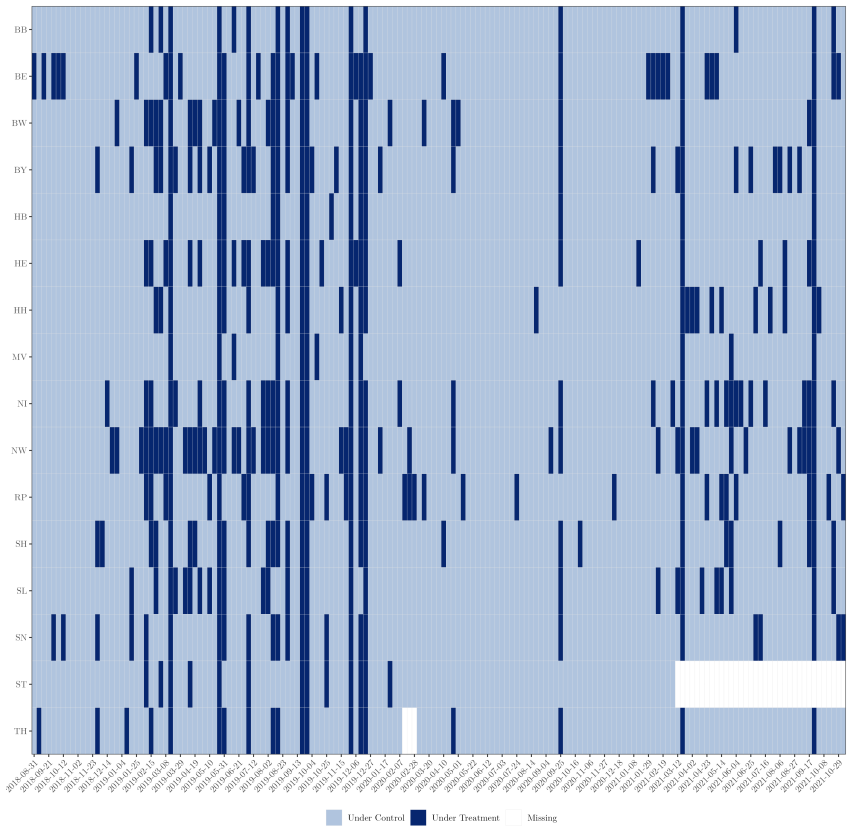
## Estimation

Estimating the causal effect of FFF protests on parties' issue attention to the environment poses the same methodological challenges the previous empirical chapter faced. Conventional regression models with the number of protests being regressed on the share or number of party press releases are likely to be plagued by omitted variable bias and both the protest and the press release could be explained through national, global, or local events and factors which have not been accounted for. However, for this analysis a RDiT design is out of the question; with FFF protests being staged frequently, it is hard to find units that have 'clean' pre-treatment and post-treatment units. For this reason, this

chapter employs a mixture of matching and difference-in-difference design (DiD) to causally estimate the effect of local FFF protests on parties' press releases.

The central idea behind DiD design is that while control and treated units might differ in numerous ways, the outcome of interest would have followed parallel trends in the absence of treatment (Angrist and Pischke, 2015). The traditional way of implementing DiD design is to use two-way-fixed effects. However, that requires units to remain treated once they experience the treatment, and the treatment to occur at the same time in all units (Goodman-Bacon, 2021). Due to the nature of FFF protests, the traditional DiD design cannot be applied; FFF protests do not take place simultaneously across all 16 states of Germany and they do not take place every week in every state. To circumvent these problems, a difference-in-difference estimator developed by Imai et al. (2023) was used. The approach combines the DiD method with matching. Matching methods facilitate a comparison between treated observations and control observations with similar characteristics. While matching methods can improve the validity of causal inference and are widely popular, they are only recently being combined with time-series cross-section data (ibid) - such as the data set in this analysis. The method allows for a comparison of units that go in and out of treatments - i.e. states that have protests some weeks but no protests other weeks - as well as treatment that occurs at a different timing across units. This aspect of the method is crucial for the analysis of the effect of FFF; the visualisation of the distribution of treatment across states and weeks is illustrated in figure 5.2.

Figure 5.2: Treatment variation plot

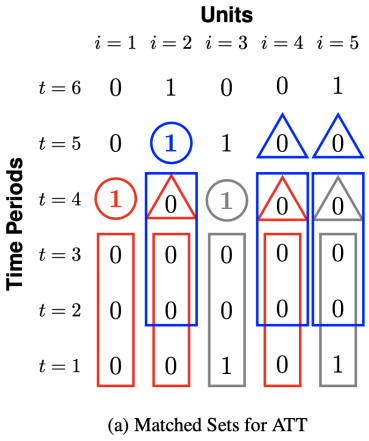



**Note:** *The figure shows the treatment status of units across time and space. The dark blue fields are treated units, while the light blue are untreated.*

In the first step, control observations are matched with observations for units that have "an identical treatment history for a pre-specified time span" (Imai et al., 2023, p. 1). This makes sure that control and treatment units are similar. Figure 5.3 illustrates the matching process for 5 units with 6 time periods where three weeks is the pre-specified time span. The authors explain: "For each treated observation (colored circles), we select a set of control observations from other units in the same time period (triangles with the same color) that have an identical treatment history (rectangles with the same color)." (ibid, p. 14). For the main analysis, a pre-treatment period of three weeks was selected and the matching sets were refined using a Mahalanobis distance matching. The

length of the period was selected with a balance between the precision and the number of matched units in mind.[6] Having established the matched sets, the average treatment effect of the treated (ATT) is established by estimating the counterfactual outcome for each treated observation "using the weighted average of the control units in the refined matched set. We then compute the difference-in-difference estimate of the ATT for each treated observation and then average it across all treated observations."(ibid., p.18).

Figure 5.3: An example of matched sets



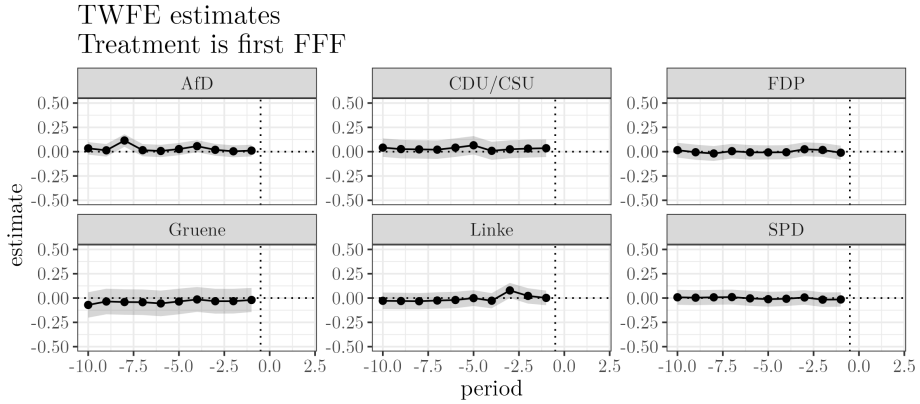

(a) Matched Sets for ATT

**Note:** *Figure from Imai et al. (2023, p. 14)*

One of the central assumptions for the estimator is that treated and untreated units would have followed parallel trends in the absence of FFF protests. That means that the share and absolute number of questions on the environment should follow similar trajectories prior to the treatment. Although this assumption cannot be directly tested, figure 5.4 illustrates that there are only marginal differences between treatment and control units in outcomes prior to treatment - providing support for the parallel trends assumption.

[6]Robustness checks include a pre-treatment period of 2 and 4 weeks and matching using a propensity distance matching.

Figure 5.4: Pre-treatment trends in outcome




**Note:** *The figure compares the pre-treatment trends of share of questions on the environment between to-be treated units and those that are not treated in that period.*

While the first hypothesis of this chapter - the hypothesis of the overall agenda-setting effect of FFF protest - is tested using the whole sample and all parties, the effect of parties' governmental status and individual parties' responsiveness to the protests re-runs the models described above with sub-samples. In the case of continuous moderators, sub-sample analysis using the (Imai et al., 2023) estimator is not possible. For this reason, multiplicative interaction models with party-state and year-fixed effects will be run. However, (Hainmueller et al., 2019) has identified two central problems conventional multiplicative interaction models can face. First, the models assume a linear interaction effect requiring them to change at a constant rate with the moderator. Second, due to a lack of common support between the moderator and the treatment variable, the results of such models can be misleading. To avoid model dependencies stemming from excessive extrapolation and relax the linear interaction effect assumption, the models will be re-run using binning estimator and kernel estimator using a package developed by Hainmuller et al. (2021), as proposed by (Hainmueller et al., 2019).[7]

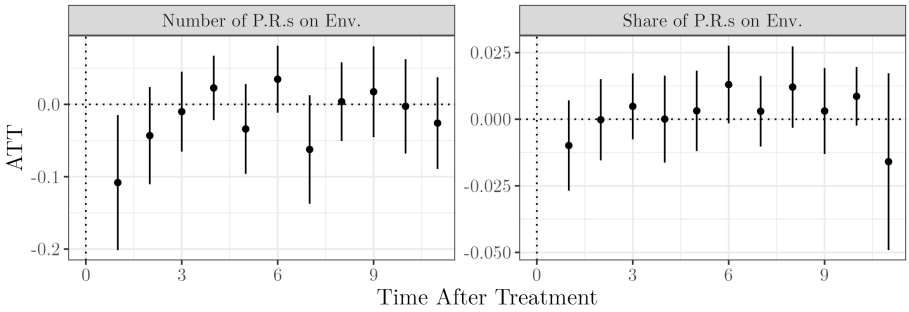
[7]See results for models with binning and kernel estimator in appendix.

# Results

Before delving into the relationship between parties' electoral incentives and their responsiveness to FFF protests, the analysis first explores the overall agenda-setting effect of the protests. Similar to the findings of the Chapter 4, FFF protests do not have an agenda-setting effect on parties' press releases - providing empirical evidence against hypothesis 1. Figure 5.5 displays an event study plot using the (Imai et al., 2023) estimator for both the share and number of parties' press releases on the environment as an outcome. The point estimator for each week shows the average treatment effect of FFF protests relative to the 3-week pre-treatment period. While the figures illustrate a positive trend in parties' attention to the environment in the three weeks following a protest event - both for the absolute number of questions and the share of questions - the trend is moving from a negative effect to a null effect. Moreover, the weekly point estimators are generally not significantly different from zero, with the exception of the average treatment effect on the absolute number of questions in the first week following a protest event. However, the effect is very small and disappears in the second week following the protest. The results show that once considering all parties, there is no agenda-setting effect of FFF protests in the 10 weeks following a protest event - indicating that there is neither an instantaneous nor long-term effect of the protests on regional parties' responsiveness. Robustness checks with different matching methods or the inclusion of press releases on energy do not result in substantially different results. [8]

[8] See figure B.2 to B.5 for outcomes for different lags and matching method, and see figure B.37 for outcome with parties' press releases on environment and energy as the outcome of interest.

Figure 5.5: Effect of FFF on parties' communications

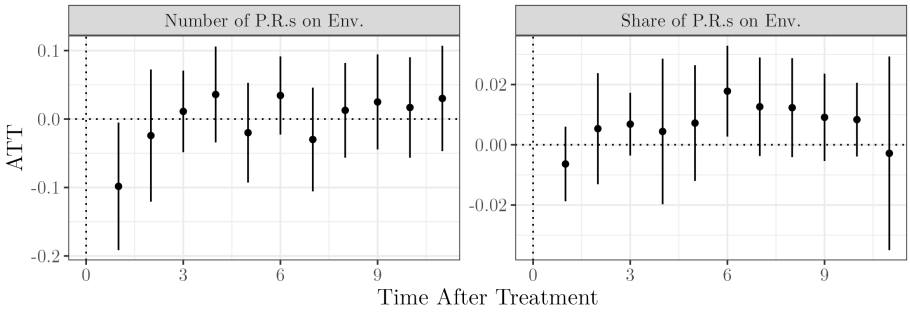



**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

This null effect of FFF protests on parties' press releases on the regional level might be explained through parties' varying electoral incentives to respond to the protest mobilisation. One such potential source of variation could be the opposition status of parties. Studies of parties' responsiveness to protests have often explored this avenue and concluded that opposition parties are more responsive to street mobilisation. Figure 5.6 illustrates the model including only opposition parties while figure 5.7 displays the results for governmental parties. Again, the matching sets are constructed using a three-week pre-treatment history, but only with opposition or governmental parties respectively. For example, this means that for opposition parties the control units are opposition parties in untreated units (state-week-party). The figures show that in contrast to hypothesis 2, opposition parties are not responsive to the FFF protests. For opposition parties, only two point estimators are statistically different from zero; i) a negative effect on the number of questions in the first week following a protest in the state; ii) a positive effect on the weekly share of questions. However, both effects are very small and close to zero.[9]

[9]The findings are not sensitive to model specifications as can be seen in figures B.6 to B.10 in the appendix for this chapter and only for 4 weeks pre-treatment matching can any effect on the share be detected - however only 6 weeks after the treatment.

Figure 5.6: Effect of FFF on opposition parties

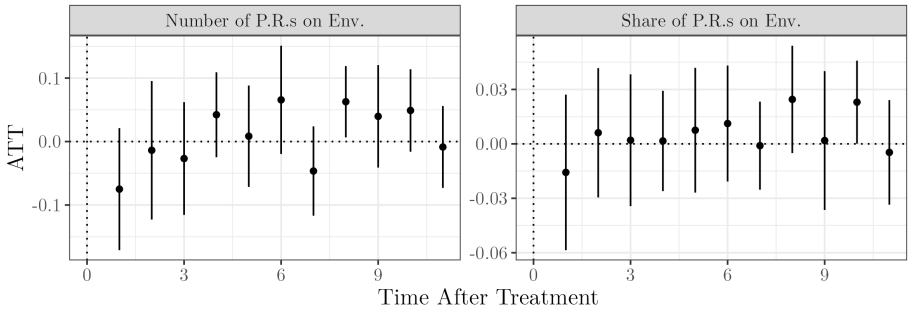



**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjusts for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

For governmental parties, the only statistically significant effect of FFF protests on party communication is around the 8th and the 10th week following the protest. However, due to the long time that passed from the protest and the nature of the parties' press releases, it is unlikely that this effect can be causally attributed to the FFF protest event in the state. Consequently, governmental parties are also not responsive to FFF protests.[10] Overall, these mixed empirical findings provide little support for hypothesis 2, i.e. that opposition parties are particularly responsive to FFF protests.

[10]These findings are robust for different model specifications. Additional model results are displayed in figures B.11 to B.15 in the appendix. Similar to the opposition party models, there is a small, significant effect detected using propensity matching. However that effect is only significant for the absolute number of press releases, six weeks after the treatment - see B.15

Figure 5.7: Effect of FFF on governmental parties




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

The results show that in contrast to theoretical expectations, opposition parties are not responsive to environmental protests. However, it might be that the opposition status affects parties differently. Consequently, the null findings for the opposition parties might be driven by all parties in the opposition being included in the sample. To explore the extent to which the effect of the opposition status is being masked by other unobserved party characteristics, the analysis was repeated but separated by parties. Figures B.16 to figure B.25 in the appendix show the results for each party dependent on governmental or opposition status. The results corroborate the null findings presented above with few exceptions. While none of the parties show any responsiveness while in opposition, the protests have a positive effect on the SPD's number and share of press releases in the environment in the weeks following the protest events (See figure B.19 in appendix).

To test hypotheses 3 and 4, the aforementioned multiplicative interaction model was used. Figure 5.8 displays the marginal effect of FFF protest on parties' press releases moderated by the votes share a party experienced in the prior elections. For the number of press releases on the environment, it seems that the smaller the electoral gain, the more likely the party is to respond to FFF

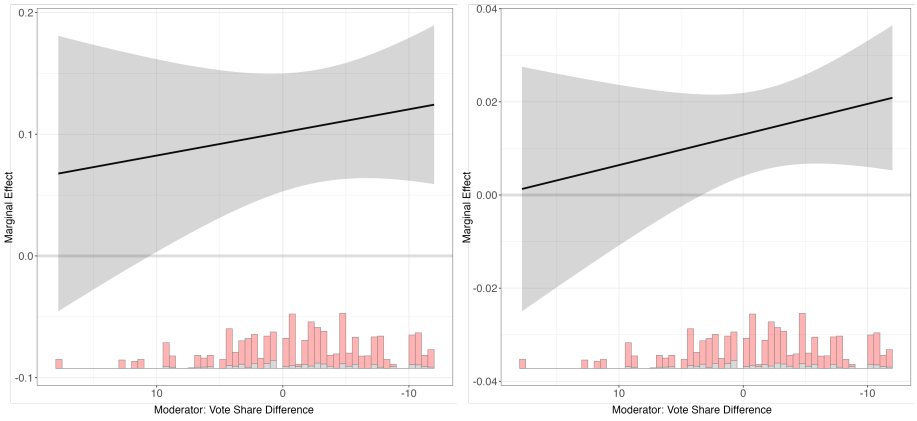
protests with an increasing number of press releases. However, for the weekly share of press releases on the environment, the moderating effect of difference in vote share is only statistically significantly different from zero for parties which experienced vote loss in the last elections - providing empirical support for hypothesis 3. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures illustrate that common support is only a potential problem for very high electoral gains, where observations are scarce. However, robustness checks illustrate that the findings are partly model-dependent; using a binned estimator, where the moderator is broken up into several bins, shows no significant difference from the results presented below.[11] However, a kernel smoothing estimator which allows for flexible estimates of the functional form of the marginal effect of protest exposure on press releases across the values of vote share differences by estimating a series of local effects with kernel re-weighting scheme (Hainmueller et al., 2019), shows that the results only hold for parties which lost a significant amount of votes in previous elections. [12] Additional analysis with the difference in seat share - which might be a better indicator of how electoral volatility affects parties - yielded the same results.[13]

[11] See models with binned estimator in figure B.27 in appendix.

[12] See figure B.28in appendix.

[13] See figure B.26 in the appendix.

Figure 5.8: Marginal effect of FFF - moderated by difference in vote share




(a) Number of P.R.s on Env.

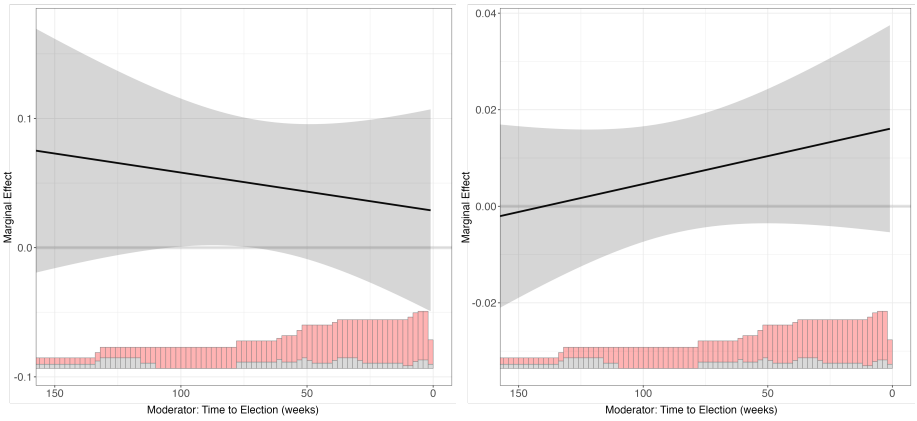
(b) Share of P.R.s on Env.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on difference in vote share parties experienced in previous elections using a conventional linear interaction model with 95% confidence intervals in grey. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

To test the final hypothesis of this chapter on the potential moderating effect of temporal proximity to elections on FFF's agenda-setting effect, the time to election in weeks was constructed into a variable starting 150 weeks prior to the local elections. Figure 5.9 displays the marginal effect from the interaction model. Contrary to theoretical expectations, the effect of FFF protests on parties' political communication does not depend on the time to the next elections and at no point is the interaction effect statistically different from zero. These null findings are robust for different model specifications.[14]

[14] See figure B.29 and figure B.30 in appendix.

Figure 5.9: Marginal effect of FFF - moderated by time to elections




(a) Number of P.R.s on Env. (b) Share of P.R.s on Env.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on temporal proximity to next elections using a conventional linear interaction model with 95% confidence intervals in grey. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

## Alternative explanations

To explore the extent to which the null findings might be the result of the selection of the outcome variable or the sample specification, further analyses were conducted. First, instead of only including press releases on the environment, press releases on energy were also included. Changes in energy policies are a key policy field in fighting climate change (Jean-Baptiste and Ducroux, 2003). Although the FFF movement is primarily focused on fighting global warming and does not protest against specific infrastructure projects like many other environmental protests, parties might publish press releases on renewable energy, climate-friendly energy sources, or criticise environmentally harmful energy sources in response to the protest mobilisation. However, analysis with this extended outcome variable did not yield substantially different results.[15]

Second, the null effect might also be explained by the aggregated approach including all parties which masks other important party differences. To explore

[15]See figures B.37 to B.41 in appendix for this chapter.

whether parties' variation in responsiveness to FFF protests might be explained through party characteristics like their left-right position or issue ownership, sub-sample analyses for each party were conducted. However, no significant overall trend of responsiveness along ideological lines could be detected. While the Green Party and the Left Party showed no increase in press releases on the environment following a protest event, a protest event had a positive and statistically significant effect on the number of questions for the SPD - albeit only three weeks and six weeks after the protest took place. Interestingly, the share of press releases on the environment also increased in the third week following a protest for the AfD, an effect which only dissipated two weeks later. However, the effect is very small, accounting for about a 1 % increase in the share of press releases.[16]

Third, while the FFF protests might not have an agenda-setting effect, parties might respond to the protests in a different way - like referring directly to the protests. In fact, (Schürmann, 2023) found that while German MPs were not more likely to increase the attention on the environment in their social media posts, they did refer more to the movement in states where more protests took place. To investigate this, a dictionary with terms frequently referred to in connection with the movement (see list of keywords in table B.1 in appendix) and the descriptive statistics for parties referring to the movement were explored. Overall, there is very low frequency of references to the movement. For example, the state with the highest share of press releases which refers to the movement is Hamburg, and the share is only slightly higher than 0.3 % of all press releases in the state.[17] While the descriptive statistics for the dictionary coding provide some empirical support for the hypotheses on parties' varying electoral incentives - with opposition parties, for example, referring more to the movement than government parties - the share of press releases overall is minuscule.[18]

Finally, the analysis includes all protests the FFF movement reports to have hosted. The literature on the political outcomes of protests and social move-

[16] See figures B.31 to B.36 in appendix.
[17] See figure B.48 in appendix.
[18] See figure B.49 to figure B.51 in the appendix.

ments has underlined the importance of the media as a mediator (Koopmans, 2004; Gamson and Wolfsfeld, 1993). While the existing data does not provide information on whether the media reported on the protests, protests in larger cities - where they can be more disruptive and observed by more bystanders - can be expected to be more successful in securing the attention of the media and lawmakers. To explore the possibility of the null findings of the chapter being driven by protests in small towns, a separate analysis only with protests in large German cities was conducted.[19] Again, the results are not substantially different results from the main analysis.[20]

## Discussion and Conclusion

When do political parties respond to protests? This chapter set out to identify the party characteristics which moderate parties' willingness to engage with protests' claims. Drawing on theoretical insights from the literature on democratic responsiveness, the chapter investigated the effect of governmental status, electoral vulnerability, and the temporal proximity to elections on the agenda-setting effect of FFF protests on regional parties in Germany. By exploring protests as a signal of public opinion to which parties could respond to, the chapter contributes to the literature on the democratic responsiveness of political elites while enhancing our understanding of the political consequences of protest mobilisation.

Overall, the empirical analysis finds very little evidence of an agenda-setting effect of FFF protests on the regional level in Germany. However, while neither the opposition status nor the temporal proximity of parties has any effect on parties' responsiveness, parties which experienced exceptionally large electoral losses in previous elections are particularly likely to respond to protest with an increase in the weekly share of questions on the environment. Moreover, additional analysis revealed that in contrast to a large strand of the literature on social movements and institutional allies, parties on the Left are not more

[19]The cities are selected according to the German administrative unit 'Kreisfreie Städte', of which Germany currently has 109.

[20]See from figure B.52 to figure B.56 in the appendix for this chapter.

likely to respond to FFF protests compared to parties on the Right. The findings underline the particularity of the circumstances required for parties to openly embrace protest mobilisation.

The FFF movement and parties' democratic responsiveness more generally has been studied a great deal, and the difference in the findings of this chapter and the findings of prior studies might reveal important context for the political consequences of protests. While Schürmann (2023) and Barrie et al. (2023) both find some effect of the FFF movement, both studies explored individual MPs online communication. The difference might indicate that while individual MP's show their support for protest movements, the party as a unitary actor does not. The difference might also stem from press releases not being the preferred avenue of parties to respond to protests. On the one hand, press releases have numerous empirical advantages over other formats of party communications and scholars have found evidence of a dynamic issue competition in parties' press release (Erfort et al., 2023; Gessler and Hunger, 2022). On the other hand, press releases might already be too formal a platform for responsiveness to protests. The question of whether political parties are responsive to street mobilisation in their online communication as unitary actors opens up avenues for future research. Moreover, the plethora of literature which has investigated parties' democratic responsiveness has primarily focused on public opinion in the form of opinion polls or referendums. While political protests can be considered a strong and unambiguous signal of public opinion it seems that the existing theoretical insights on democratic responsiveness offer a limited understanding of *why* and *when* political elites respond to protests.

Overall, the findings indicate that parties are only responsive to street mobilisation when they are particularly electorally vulnerable. However, to explore if the results might be driven by an alternative explanation, the results were replicated using only protests in large cities. However, these protest characteristics did not change the main findings. Moreover, an investigation of individual parties' responses or whether parties referred directly to the movement instead of increasing the attention on the environment did not yield different findings.

While the findings carry important implications for future research on protests'

political consequences and parties' democratic responsiveness, the chapter has some limitations. First, the analytical focus of the chapter is primarily on the amount of attention parties pay to the environment following an FFF protest. Consequently, little can be said about *how* parties talk about the environment and if that changes following a protest mobilisation. Second, while the chapter focuses on the regional level in Germany, the null effect might be driven by national coordination on the party level - rendering local protests powerless. Third, with the theoretical focus on responsiveness on the party level, the findings do not exclude the potential of external debates *within* the parties.

Despite these limitations, the chapter contributes to the literature in three important ways. First, the analysis shows that even the largest and best-organised political movements do not necessarily have an agenda-setting effect on political elites once disaggregated and primarily focused on movements' protest activities. Scholars of social movements have often made broad and bold claims about the success of large environmental movements without really defining what success looks like or to which movement activities they can be attributed to. Second, political protests are a sign of public opinion and future research on the democratic responsiveness of political elites needs to extend its theoretical toolbox to explore responsiveness to protests. Finally, the chapter contributes to the literature on the political consequences of protests by identifying important characteristics of parties which contribute to their willingness to respond to the protests' demands. The findings and the limitations of the chapter open up new avenues for future research - which should focus not only on the agenda-setting power of protests, but also on their potential to change the discourse around their issue, and their capacity to spark inter-party conflicts.

# Chapter 6

# Linking responsiveness back to voters

The two previous chapters have illustrated the limited extent of political parties' responsiveness to protest mobilisation. Overall, political parties do not respond with increased issue attention in parliament, or in their press releases. This chapter will now examine the electoral consequences of party responsiveness to protests - or indeed the lack of it. The theoretical assumption underpinning most scholarship on the political consequences of party responsiveness is that it is rooted in electoral considerations (See e.g. Lohmann, 1993; Burstein and Linton, 2002; Uba, 2009; Luders, 2006). This aligns with the central contention of this thesis, namely that political parties' responsiveness is primarily motivated by their attempts to appeal to protesters as voters, or to the broader electorate that supports the protests. Following this logic, voters should either punish or reward politicians for their responsiveness to protests. However, this link between protest mobilisation, responsiveness and voting behaviour has not been empirically explored, and we know very little about how and if voters expect their representatives to be responsive to protests.

This chapter moves away from parties as the dependent variable, shifting the focus onto voters. Using an online survey experiment conducted in Germany, the

chapter attempts to establish whether voters reward or punish political parties for their responsiveness to protests. To explore this aspect of the relationship between voters and parties, the chapter departs from issue salience as a form of responsiveness, focusing instead on ideological congruence. While a party choosing to emphasise a given issue following a protest can represent a form of democratic responsiveness, emphasis alone does not always provide the full picture of the ideological alignment between the protest and the party. This chapter uses the spatial model (Downs, 1957) to explore the link between party responsiveness, protests and voters in more detail, as this model accounts for parties not only addressing the issue raised by the protest, but also taking a policy position on (for or against). According to the spatial model, parties are considered responsive to protests when they take a congruent position with the protest. Similarly, parties are considered unresponsive to protests if they take an incongruent position with the protest. Following the classic spatial model, voters are expected to be less likely to vote for parties that diverge from them ideologically, while they are expected to be more likely to vote for parties that move ideologically closer to them. However, in addition to voters' issue preferences, protests can provide additional democratic expectations for parties to respond, as they can be understood as a clear signal of public opinion.

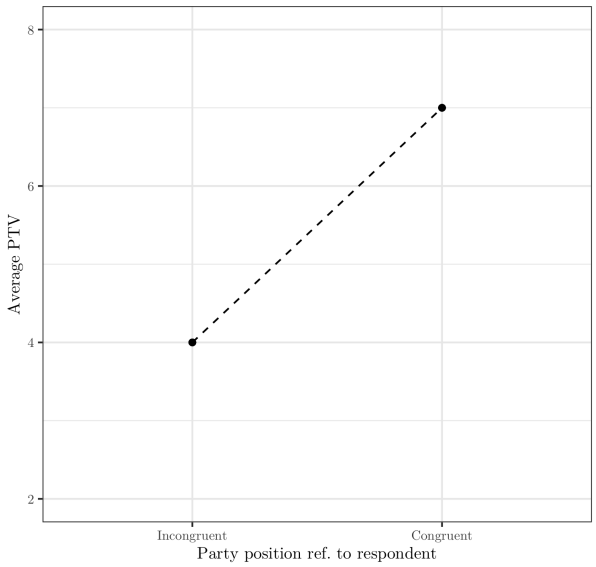
The chapter begins by elaborating the specific theoretical assumptions on which it is based. This is followed by an overview of the research design and the experimental setup. The findings from the survey experiment are then presented. While the results find empirical support for the standard theory of spatial voting, parties' responsiveness to protests has little to add to that story - regardless of whether the voters positionally agree with the protesters or not. The negative effect of ideological divergence on respondents' propensity to vote for the party in question is not exacerbated or weakened by the presence of a protest. This means that party responsiveness to protests does not have any electoral consequences. These findings have important implications for the role of protest in today's democracies, and for future research on elites' responsiveness to street mobilisation.

# Protest mobilisation, party strategies, and voters' expectations

To disentangle voters' preferences on party responsiveness to protests from their own issue preferences, this chapter adopts the spatial model of the voter-party relationship. To recap, the spatial model assumes that voters hold pre-existing, exogenous policy preferences that guide their vote choices. Voters reward parties for ideological congruence by casting their vote for the party, while they punish parties which move ideologically away from them on an issue dimension by being less likely to vote for the party. The spatial logic which underpins the theoretical assumptions of this chapter is summarised in the following hypothesis and displayed in figure 6.1:

HYP1 - *Baseline hypothesis: Voters are less likely to vote for a party which is ideologically incongruent with them in comparison to a party which is ideologically congruent with them.*

Figure 6.1: Relationship between voting and ideological congruence




**Note:** *The figure displays the hypothesised predicted values of PTV dependent on ideological congruence between the party and the voter.*

Assuming ideological congruence influences voting behaviour, the next question is whether this process is affected by the presence of a protest and the nature of parties' responsiveness. The definition of protests' core characteristics in Chapter 2 and the theoretical framework established in Chapter 3 offer some support for the idea that party responsiveness to protests should fundamentally matter to voters. Throughout this thesis, protests have been conceptualised as a public and collective expression of grievances, claims, and concerns (Snow et al., 2019). They signal to voters and representatives which issues need to be prioritised, which issues have not been sufficiently addressed, and who is to be held accountable (Lohmann, 1993). Protest mobilisation can be informative to voters as it reveals their peers' political attitudes to certain issues (Lee, 2002) and suggests how many of a given population consider the issue important. By taking to the streets, protesters transform their personal, individual policy positions into a public signal (Lohmann, 1993). This can be expected to affect the *personal* relationship between voter and party, as it reveals to the voter the willingness and capacity of the party to listen to a clear signal of *public* opinion. One of the central democratic functions of political parties and their role in democracies is to be responsive to public opinion and voters' preferences (Bardi et al., 2015). If voters acknowledge protests as an important public opinion signal beyond their own policy preferences, we can expect party responsiveness to protests to matter to them. However, the ideological congruence between voter and a party is still expected to play a crucial role in influencing voters' intentions. Experimental evidence suggests that while voters do appreciate responsive representatives (Esaiasson et al., 2017) they also prioritise outcome favourability over democratic expectations (Christensen et al., 2020; Esaiasson et al., 2019).

Bringing together ideological congruence and responsiveness to protests leads to the following theoretical assumption: Responsiveness does not necessarily amplify the positive effects of congruence between party and voter on voting behaviour, but it may lesson the negative effects of incongruence between party and voter.

For example: If party A signals incongruence to a voter by being responsive

to a protest with which the voter disagrees, it is still being democratically responsive - and this might limit negative effects of ideological incongruence on voting propensity. Conversely, if party B signals a congruent position to a voter by criticising a protest with which the voter disagrees, they may find that the positive effects of this congruence are weakened - because it is not supported by democratic responsiveness. To complete the picture, one must consider the inverse scenarios. Rather than embracing a protest disliked by its voters like party A did, party C could opt to publicly criticise a protest supported by its voters. This would make party C incongruent and democratically unresponsive, exacerbating the negative effects of ideological incongruence on voters' propensity to vote for that party. Finally, party D could signal congruence with the voter by embracing the message of a protest the voter agrees with, i.e. a congruent protest - thus combining congruence with responsiveness and (potentially) amplifying the positive effect of ideological congruence on voters' propensity to vote for the party.

Table 6.1: Relationship between the voter's position, the protest position, the party position

| **Party's responsiveness** | *Incongruent* | *Congruent* |
|---|---|---|
| *Responsive* | Party **A** is incongruent with voter's position | Party **D** is congruent with voter's position |
| *Unresponsive* | Party **B** is congruent with voter's position | Party **C** is incongruent with voter's position |

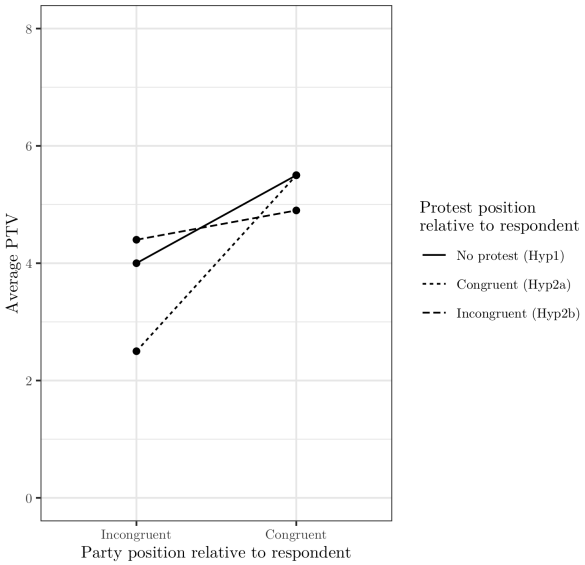
**Protest's position relative to voter**

Taken together, these scenarios broadly reflect a mechanism whereby parties are rewarded for ideological congruence and punished for ideological incongruence. This mechanism is in turn weakened by the presence of incongruent protests and strengthened by the presence of congruent protests. The two interactive hypotheses on the relationship between ideological congruence between a voter and a party and the ideological congruence between the voter and the protest are summarised as follows and illustrated in figure 6.2:

HYP2A: *The effect of ideological incongruence between a voter and a party is stronger in the presence of a protest which is congruent with the voter.*

HYP2B: *The effect of ideological incongruence between a voter and a party is weaker in the presence of a protest which is incongruent with the voter.*

Figure 6.2: Interaction between protest position and party position




**Note:** *The figure displays the hypothesised predicted values of PTV for each combination of protest and party position. The protest and the party position is always expressed in relation to the voter.*

## Research Design and experimental setup

To study the extent to which voters' electoral intentions are affected by party responsiveness to protests, a representative population-based online survey experiment with 2,500 respondents and a vignette treatment was conducted in April 2023 in Germany.[1] A survey experiment was chosen as the most suitable research design to answer this question for a multitude of reasons. First, observational data on the different factors would be hard to find. Not only would the analysis require data on party responsiveness to protests, but also fine-grained survey data on respondents' propensity to vote for the responding party and the respondents' opinion on the protest in question. Panel studies, for example, are usually conducted at intervals of a few years - a time-frame in which many things can change. Second, even if such data existed there would still be many moving parts: the protests' characteristics and tactics, the formulation of the party responsiveness, the general political climate, and other important events. Consequently, it would be difficult to causally estimate the effect of party responsiveness to protests on voting behaviour using observational data.

Experiments are the gold standard for inferring causality and excluding spurious relationships. By using a representative survey experiment, important factors can be made to co-vary, third variables - like protest's characteristics - can be held constant, and the cause precedes the outcome by design (Mutz, 2011). The experiment implemented in this study is a between-subjects design and took the form of a 2x3x2 factorial design, randomising the party position, the protest position, and the party in the vignette. The policy issue of the vignette was the trade-off between environmental protection and economic growth. Moreover, existing German parties were used in the vignettes. These two design choices will elaborated in more detail later in this chapter. Table 6.2 provides an overview of the factors and conditions.

The experimental setup is illustrated in figure 6.3. The experiment was set

[1] The experiment was pre-registered in OSF and received approval by the Ethics committee of the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences of the Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin. The pre-registration plan can be found in the supplementary material for this chapter. Further discussion and justification for the sample size can be found in the appendix.

Table 6.2: Overview of factors and conditions

| Factors | Conditions |
|---|---|
| **Party position** | *Pro environment, Pro economy* |
| **Protest position** | *No protest, Pro environment, Pro economy* |
| **Party** | *SPD, CDU* |

up as follows: First, the respondents were asked for their consent to participate in the experiment. They then completed the pre-treatment survey. The questionnaire included conventional items on political interest, experience with unconventional forms of participation, past vote choice, left-right placement, partisan identity, and issue importance. The items were primarily adopted from the German electoral studies (GLES, 2021, 2022a,b). To measure their position on the trade-off between the environment and the economy, respondents were asked in the pre-treatment survey if they think that environmental protection should take precedence over economic growth or vice versa.[2] While an extensive academic debate exists on the optimal number of alternatives for the Likert-scale (Leung, 2011, see an overview of the debate in ), a 4-point Likert-scale with anchored end-points was selected for this question. This was done to reduce variance - as a simple pro/contra position to the protest was required - and to avoid a neutral point. The respondents were provided with a "don't know" option, but if they chose it they were prompted to answer the question again with a different wording for the "don't know" option ("I really don't know"). Those who chose "I really don't know" were dropped from the survey.

After the pre-treatment survey, the respondents received a vignette. The control group's vignettes did not include any protests. Instead, they just included a short primer on the trade-off between environmental protection and economic growth and a randomised party and party position on that trade-

[2]Wording of question adapted to an item from GLES (GLES, 2021).

off (pro-economy or pro-environment). The treatment groups received the same primer on the trade-off between environmental protection and economic growth. Their vignette also included a paragraph on a protest that is either rallying around environmental or economic issues. The last paragraph in the treatment group's vignette included a party that is either criticising or voicing support for the protest - thus taking a position on the trade-off between the environment and economic growth. While the assignment of respondents into treatment and control groups was completely random, the party featured in the vignette utilised blocked random assignment based on past vote choice. This means that the randomisation between the CDU/CSU and the SPD was done within each voter group (e.g. within FDP voters or SPD voters), resulting in the party conditions containing roughly the same proportion of each voter group. Blocking on a variable that is a strong indicator of the outcome - like past vote choice is for PTV (van der Eijk et al., 2006) - can improve the precision of the estimate and assures that the treatment effect is not driven by an imbalance in the sample within the party treatment conditions (Gerber and Green, 2012).

Following the vignette, the respondents were asked to fill out the post-treatment survey with the outcome variables, manipulation checks and questions on the mechanism. The primary outcome variable of interest is a standard item on voting behaviour - the propensity to vote for a party (PTV). The PTV was measured on a 10-point scale with anchored endpoints ("I will certainly never vote for this party" and "I will certainly vote for this party at some time.) To avoid any bias introduced by a single-item measure of the outcome (Mutz, 2011), the respondents' attitudes to the party's responsiveness, and how capable they perceived the party in the vignette in dealing with the environment and the economy were measured as additional outcomes. By measuring secondary outcomes, the experiment accounted for the potential of protest and party behaviour not affecting political behaviour, but attitudes.

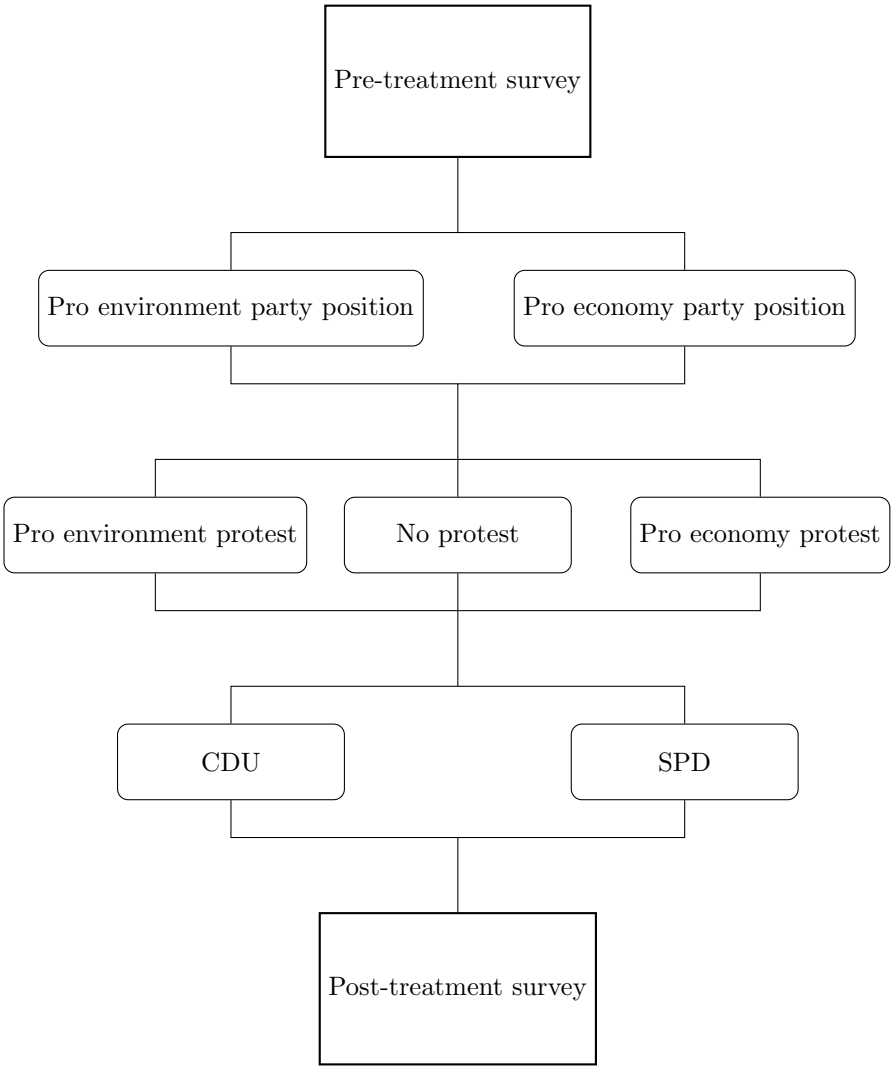
While the hypothesised effects were expected to work similarly for attitudes and political behaviour, the secondary outcome variables were expected to be easier to manipulate compared to voting behaviour. The additional outcomes were measured with the questions "To what degree do you think that the party

adequately represents the public opinion", and "How suited do you find the party in dealing with the issue of environmental protection/deal with the economy" where the respondents were given a 1 to 10 point scale with anchored end points.

Following the questions on the outcome variables, the respondents were asked a few questions relating to the potential mechanisms linking responsiveness to protests to voting behaviour. These included questions on identification with the protesters, support for the protest cause, and whether the respondents believed that regular citizens should be able to exert influence on political parties. To measure if the respondents had been persuaded by the protests, the question of their policy preferences on economic growth vs. environmental protection was repeated. While the mechanisms cannot be causally identified, as these factors are not randomised and are asked after the outcome, the questions provide some observational insights. Finally, the respondents were asked multiple questions on the treatment to explore whether they had properly received the treatment, i.e. read and understood the vignette. Finally, the respondents were debriefed with a short statement.[3]

[3]The whole questionnaire can be found in German in the supplementary material for this chapter. The primary variables of interest (outcomes and manipulation checks can be found in English in the pre-registration plan in the supplementary material).

Figure 6.3: Overview for the experimental setup



## The vignette

While experiments are particularly good for causally estimating the relationship between cause and effect, the design of a vignette treatment has to be carefully considered to ensure external validity and enough variance in the outcome of interest. The topic of the experiment, the wording of the vignette, and the parties included in the experiment were all chosen with this in mind. First, real parties were included in the study, as the primary outcome of interest is the propensity to vote for the party in the vignette. It is hard to infer what respondents' propensity to vote for a fictional party might mean for the real world, and the external validity of the experiment would be considerably decreased. Second, the CDU/CSU and the SPD were chosen to provide variance in ideology, parties' characteristics, and popularity. This would warrant enough variance in the outcome of interest, as well as ensuring the treatment effect is not driven by the peculiarities of the party selection and allowed the results to be generalisable for other parties. The parties represent an opposition and governmental party and cover both the right and the left side of the ideological spectrum.

However, the inclusion of real parties does not alone increase external validity. Rather, it is crucial to combine the parties selected with a policy issue on which their position can realistically be randomised. An experiment without realistic party behaviour risks disengaged and potentially frustrated subjects which will result in a critical dynamic and threaten the internal validity of the study (McDermott, 2011). The topic needed to present a realistic issue on which the parties could theoretically take a support or critical position on without appearing absurd to the respondent. The issue of environmental protection vs. economic growth was selected with these criteria in mind. An exploration of the most recent party manifestos and party websites reveals that all parties include sections on environmental protection and economic growth. For example, the proportion of the manifestos for the 2021 elections dedicated to the environment and climate change mitigation ranges from 2.5 % in the AfD's manifesto to almost 8 % in the Green Party's manifesto (Lehmann et al., 2023). While parties state their dedication to the environment, their reference to the economy

or the environment often reflects the potential cost of environmental policies. The CDU, for example, included the following sentence on the environment in their policy program on their website: "We always think environmental and climate protection together with economic and social development. We put a price tag on emissions. We rely on new and clean technologies instead of bans." (CDU, 2023). Similarly, the SPD refers to the need for structural support and the creation of new jobs in regions that are affected by the closing of mining areas (SPD, 2021, p. 9). While the party manifestos do not take a clear position prioritising one issue over the other - and they even often combine both - the existence of both issue positions in their policies allows for more realistic position-taking. In addition to both parties being able to take both positions realistically, the most recent wave of the German longitudinal electoral survey reveals that voters are distributed across the spectrum on the question of prioritising economic growth or climate change mitigation - however, with a stronger tendency for voters to priorities climate change (almost 45 % of the sample) or to select the neutral middle point (about 30 % of the sample) (GLES, 2021).

Finally, the vignette needs to strike a balance between providing enough information on the protest in question without tiring the respondents. The protest in the vignette will be in support of environmental protection or the economy. The vignette tries to provide comprehensive information about the protests so that respondents do not have to 'fill in the gaps' with their own preconceptions about a protest mobilisation on such an issue. This involves providing information on size, tactics (the protest was peaceful), and stating that the protest was frequented by actors from across the political spectrum. Moreover, this additional information means that the protest can be considered a most likely case, as studies have shown that large, peaceful protests with diverse actors are most likely to engender support from bystanders (Wouters, 2019). The respondents were also required to answer questions on the protest in question to make sure the treatment was received as intended. Figure 6.4 exemplifies an English translation of a treatment with an environmental protest and a party with a pro-economy position (all vignettes can be found in German in the questionnaire in the supplementary materials).

Figure 6.4: Example vignette

We will now present to you a brief text. Please read the text carefully. Imagine the following scenario:

**The economy and environmental protection**

*Public debates often presents economic growth and measures to protect the environment as a trade-off. On the one hand, it is argued that environmental protection measures can be costly and regulations can be damaging for the economy. On the other hand, it is argued that economic growth often comes at the cost of natural resources, the health of the environment, and the climate.*

**Environmental protest in front of the German Parliament**

*This idea about a trade-off between environmental protection and economic growth can also been found in public debates. For example, several thousand people from across the political spectrum gathered to protest in Berlin last Saturday and demanded leaders to take stronger action to protect the environment. Organisers said the protest aimed to highlight the emergency of the world's declining biodiversity and they hope to build up pressure for political parties to take the problem seriously. Many protesters carried signs and placards reading "Protect nature – before it's too late" and banners saying "Sustainability instead of greed and growth". The peaceful march ended in front of the German parliament.*

**The [PARTY] criticises the protest**

*Following the protest,* [PARTY] *published a press release where the party criticised the protests. "We do not agree with the participants and we believe that efforts should be invested in fighting rising living costs.*

## Estimation

To test the theoretical assumptions of the chapter, the party position and the protest position will be coded as being either congruent or incongruent with the respondents' position on the environment and the economy from the pre-treatment survey. An OLS regression will then be used with the propensity to vote for the party in the vignette as the outcome variable. The model below

displays the regression equation to test HY1, where the $i$ stands for respondents 1,...,$n$ and the $\alpha$ represents the average PTV for respondents who have received a vignette without any protest and a party position which is congruent with their issue position. The theoretical framework does not assume any heterogeneous treatment effect dependent on the specific party in the vignette, so the party sub-groups will be pooled.[4] The baseline hypothesis of the paper would be supported by the data if the coefficient from the regression is negative.

$$\begin{aligned} \text{PTV}_i = \alpha &+ \beta_1 \text{Party incon} \quad (\textit{Hyp1}) \\ &+ \epsilon_i \end{aligned} \tag{6.1}$$

To test H2a and H2b an OLS regression with an interaction term between the party position and the protest position will be used. As with the first model, the parties will be pooled. The primary coefficients of interest for hypotheses 2a and 2b are the interaction terms. Hypothesis 2a would be supported by the data if coefficient $\beta 3$ is negative and hypothesis 2b if coefficient $\beta$ 5 is positive.

$$\begin{aligned} \text{PTV}_i = \alpha &+ \beta_1 \text{Party incon} && (\textit{Hyp1}) \\ &+ \beta_2 \text{Protest con} \\ &+ \beta_3 \text{Party incon*Protest con} && (\textit{Hyp2a}) \\ &+ \beta_4 \text{Protest incongruent} \\ &+ \beta_5 \text{Party incongruence*Protest incongruence} && (\textit{Hyp2b}) \\ &+ \epsilon_i \end{aligned} \tag{6.2}$$

Any potential heterogeneous treatment effect across respondents, parties, and the protest's issue and the mechanisms will be investigated via exploratory analysis. Moreover, robustness checks will include models with (a) party-fixed effects to account for any potential unobserved heterogeneity across parties and (b) issue protest fixed effect, i.e. whether the respondent received a vignette with an environmental protest or economic protest. Randomisation checks will

[4] See table C.10 for the full models with party-fixed effects and issue-fixed effects.

be performed to ensure that the six groups (protest position*party position) of respondents are similar regarding the following variables: age, gender, education, left-right placement and the federal state in which the respondent currently lives. In case of imbalance, the main models will be re-run with controls. [5] As a final robustness check, respondents who did not pass the central manipulation checks will be excluded. The reasons for including these respondents in the main analysis but excluding them in the robustness check are; a) the manipulation checks are seven questions after the treatment and can only be indicative of respondents' perception of the treatment, b) as all of the manipulation checks are post-treatment items, making the exclusion too restrictive could imbalance the sample with respect to observed or unobserved co-founders (Montgomery et al., 2018), c) with so many manipulation items, strict exclusion is likely to result in a sample which is too small.[6]

## Results

Prior to analysing the effect of party responsiveness to protests on respondents' propensity to vote for the party in the vignette, multiple chi-square tests between demographic variables and the six vignettes were conducted to ensure the randomisation was successful.[7] The outcome variable - respondents' propensity to vote for the party in the vignette - is not normally distributed. Rather, a large portion of voters say they would never vote for the party in the vignette as can be seen in figure 6.5. Similar tendencies are detected for the secondary outcome variables. [8]

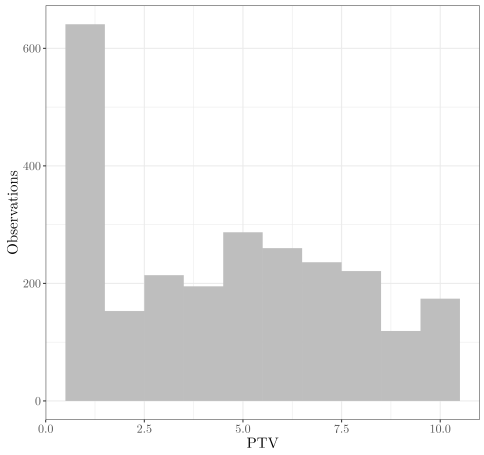
[5] See table C.10 in the appendix for results with all controls and party fixed effects.

[6] More details on the research design choices can be found in the pre-analysis plan.

[7] The chi-square tests were also conducted for the 12 conditions (2x3x2) i.e. multiplying the vignettes with the two parties. While the chi-square tests revealed no statistical relationship between any demographic variables and the six vignettes, there was some correlation detected between the 12 conditions and gender and the federal state. For this reason, all robustness tests include gender and federal state as control variables as well.

[8] see figure C.1 in supplementary material section for this chapter.

Figure 6.5: Distribution of the propensity to vote for the party in the vignette



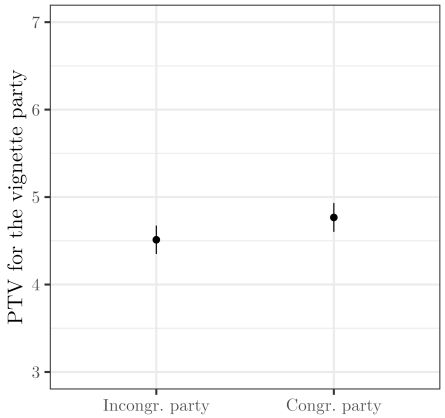

**Note:** *The figure displays the absolute number of respondents for each value on the primary outcome variable - the propensity to vote for the party in the vignette.*

Figure 6.6 displays the average treatment effect of parties' ideological issue incongruence on respondents' PTVs using the full sample. Respondents who received a vignette with an incongruent party position have a 0.25 lower PTV on average compared to respondents who received vignettes with a congruent party position. While the effect is statistically significant at the 5 % level, it is very small - or only 0.08 of a standard deviation. Although this small effect might stem from voting behaviour being hard to change, further analysis reveals no effect of ideological incongruence on the secondary outcome variables.[9] Despite the small effect, the analysis of the full sample provides only weak empirical support for the first hypothesis that ideological incongruence has a negative effect on voters' PTV.

To answer the question of whether voters will punish or reward parties for responsiveness to protests, a regression with an interaction term between the party position and protest position was calculated. Figure 6.7 shows the predicted values of PTV for each condition and table 6.3 displays the outcome from the regression model. Although the effect of party responsiveness to protests

[9] see figure C.2 in the appendix.

Figure 6.6: Average treatment effect - PTV

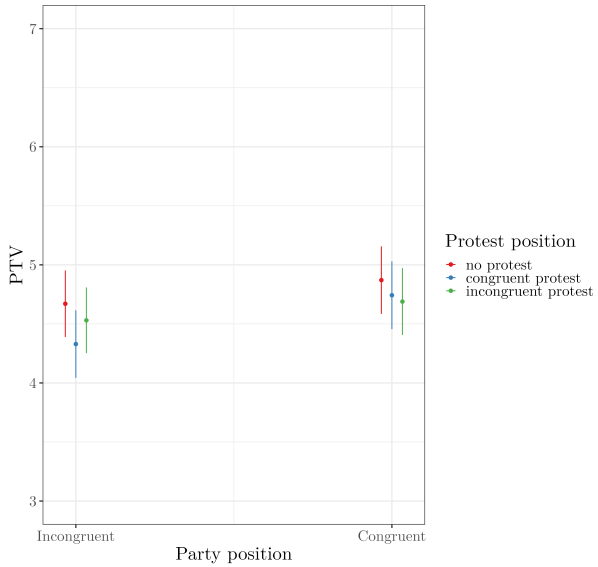



**Note:** *The figure displays the average treatment effect of party position on PTV with 95% confidence intervals using the full sample of respondents.*

shows change in the expected direction, the interaction terms are statistically insignificant. The predicted values for each condition illustrate that the effect of ideological incongruence differs slightly between the protest conditions. The condition where a party takes an incongruent position with the voter and a protest the voter agrees with has the most negative effect on the respondents' PTVs. However, the group means are not statistically significant from one another.[10]

[10]See table C.1 for the results from a Tukey Honest significant difference test the in appendix. The test is commonly used to assess if there is a statistically significant difference between pairs of group means.(See further information in Hervé and Williams, 2010)

Figure 6.7: Predicted PTV - Full model




**Note:** *The figures displays the predicted PTV for each combination of protest and party position with a 95% confidence intervals using the full sample of respondents. The protest and the party position is always expressed in relation to the voter.*

Moreover, once the protest conditions are included in the model, the main effect of ideological incongruence on respondents' PTVs becomes statistically insignificant and decreases down to 0.2 points PTV. This change indicates that the negative effect from the baseline model was primarily driven by the protest condition. Further analysis of the secondary outcome variables does not lead to different results.[11] Overall, these findings indicate that respondents' voting behaviour is not affected by party responsiveness to protests.

[11] See figure C.3 and tables C.2 to C.4 in appendix.

Table 6.3: Full sample - Main analysis

| | *PTV* | |
|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | −0.255** | −0.200 |
| | (0.118) | (0.205) |
| Congruent protest | | −0.128 |
| | | (0.206) |
| Incongruent protest | | −0.182 |
| | | (0.205) |
| Incong. party*Cong. protest | | −0.213 |
| | | (0.291) |
| Incong. party*Incong. protest | | 0.041 |
| | | (0.288) |
| Constant | 4.767*** | 4.871*** |
| | (0.084) | (0.146) |
| Observations | 2,500 | 2,500 |
| $R^2$ | 0.002 | 0.003 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.001 | 0.001 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the whole sample of respondents. The PTV for the party of the vignette is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

## Additional analysis

While the overall population does not seem to be affected by party responsiveness to protests, certain groups might be more affected than others. Scholars have often found partisans' voting behaviour and attitudes particularly hard to move (Bartels, 2000; Huddy and Bankert, 2017; Tilley and Hobolt, 2011; Kayser and Wlezien, 2011). Respondents with strong partisan ties either to the party in the vignette or other parties would result in a potential flooring or ceiling effect for the outcome: Partisans of other parties would never consider voting for the party in the vignette, whereas partisans of the party in the vignette would always report to vote for the party. Additionally, scholars have found conservative-liberal bias for support for protests as a form of participation

(Barker et al., 2021; McCright and Dunlap, 2008; Bernhagen and Marsh, 2007; Torcal et al., 2016; van der Meer et al., 2009). Finally, voters might have to care strongly about the issue in question to be affected by ideological incongruence and party responsiveness to protests.

However, an exploratory analysis of potential heterogeneous treatment effects does not reveal any interesting variation dependent on any of those attitudes or characteristics. Sub-sample analyses i) excluding respondents with strong partisan ties to any party[12], ii) only with respondents who find the issue of environment and the economy very important[13], or iii) analysis separately for left-leaning or right-leaning respondents[14] do not change the main conclusion that voters' electoral considerations are not affected by party responsiveness to protests.[15]

Experiments can give an accurate estimation of the relationship between cause and effect, but one has to exclude the possibility of the results being driven by research design choices. Perhaps the null results for the party responsiveness to protests are explained by respondents not actually receiving the treatment they were assigned. While respondents could not skip the vignette, their assignment into the treatment group does not automatically result in them being treated. Text vignettes are unobtrusive and require a degree of focus and attention by the respondents if their message is to be properly understood (Mutz, 2011).

To explore the extent to which the results are driven by inattentive and untreated respondents, the sample was restricted to respondents who passed the central manipulation tests. This excludes respondents who a) in the control group were unable to name the position of the party and b) in the protest vignettes were unable to recall the right party in the vignette and the party's responsiveness (criticise or agree) to the protest.[16] Restricting the sample to those

[12]See table C.5 in the appendix.

[13]See table C.6 in the appendix.

[14]See table C.7 in the appendix.

[15]See tables C.8 and C.9 for analysis of heterogeneous treatment effect for the secondary outcome variables and table C.10 for models with controls for robustness-checks.

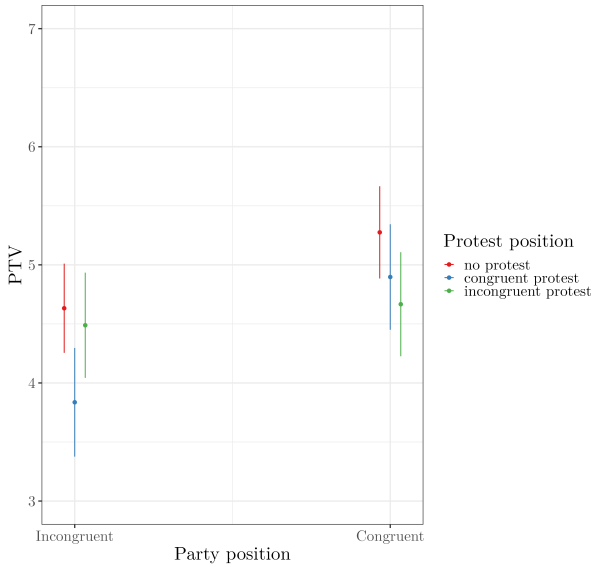
[16]See table for an overview of the manipulation checks.

respondents who passed manipulation checks creates several problems. First, the sample size is halved, with only 1170 respondents passing all tests. Second, the sample is no longer representative for the whole population as the respondents who passed the tests are both older and better educated.[17] Third, scholars have warned of potential biases introduced by controlling post-treatment variables (Montgomery et al., 2018). However, to investigate whether the null effect for protest truly holds for those who can be considered to be "truly treated", the analysis was re-run for this sample.

Overall, the repeated analysis for those who passed the manipulation test corroborates the findings of the main analysis. The baseline model which only includes the party's position shows that the effect of ideological incongruence on voters' PTV of the party in the vignette is statistically significant and negative as can be seen in table 6.5. The effect is stronger than in the analysis for the whole sample, and respondents who received ideologically incongruent party positions report a 0.6 point lower PTV on average for the party in the vignette compared to respondents who received ideologically congruent party positions. However, in contrast to the full sample, this effect remains stable and statistically significant once the protest condition is included in the model. Despite the treatment having a stronger effect on the respondents who carefully read the vignette, the coefficients for party responsiveness to protests remain statistically insignificant - indicating that voters' willingness to punish ideological incongruence is not exacerbated by protests. However, similar to the first model, one can see that the effect goes in the expected direction with the predicted PTV being the lowest for a party which is both ideologically incongruent with a voter and incongruent with a protest. Figure 6.7 displays the predicted PTV for each condition for the respondents who passed the manipulation checks.

[17] See table C.12 for logistic regression with a binary variable for passed or not passed as the outcome variable.

Figure 6.8: Predicted PTV - Passed manipulation checks




**Note:** *The figures displays the predicted PTV for each combination of protest and party position with a 95% confidence intervals only including respondents who passed the required manipulation checks. The protest and the party position is always expressed in relation to the voter.*

The analysis with the more attentive respondents shows that party responsiveness to protest mobilisation does not affect the propensity of the respondents to vote for the party. However, maybe changing respondents' vote choice is too hard a test of the protests' effects on the respondents. Numerous studies have shown that vote intentions are hard to change and, for example, online political messages (Coppock et al., 2022) or campaigning has been found to have very limited effect on vote choice (Kalla and Broockman, 2018). Perhaps party responsiveness affects respondents' attitudes which in the long run could in turn affect respondents' vote intentions.

Table 6.4: Passed manipulation checks - Main analysis

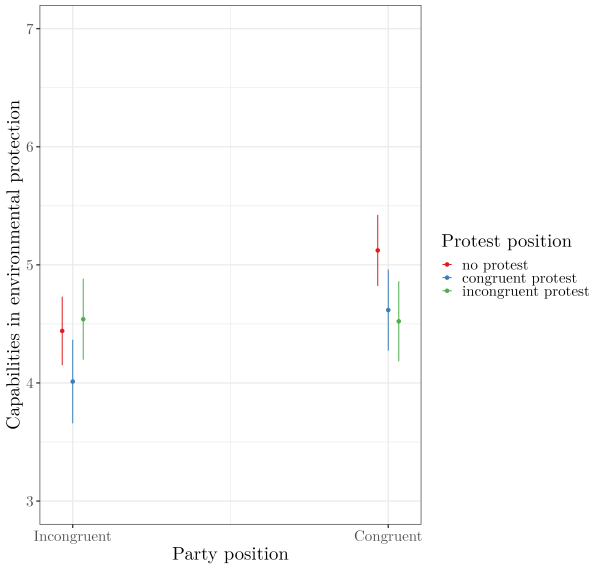
| | *PTV* | |
|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | $-0.609^{***}$ | $-0.642^{**}$ |
| | (0.177) | (0.277) |
| Congruent protest | | $-0.378$ |
| | | (0.302) |
| Incongruent protest | | $-0.608^{**}$ |
| | | (0.300) |
| Incong.party*Congr.prot. | | $-0.418$ |
| | | (0.428) |
| Incong.party*Incong.prot. | | 0.464 |
| | | (0.423) |
| Constant | $4.974^{***}$ | $5.275^{***}$ |
| | (0.125) | (0.199) |
| Observations | 1,170 | 1,170 |
| $R^2$ | 0.010 | 0.020 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.009 | 0.016 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who passed the manipulation checks. The PTV for the party of the vignette is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Tables 6.5 to 6.7 display the results for the three additional outcome variables. The analysis of the secondary outcome shows that party responsiveness to protest mobilisation has a very limited effect on respondents' attitudes. Parties' ideological incongruence has a negative effect on how representative and capable of dealing with the environment respondents perceive the party in the vignette to be. There is only one scenario in which party responsiveness has an effect; the interaction between an incongruent party position and an incongruent protest position is statistically significant on the 5 % level with respondents' perceived capability on the environment as the dependent variable. Figure 6.9 displays the predicted values for the model with perceived capabilities on the environment as outcome. The figure shows that the predicted value for incongruent protest and incongruent party position is slightly higher than if the party takes

an incongruent position and there is no protest or a protest the voter agrees with. However, with the interaction term being positive, the predicted values of incongruent protests are almost the same for each party position - meaning that the party reaction to a protest the respondents do not agree with is almost irrelevant for how capable the respondents think the party is in dealing with the environment.

Figure 6.9: Predicted capabilities on the environment - Passed man. checks




**Note:** *The figure displays the predicted perceived capabilities of the party in dealing with the environment for each combination of protest and party position with a 95% confidence intervals only including respondents who passed the required manipulation checks. The protest and the party position is always expressed in relation to the voter.*

Table 6.5: Passed sample - Secondary analysis

| | *Perceived Representation* | |
|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | $-0.386^{***}$ | $-0.428^{*}$ |
| | (0.141) | (0.221) |
| Congruent protest | | $-0.230$ |
| | | (0.242) |
| Incongruent protest | | $-0.496^{**}$ |
| | | (0.240) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | $-0.454$ |
| | | (0.342) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | 0.540 |
| | | (0.338) |
| Constant | $4.957^{***}$ | $5.179^{***}$ |
| | (0.100) | (0.159) |
| Observations | 1,170 | 1,170 |
| $R^2$ | 0.006 | 0.018 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.005 | 0.014 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who passed the manipulation checks. How well the respondents think the party in the vignette represents public opinion is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table 6.6: Passed sample - Secondary analysis

| | *Perceived capability on the env.* | |
|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | $-0.436^{***}$ | $-0.681^{***}$ |
| | (0.136) | (0.213) |
| Congruent protest | | $-0.505^{**}$ |
| | | (0.233) |
| Incongruent protest | | $-0.600^{***}$ |
| | | (0.231) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | 0.076 |
| | | (0.329) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | $0.699^{**}$ |
| | | (0.325) |
| Constant | $4.786^{***}$ | $5.122^{***}$ |
| | (0.096) | (0.153) |
| Observations | 1,170 | 1,170 |
| $R^2$ | 0.009 | 0.020 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.008 | 0.016 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who passed the manipulation checks. How capable the respondents think the party in the vignette is in dealing with the environment is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table 6.7: Passed sample - Secondary analysis

| | *Perceived capability on the economy* | |
|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | −0.255* | −0.394* |
| | (0.144) | (0.226) |
| Congruent protest | | −0.337 |
| | | (0.247) |
| Incongruent protest | | −0.507** |
| | | (0.245) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | −0.187 |
| | | (0.349) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | 0.607* |
| | | (0.345) |
| Constant | 5.594*** | 5.852*** |
| | (0.102) | (0.162) |
| Observations | 1,170 | 1,170 |
| $R^2$ | 0.003 | 0.012 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.002 | 0.008 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who passed the manipulation checks. How capable the respondents think the party in the vignette is in dealing with the economy is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

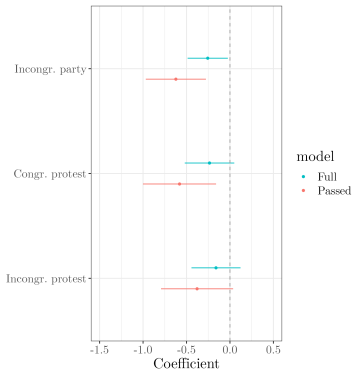
An exploratory analysis of a potential heterogeneous treatment effect for this sample results similar findings from the main analysis. While the effect of ideological incongruence is stronger on respondents' PTVs once excluding partisans[18] or those who find these issues unimportant[19], the interaction effect between protests and the party position remains statistically insignificant on voters' propensity to vote for the party in the vignette.

[18] See table C.13 in the appendix.
[19] See table C.14 in the appendix.

## Exploratory analysis

Additional analysis of the sub-sample of respondents who passed the manipulation checks reveals one interesting distinction from the full sample: The incongruent protest treatment has a consistent negative effect across the four different outcome variables - regardless of party responsiveness to the protest. For exploratory purposes, two regressions including only the direct effects of the party position and the protests were conducted: one model for the full sample and one model for the sub-sample of respondents who passed the manipulation checks. Figure 6.10 illustrates the coefficients from these two models, while table 6.8 displays the results. Again, the effect of the party position for the more attentive respondents is stronger and the direct effect of protest for the full sample is not significantly different from zero. However, the results show that for the respondents who passed the manipulation checks, the direct effect of a protest the respondents agree with is just as strong as an incongruent party position. While the effect of incongruent protest is also negative, it is only statistically significant on the 10 % level.

Figure 6.10: Coefficient plot - Direct effect of protest




**Note:** *The figure displays the estimates with 95% confidence intervals for the direct effects of party position and protest position. The baseline is a congruent party position and no protest. The light grey estimates include a model with all respondents while the dark grey estimates only include those who passed the required manipulation checks. The protest and the party position is always expressed in relation to the voter.*

Table 6.8: Direct effect of protests

| | *PTV* | |
|---|---|---|
| | Full Sample | Passed man. checks |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent Party | $-0.256^{**}$ | $-0.623^{***}$ |
| | (0.118) | (0.176) |
| Congruent protest | $-0.235$ | $-0.580^{***}$ |
| | (0.145) | (0.214) |
| Incongruent protest | $-0.161$ | $-0.378^{*}$ |
| | (0.144) | (0.211) |
| Constant | $4.899^{***}$ | $5.265^{***}$ |
| | (0.119) | (0.166) |
| Observations | 2,500 | 1,170 |
| $R^2$ | 0.003 | 0.017 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.002 | 0.014 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the whole sample of respondents and for the sample who passed the manipulation checks. The PTV for the party of the vignette is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

This direct effect of protests is very interesting, as it shows that while parties' responsiveness to protests does not affect their electoral prospects, all protest mobilisation - be it congruent or incongruent with the voter - is associated with lower PTV of attentive respondents for the party in the vignette. An explanation for this might be that political protests are a sign of dissatisfaction with the status quo or the performance of politicians, and grievances constitute one of the core elements of protesting (Klandermans, 1997). Protests are not only a signal to policymakers about what has gone astray but also to other citizens. The direct effect of protests on respondents' evaluation and propensity to vote for the party in the vignette - regardless of the parties' reaction - is perhaps a sign that respondents can be receptive to the signal protests provide. However, further analysis shows that this does not apply to all parties. Rather, it seems that congruent protest mobilisation only has a negative effect on the

PTV of the CDU. [20] While the data cannot provide answers to why this is the case, a potential explanation for the CDU being particularly affected by protest mobilisation is the party's strong association with the status quo - until 2021, the party had held the chancellor's position for sixteen years.

Finally, an alternative explanation for the null findings of the experiment might be that while voters' propensity to vote for the responding party remains unchanged, they might be more likely to vote for another party, for example, for an issue owner of the protest's issue or for a party which is ideologically close to the protest in the vignette. While the Green party is the obvious winner for the environmental protest, one could argue that the FDP - a party that emphasise innovation, technology, and the free market as a solution to climate change in their party manifesto for the German parliamentary elections in 2021 (Freie Demokraten, 2021) - presents the most likely winner for the pro-economic protest. However, an exploratory analysis with these parties as the outcome variable does show that this is only partly the case. While table 6.9 displays the regression output for vignettes with environmental protest on the propensity to vote for the Green party as the outcome variable, table 6.10 shows the regression output from vignettes with pro-economic protests and the propensity to vote for the FDP as the outcome variable.

Both regression tables highlight a link between the two protests and the electoral prospect of the Green Party and the Liberal Party: Respondents who agree with the environmental protest are more likely to vote for the Green Party and less likely to vote for the FDP compared to respondents who saw no protests. Respondents who disagree with the economic protests are also more likely to vote for the Green Party and less likely to vote for the FDP compared to respondents who did not receive any protest in their vignette.

[20] See table C.15 in appendix.

Table 6.9: Environmental protests - Exploratory analysis

| | *Dependent variable:* | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | PTV - Greens | | PTV - FDP | |
| Incongruent party | 0.284* | 0.382* | 0.050 | 0.044 |
| | (0.147) | (0.204) | (0.129) | (0.182) |
| Congruent protest | | 1.523*** | | −0.758*** |
| | | (0.273) | | (0.244) |
| Incongruent protest | | −0.491** | | 0.132 |
| | | (0.236) | | (0.210) |
| Incong.party*Cong.prot. | | −0.427 | | 0.164 |
| | | (0.378) | | (0.337) |
| Incong.party*Incong.prot. | | −0.141 | | −0.045 |
| | | (0.333) | | (0.297) |
| Constant | 3.644*** | 3.495*** | 3.933*** | 4.041*** |
| | (0.105) | (0.146) | (0.092) | (0.130) |
| Observations | 1,679 | 1,679 | 1,679 | 1,679 |
| $R^2$ | 0.002 | 0.050 | 0.0001 | 0.013 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.002 | 0.047 | −0.001 | 0.010 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who received a vignette with an environmental protest or no protest. The PTV of the Green Party and the FDP are the dependent variables.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table 6.10: Economic protests - Exploratory analysis

| | *Dependent variable:* | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | PTV - Greens | | PTV - FDP | |
| Incongruent party position | 0.174 | 0.382* | −0.073 | 0.044 |
| | (0.148) | (0.201) | (0.126) | (0.177) |
| Congruent protest | | −0.515** | | 0.101 |
| | | (0.234) | | (0.206) |
| Incongruent protest | | 1.959*** | | −0.563** |
| | | (0.268) | | (0.235) |
| Incong.party*Cong.prot. | | −0.366 | | −0.195 |
| | | (0.335) | | (0.294) |
| Incong.party*Incong.prot. | | −0.721* | | −0.228 |
| | | (0.371) | | (0.326) |
| Constant | 3.734*** | 3.495*** | 3.959*** | 4.041*** |
| | (0.105) | (0.143) | (0.090) | (0.126) |
| Observations | 1,653 | 1,653 | 1,653 | 1,653 |
| $R^2$ | 0.001 | 0.075 | 0.0002 | 0.012 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.0002 | 0.072 | −0.0004 | 0.009 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who received a vignette with an economic protest and no protest. The PTV of the Green Party and the FDP are the dependent variables. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01*

Interestingly, while agreeing or disagreeing with the environmental protest and economic protest is strongly associated with voters' propensity to vote for the Green Party, the same only partly applies to the FDP. While respondents who find the environment more important are moved by protests, respondents who find the economy more important are not any more motivated to vote for the FDP after seeing a pro-economic protest. This indicates that the link between the environmental issue and the Green Party is much stronger compared to the FDP and the economy. However, while protest mobilisation has an effect on the propensity to vote for the Green and the FDP - the SPD's or the CDU's response to these protests has a very limited effect on the respondents' propensity to vote for the Green Party or the FDP with none of the interaction coefficients reaching a statistical significance of the 5 % level. The exploratory analysis shows that

while protests can have some effect on voting behaviour, party responsiveness to protests does not affect voters' calculations or drive them to parties which 'own' the protests' issue.

## Discussion and Conclusion

This chapter set out to empirically test whether voters electorally punish or reward party responsiveness to protests. The shared theoretical assumption in most studies on elites' responsiveness to street mobilisation is that politicians' behaviour is driven by electoral considerations. However, what voters truly expect of politicians when it comes to protests has received little empirical scrutiny. By implementing a survey experiment in Germany, this chapter explored first the extent to which voters electorally punish parties for ideological incongruence, and second if the negative effect of ideological incongruence is weakened or exacerbated by a protest mobilisation.

While the results only detect a weak relationship between parties' ideological incongruence and voters' propensity to vote for that party, party responsiveness to protests has no significant effect on that relationship - even when only the most attentive respondents are included in the analysis. Regardless of whether voters agree or disagree with the protest in question, the effect of ideological incongruence on respondents' propensity to vote for the responding party is not any different from when there is no protest. This indicates that voters are primarily driven by outcome favourability and that they do not seem to be affected by party responsiveness to street mobilisation. Beyond respondents' electoral considerations, party responsiveness to protests has also no effect on voters' perception of the parties' ability to represent public opinion or their capabilities to deal with the environment and the economy.

However, this is not to say that protest mobilisation has no effect on voting intentions: Additional analysis of the most attentive respondents shows that protest mobilisation can have a direct and negative effect on parties' PTV - regardless of how the parties responded. Moreover, an exploratory analysis of environmental and economic protest separately reveals that the electoral

prospects of the Green Party are strongly tied to protest mobilisation. This direct effect of protest mobilisation detected in the analysis supports the findings of existing studies which have detected an link between electoral outcomes and protest mobilisation (See e.g. Madestam et al., 2013; Gillion and Soule, 2018; Wasow, 2020; Valentim, 2023)

Why would voters not care about how parties respond to street mobilisation - even if they agree with the protest in question? While further analysis illustrates that the results cannot be attributed to inattentive respondents, the null effect could be attributed to some of the other design choices of the experiment: First, the null effect might be due to voters not being satisfied with the parties' responses. The vignette only reports the parties releasing a press statement where the party either voices support for the protest or criticises it. This can be considered as a merely 'symbolic' responsiveness as it offers no concrete actions or policies. Perhaps the voters simply 'do not buy it' or it is not a satisfying response to them. However, while the respondents might have been more persuaded by a policy promise from the parties, it would not be a very accurate portrait of parties' responsiveness to protests, as most studies struggle to find any effect of protests on policy outcomes. This potential explanation of the null findings highlights a limitation of the analysis. The study does not have information on the respondents' evaluation of the parties' responses. The respondents were only asked how and if the party responded but not what they personally thought of that response. Future studies would benefit from a more in-depth analysis of voters' perceptions of parties' responsiveness to street mobilisation.

A second potential explanation for the null effect of the analysis is that the respondents were not persuaded by the protests. The research design included only a text vignette to avoid a compound treatment effect and potential unobserved bias introduced by the inclusion of pictures and videos. However, this might have made the protests too abstract for the readers and not persuasive enough. While the vignette portrayed a realistic news item, protests perhaps primarily affect bystanders and participants who are more exposed to the event. Future studies need to explore the extent to which the *intensity* of the protest

exposure matters for parties' electoral prospects.

Third, while experiments represent the golden standard for estimating causal relationships, they often provide only limited context for participants and lack external validity as they do not accurately reflect the complexity of the real world. For this reason, we cannot say whether the null findings of the analysis stem from the participants lacking further information on the protest: Perhaps responsiveness to protests only matters to voters when the protest is coupled with information from opinion polls. Perhaps the respondents would need to be repeatedly exposed or emotionally moved by protesters' stories to care. Future studies need to move beyond the question of *if* voters are affected by party responsiveness to protests and explore the conditions under which party responsiveness matters.

Finally, due to the focus of the thesis, the experiment considered political protests as the only public opinion signal parties could respond to. However, the world is full of signals for politicians and citizens. Although almost 70 % of the respondents think that 'normal people should be able to influence political parties', it might be that political protests do not fall into citizens' notion of public opinion. An interesting avenue for future studies would be how responsive voters think parties should be to another signal of public opinion compared to protest mobilisation.

The findings have important implications for research into political elites' responsiveness to protests. While Chapter 4 and 5 found limited responsiveness of political parties to protest mobilisation, this chapter concludes that political party responsiveness does also not entail any electoral consequences for parties. Although the findings might render protests ineffective and unimportant in the democratic process, this is also not the case. Instead, protests have - in some cases - a direct effect on the electoral prospect of parties - regardless of the parties' responsiveness to the protest. Perhaps parties have little leeway to change the course of action once protests take place. Protesters take to the streets as they are dissatisfied with the state of current affairs, they highlight issues which have not been adequately addressed and attribute blame. Perhaps it is simply too late when politicians respond. Despite the thesis showing that

political protests garner little reaction from politicians, finding this direct effect of protest can serve as a shimmer of hope for protesters and activists.

# Chapter 7

# Conclusion

Everyone has the right to freedom of peaceful assembly and association. However, that form of political participation is no guarantee for a change in politicians' attention. This thesis set out to understand *whether* and *under which* conditions political parties respond to political protests in Western Europe. While political parties constitute the central channel of representation in today's democracies, political protests represent one of the most important instruments for regular citizens to participate in politics and make their voices heard. The findings of the thesis nevertheless show that political parties rarely respond to protests. Only when parties have faced a major electoral loss do protests have an agenda-setting effect, though the results reveal that parties do acknowledge radical-right protests by raising parliamentary questions on far-right violence and the threat of far-right organisations.

Chapter 4 explored political parties' responsiveness in parliament to environmental and radical-right protests in Germany and specifically investigates the effect the parliamentary entrance of protests' institutional allies can have on the responsiveness of other established parties. To causally estimate the effect of protest mobilisation on parties' parliamentary agendas, the chapter implemented regression discontinuity in time design and the analysis covered protests and parliamentary questions from 1975 to 2019. While the chapter

found very limited empirical support for an agenda-setting effect of environmental and radical-right protests on parties' parliamentary questions, radical-right protests have the unintended consequences of parties raising questions on far-right violence following the protest events. Interestingly, the entrance of the institutional allies - the Green Party and the populist radical right party, AfD - does not provide other parties with incentives to respond more to protest mobilisation. Rather, the entrance of the Green Party coincides with a cessation of responses to environmental protests. The chapter contributes to our understanding of how a changing political landscape can affect parties' willingness to respond to street mobilisation. Moreover, the findings contribute to the literature on institutional allies' effect on protest outcomes - something which has primarily been focused on the institutional allies themselves and less on their effect on other political actors' behaviour. Finally, the findings on parties' responsiveness towards radical-right protests underline the importance of future research paying more attention to political actors and protest mobilisations on the Right.

Chapter 5 shifted the focus from all protests which have taken place on a certain issue to a single movement - the Fridays for Future movement in Germany. The movement - one of the larger environmental movements in recent times - has mobilised millions of people globally. The chapter explored individual parties' incentives to respond to the protest mobilisation with an increase in parties' press releases on the environment. Drawing on insights from existing research on democratic responsiveness, the chapter tested the extent to which electoral vulnerability, opposition status, and time to the next election affect parties' willingness to engage with the protest. Using regional parties' press releases and geo-coded data on FFF protests in Germany, the chapter implemented a new method developed by Imai et al. (2023) combining matching and difference-in-difference approach to causally estimate the effect of the protests on parties' political communications. Similar to the findings from Chapter 4, the analysis detected very limited responsiveness to FFF protests on the regional level in Germany. Overall, parties did not increase the attention paid to environmental issues in the weeks following environmental protests. However, the findings revealed that only parties which experienced a significant amount

of electoral loss were likely to respond to the FFF protest events. On the one hand, the findings enhance our understanding of the political outcomes of large protest movements like the Fridays for Future movement by showing that while existing studies which have found individual MPs to be responsive towards the movement (Schürmann, 2023; Barrie et al., 2023), political parties as unitary actors are not. On the other hand, the chapter provides new evidence on the effect of parties' characteristics on their democratic responsiveness which have until now primarily been explored in relation to other public opinion signals like opinion polls and referendums.

Following two chapters exploring whether and under which conditions political parties respond to street protests, Chapter 6 investigated the electoral consequences of this responsiveness - or the lack of it. The previous chapters follow in the footsteps of existing research which assumes that political elites' responsiveness towards protests is driven by electoral considerations. According to that logic, protests not only mobilise voters, but political elites can also influence their electoral prospects by responding to protests. However, that theoretical assumption has received little empirical scrutiny. Using a survey experiment in Germany, Chapter 6 explored whether voters' propensity to vote for a party is affected by the parties' responsiveness to protests. In contrast to theoretical expectations, voters seem to care about little else than their favoured outcome - meaning that parties' responsiveness to a protest mobilisation has little to add to voters' electoral considerations. The findings do not only contribute new empirical insights into research on protest mobilisation and electoral politics, but also voters' perception of protests as a public opinion signal.

The thesis not only contributes to the literature by exploring political parties' responsiveness to protest mobilisation - a topic which has received a limited amount of attention from scholars - but also introduces new and innovative methodologies into research on the political consequences of protest mobilisation. Research on the effect of protests and social movement has faced various methodological problems such as lack of fine-grained data, endogeneity, and omitted-variable bias (Amenta, 2014; Amenta et al., 2010; Bosi et al., 2016; Giugni et al., 1999; Uba, 2009). With the use of new fine-grained data sets and

methods which come close to the 'gold standard' of randomisation, the thesis addresses the shortcomings of prior studies.

What are the implications of these findings? Have parties missed a chance to regain their foothold among voters by not being responsive to street mobilisation? And is it problematic for our democracy that parties are not responsive to protests? Active civil society represents the foundation of democratic regimes and is considered the key to democratic accountability (Verba, 1996). However, protests' outcomes are dependent on political elite's sympathy and support, as protesters find themselves outside the realm of institutionalised politics. Parties' non-responsiveness is therefore at least partly rather worrying. While participants of unconventional political participation are often also highly involved in conventional political participation (Goldstone, 2004a; Meyer, 2004; Rosenstone and Hansen, 1993), there are certain demographic groups - such as young people - who are the foundation of many environmental movements like the Fridays for Future movement and are less likely to vote compared to older citizens (Melo and Stockemer, 2014). How are these groups represented if they neither vote nor are listened to when they take to the streets? And what might that do to their feeling of political efficacy, trust in political institutions, and faith in democracy in the long term?

While these questions focus on the potential long-term consequences of non-responsiveness, the short-term consequences for parties are less bleak. Chapter 6 showed that although voters think that citizens should be able to influence political parties, their perception of the parties' ability to represent public opinion is not affected by parties' non-responsiveness. Rather, voters care primarily about their own policy position. Consequently, as long as parties remain in touch with voters in some form - be it through election outcomes, opinion polls, or focus groups - their electoral prospects are less alarming. However, little can be said about how the findings from Chapter 6 would translate onto a more long-term perspective.

Beyond parties' general non-responsiveness to protests, there is also some silver lining in the findings. Chapter 4 highlighted the unintended consequences protests can have. While parties did not engage with the grievances of environ-

mental protests, they did condemn violence used by radical-right protests. Mobilisation on the Right is on the rise with protest movements like the PEGIDA movement in Germany and the Golden Dawn movement in Greece. While there are many similarities between protests on the Right and the Left - they often follow the same mobilisation patterns (Castelli Gattinara et al., 2022) - there are many patterns for right-wing protests which are troubling for liberal democracies. The radical Right has a high proportion of violent repertoire involving physical attacks on minority groups, its ideology is fundamentally opposed to the values of liberal democracies (Mudde, 2019) and it is thus important that parties take a clear stance against them. Which they, in fact, do.

Despite the importance of the findings, the research design of the thesis also has some limitations which, in turn, open up new avenues for future research. First, with the empirical focus on causal estimation of the effect of protests on parties' agendas, the thesis cannot exclude the possibility of an indirect long-term effect of protest mobilisation. The thesis treats protests as isolated events, an approach which turns a blind eye to protests often coming in waves which ebb and flow - making them more or less powerful in affecting the political agenda. Numerous scholars have concluded that protests only have an effect by either influencing public opinion or by amplifying already existing public opinion (Burstein and Linton, 2002; Burstein, 1998; Giugni, 2004; Agnone, 2007). However, isolating this potential indirect effect of protests on parties' agendas constitutes a mammoth methodological task, as it would have to disentangle protests from other public opinion signals and allow for more long-term effects as the protests' signals would need a longer time to travel through public opinion to political elites. The challenge of future research is to address this shortcoming of the theoretical approach while overcoming the methodological difficulties it entails. Future studies need to shift their methodological focus more to natural experiments, instrumental variables (See e.g. Madestam et al., 2013) and more spatially fine-grained data (See e.g. Barrie et al., 2023; Gause, 2022; Gillion, 2012, 2020; Schürmann, 2023) to combine these two goals.

Second, with the analytical focus on parties' characteristics and electoral incentives, the thesis does not investigate the effect of protests' characteristics

- beyond the distinction between environmental and radical-right protests - on parties' responsiveness. Consequently, the null findings of the thesis might potentially be explained through parties only being responsive to a very selective set of protests. Studies have found that size (McAdam and Su, 2002; Johnson, 2008), frequency (Valentim, 2023), protest issue (Andrews and Edwards, 2004), tactics (Feinberg et al., 2020), and clarity of message (Fassiotto and Soule, 2017) matter for protests' outcomes. However, while the social movement literature has provided ample insights on protest characteristics, few studies have explored how protests' characteristics might interact with political elites' characteristics. Perhaps parties on the Right are more sensitive to the use of disruptive tactics by protesters. Ideological conservatism has been persistently linked to antagonism towards and acceptance of protests as a form of participation due to protests' defiance of established political authority (Barker et al., 2021; McCright and Dunlap, 2008; Bernhagen and Marsh, 2007; Torcal et al., 2016; van der Meer et al., 2009; Hutter and Kriesi, 2013). And how does major electoral loss interact with protests' characteristics? Are those parties also receptive to small protests, or do small protests never stand a chance of gaining attraction? Future studies could enhance our understanding of parties' responsiveness and political protests' outcomes by exploring the interaction between protests in parties in more depth than this thesis has done.

Third, scholars of unconventional political participation have long highlighted the importance of a more comparative approach to protest mobilisation (van Stekelenburg and Roggeband, 2013; Amenta, 2014). While the thesis compares protests across time, political context, and regional location, the analysis is limited to a Western European country. Partly, this is due to data availability - as, for example, parliamentary questions are very hard to compare across countries due to the different institutional settings and rules (Russo and Wiberg, 2010). However, with an ever-increasing number of projects addressing this problem (See e.g. Kriesi et al., 2020; Hutter et al., 2023; Erfort et al., 2023) and increasingly automated data-collection, future studies can heed the call and focus their efforts on cross-country comparisons. The transformation the party systems have undergone in Western Europe has, for example, been less pronounced in Southern and Eastern Europe (Hutter and Kriesi, 2019;

Borbáth and Gessler, 2020). Existing studies which have compared countries beyond Western Europe have found a considerable variation in parties' engagement with the protest arena depending on the countries' democratic history and the strength of the civil society (Borbáth and Hutter, 2020). Moreover, studies have found the issues of protests to vary considerably (Císař and Vráblíková, 2019). Further cross-country comparisons would enhance our understanding of the political context of elites' openness to protest mobilisation even further.

Finally, in line with the literature on party competition, the thesis considers political parties as unitary actors. Despite offering analytical merits, the unitary approach might simply put the bar too high for political elites' responsiveness to protests, as it requires a certain amount of coordination and agreement within the party before responding. This might explain the discrepancy between the null findings of this paper and the studies which have found individual MPs to be responsive in some form (Schürmann, 2023; Barrie et al., 2023). Moreover, departing from the unitary assumption would also bring its own analytical merits and potential new insights. Perhaps representatives who sit on relevant parliamentary committees and have expertise on the issues are more compelled to respond to protests' grievances than representatives who do not feel adequately informed on the issue. Going beyond the unitary assumption of parties would allow for an exploration into the relationship between individual politicians' policy preferences or their issue specialisation and their responsiveness to protest mobilisation.

The thesis' findings and limitations illustrate that many questions remain unanswered. Three avenues would be especially interesting for future research. First, future studies should do more to understand why the political elite does *not* respond to protests. While numerous studies have found some sign of agenda-setting effect of protests, there is almost an equal amount of studies which have found very limited evidence of such effect (Giugni, 2004; Barrie et al., 2023; Uba, 2009; Amenta et al., 2010). Chapter 6 found that voters do not care much about parties' responsiveness to protests - and the question arises whether parties are aware of this? Scholars need to explore more deeply how politicians and non-protesting citizens perceive protests. Are they perceived a

legitimate - or are they only accepted under very specific circumstances? And if protests are not perceived as legitimate, then why is that the case? The existing studies which have focused on citizens' and politicians' perceptions of protests have illustrated the complexity of the topic. A study by Wouters and Walgrave (2022), for example, provided a qualitative insight into politicians' perception of protesters and showed that politicians have an almost impossible list of demands for protests if they are to be listened to. This involves expectations that protesters provide technical and professional information on their policy demands while remaining authentic and providing personal stories. Experimental findings into support for protests (See e.g. Wouters and Walgrave, 2017; Wouters, 2019) show a complex relationship between the protests' characteristics and ideological predisposition and identification with the demonstrators. Future studies need to explore citizens and political elites' perception of protests and demonstrators further to enhance our understanding of why politicians seem so unresponsive to them and what that unresponsiveness means for the health of democracy.

The second avenue for future studies is to further investigate the unintended consequences of protest mobilisation - echoing scholars who have highlighted the need for studies to expand from well-defined goals of protests to their unintended consequences (Suh, 2014; Giugni et al., 1999). The thesis shows that this is especially important for protests which are outside the political mainstream such as movements on the Right. Future studies need to expand the scope of potential outcomes and include potential negative outcomes. Existing research shows that a complex and reinforcing interplay exists between protests and counter-protests (Vüllers and Hellmeier, 2021). In turn, research has found that an ideological balance between left-wing and right-wing protests has an effect on outcomes such as vote share in the US (Gillion and Soule, 2018). Moreover, political elites' condemnation and the populations' heightened sense of threat - two factors which are likely to have a negative effect on citizens' support for protests - would be interesting avenues for future research into the unintended consequences of protest mobilisation, as it could be indicative of the protests' political efficacy.

A third avenue for future research is to understand what political elites' non-responsiveness means for protest participants. While the democratic importance of parties' responsiveness to protests was outlined in the introduction of the thesis, Chapter 6 shows that in contrast to theoretical expectations voters, are barely affected by this. However, what this non-responsiveness means for protest participants and whether it has any long-term effect on their democratic satisfaction is still a question. Does this non-responsiveness have a negative effect on protesters' perceived democratic efficacy? Or is the political outcome of protests perhaps less important than scholars make it out to be? While studies have found protesting to be associated with a critical stance towards political institutions and conventional politics, demonstrators also have a heightened sense of political efficacy (Giugni and Grasso, 2018). Future studies need to explore the feeling of political efficacy and democratic satisfaction in the light of political elites' non-responsiveness.

The thesis concludes that political parties are not particularly responsive to protests. While political parties constitute the central channel of representation in today's democracy, they do not seem to embed protests' demands into their policy agenda. Although protests provide a crucial arena for citizens to express their political views, their grievances remain unaddressed by political parties. These findings provide important insights into research on political parties' responsiveness and the political consequences of unconventional political participation. While the non-responsiveness could be seen as a sign of an unhealthy democracy, future studies need to investigate the drivers behind this non-responsiveness, as well as its effect on protesters' and citizens' faith in democracy in the long term.

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# Appendix A

# Supplementary Materials - Chapter 4

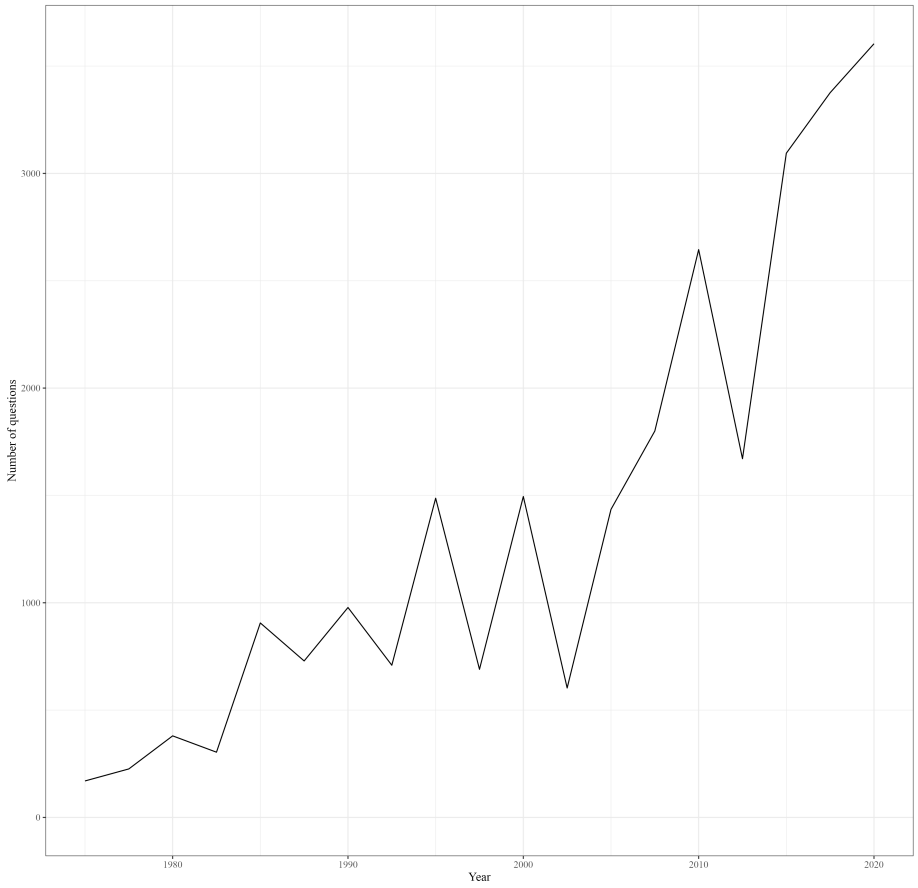
Additional outcome tables can be accessed via this link:

https://box.hu-berlin.de/d/458a368e9b5945fc804d/

Table A.1: Absolute number of parliamentary questions asked by party

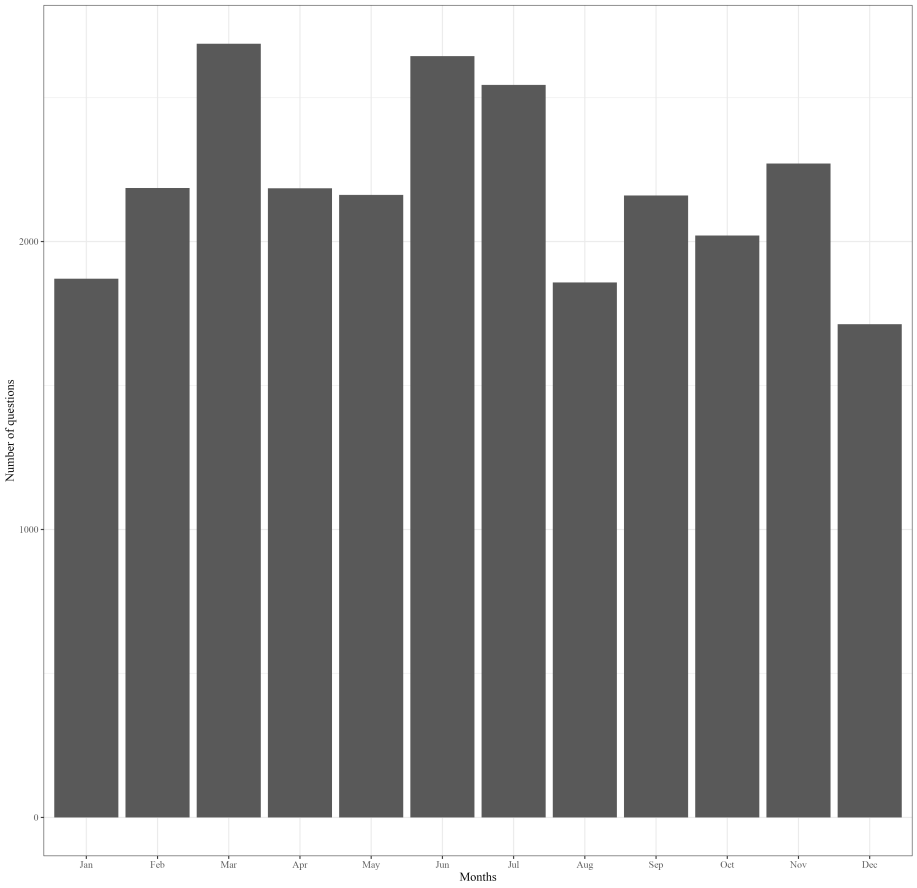
| **Party** | **Number of questions** |
|---|---|
| AfD | 1803 |
| Bündnis90/Green | 8271 |
| CDU/CSU | 1549 |
| FDP | 3784 |
| LINKE/PDS | 9540 |
| SPD | 1355 |
| **Total** | **26302** |

Figure A.1: Number of parliamentary questions over time 1975-2020




**Note:** *The figure displays the absolute number of parliamentary questions across time for the whole analytical period.*

Figure A.2: Average number of parliamentary questions over months




**Note:** *The figure displays the average number of parliamentary questions for each month over the whole analytical period.*

Table A.2: Distribution of questions and protests over weekdays

| **Weekday** | **Questions** | **Env. protests** | **Radical-right protests** |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Sunday** | 64 | 217 (25 %) | 224 (25 %) |
| **Monday** | 4155 | 101 (11 %) | 67 (7 %) |
| **Tuesday** | 6419 | 52 (6 %) | 39 (4 %) |
| **Wednesday** | 7359 | 43 (5 %) | 43 (5 %) |
| **Thursday** | 4642 | 43 (5 %) | 34 (4 %) |
| **Friday** | 3622 | 67 (8 %) | 32 (4 %) |
| **Saturday** | 41 | 356 (41 %) | 462 (51 %) |
| **Total** | **26302** | **879** | **901** |

Table A.3: Distribution of questions over weekdays – dependent on issues

| **Weekday** | **Immigration** | **Far-right violence** | **Environment** |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Sunday** | 10 (0 %) | 12 (0 %) | 12 (0 %) |
| **Monday** | 520 (19 %) | 260 (21 %) | 1148 (14 %) |
| **Tuesday** | 670 (24 %) | 283 (23 %) | 2034 (26 %) |
| **Wednesday** | 718 (26 %) | 294 (24 %) | 2168 (27 %) |
| **Thursday** | 521 (19 %) | 226 (19 %) | 1387 (17 %) |
| **Friday** | 360 (13 %) | 145 (12 %) | 1174 (15 %) |
| **Saturday** | 7 (0 %) | 1 (0 %) | 15 (0 %) |
| **Total** | **2803** | **1221** | **7938** |

Table A.4: Dictionary for classification

| | |
|---|---|
| asyl | ausländerinnen |
| asylant | flüchtling |
| asylanten | flüchtende |
| asylbewerber | flüchtlinge |
| asylbewerberin | flüchtlingen |
| auslander | migranten |
| einwanderer | vertriebene |
| einwandernde | asylantinnen |
| einwanderung | asylbewerberinnen |
| migration | auslanderinnen |
| immigration | einwandererin |
| schutzsuchende | einwandererinnen |
| visa | fluchtling |
| visum | fluchtende |
| zuwanderung | fluchtlinge |
| zuwanderer | schutzbedurftige |
| zuwandernde | schutzbedürftige |
| ausländer | |

## A.1 Overview of coding decision on parliamentary questions on immigration

**Issues included into immigration and far-right violence:**

- Every question directly addressing integration issues in Germany
- Questions on the humanitarian situation in countries:
    1. from which Germany received multiple refugees;
    2. countries with which Germany was in direct cooperation on border control;

3. countries which were being discussed as safe countries to send refugees back to.

- Questions on terrorism, when migrants were specifically mentioned as the perpetrators.

- Questions on border control

- Questions on Far-right violence where violence was specifically against migrants.

- Questions on Far-right groups which specifically focused on migrants.

**Issues specifically excluded:**

- On the administrative sides of visa application processes (e.g. how long the process takes).

- On questions related to expellees (die Vertriebene), who were German nationals of all ethnicities and foreign ethnic Germans who fled or were expelled from Central and Eastern Europe following the WWII.

- Social issues, such as housing and schools, which had only vague reference to migrants (e.g. migrants were just one of the many social groups listed).

## A.2 Description of pre-processing for classification

The corpus was stemmed, stopwords were removed, numbers and other special symbols and the whole corpus was tokenised. Removing of the most common (in 75 per cent of documents) and the least common (in less than 0.5 per cent) terms, names of German MP's and the parties' names for the whole period were removed. This was done to avoid the classification into topics being based on authors rather than content. A dataset with the MP's names was constructed from list from Wikipedia (see an example for the 7th parliamentary term here: https://de.wikipedia.org/wiki/Liste_der_Mitglieder_des_Deutschen_Bundestages_(7._Wahlperiode))

Table A.5: Classifier performance – Overall statistics by class

| | 0 | Immigration | Far-right violence | Environment |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Sensitivity** | 0.8125 | 0.9398 | 0.8785 | 0.8942 |
| **Specificity** | 0.9370 | 0.9488 | 0.9863 | 0.9867 |
| **Pos Pred Value** | 0.7222 | 0.8788 | 0.9126 | 0.9789 |
| **Neg Pred Value** | 0.9612 | 0.9756 | 0.9803 | 0.9310 |
| **Precision** | 0.7222 | 0.8788 | 0.9126 | 0.9789 |
| **Recall** | 0.8125 | 0.9398 | 0.8785 | 0.8942 |
| **F1** | 0.7647 | 0.9083 | 0.8952 | 0.9347 |
| **Prevalence** | 0.1678 | 0.2831 | 0.1402 | 0.4089 |
| **Detection Rate** | 0.1363 | 0.2661 | 0.1232 | 0.3657 |
| **Detection Prevalence** | 0.1887 | 0.3028 | 0.1350 | 0.3735 |
| **Balanced Accuracy** | 0.8748 | 0.9443 | 0.9324 | 0.9405 |

## A.2 Dealing with overlapping events

Partly adapting Riaz's et al. approach, see supporting information p. 8):

- Only single protest event is retained. In multiple protest events occurred on the same day, only one was kept in the data.
- If another protest event occurs within the next 7 days after the treatment event i, all observations of Y_i,t after this next protest event (i.e. after second treatment) were dropped.
- If another protest event occurred within 7 days before the treatment event, the treatment status is unclear and such events are dropped.

## A.3 Additional notes on the methodology

Although RDiT design addresses many of the prior methodological concerns in research on protests, it also raises new problems. There are two central problems that the RDiT design entails and need to be considered in the analysis. First, albeit coming close to some of the experimental ideals of the classic

RDD, the standard of a randomised trial is not fulfilled to the same extent in an RDiT design. That is because with time as the running variable, sorting around the threshold cannot be tested for as standard density tests, such as the McCrary test, become irrelevant with a uniform running variable. For this reason, theoretical considerations need to be included regarding potential unobserved sorting, anticipation, adaptation, or avoidance effect (Hausman and Rapson, 2018). While an avoidance effect can be theoretically excluded, as the protests took place no matter politicians' efforts, responsiveness in anticipation to the protest could be possible, as protests – especially large or controversial ones – are often covered in the media before taking place. A second methodological concern with an RDiT design is the possibility of an auto-regression due to the time-series nature of the data. While RDiT addresses this partly with clustered standard errors, this is a prominent problem in design that uses a long-time span for the analysis and examines the long-term effect of a treatment (Hausman and Rapson, 2018). To address this, this study implements a short-term time frame, which should both hold time-varying variables constant while avoiding time-dependencies in the dependent variable. Finally, as both protests and parliamentary questions cluster on certain weekdays - protests on weekends, and questions on weekdays - all of the models include weekday fixed-effects to ensure the results are not driven by the particularities of weekdays.

Table A.6: LATE for environmental protests - all parties' questions

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.072 | 0.183 | 8 | 1,529 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.138 | 0.078 | 9 | 1,653 | Quadratic | Full sample |
| 0.466∗ | 0.032 | 7 | 165 | Linear | Before the Greens |
| 0.021 | 0.692 | 9 | 1,474 | Linear | After the Greens |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily share of parliamentary questions on the environment as the outcome. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$*

Table A.7: LATE for environmental protests - different bandwidth length

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.152∗ | 0.046 | 4 | 528 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.095 | 0.073 | 7 | 1,017 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.082 | 0.093 | 8 | 1,152 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.055 | 0.197 | 10 | 1,311 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.012 | 0.735 | 14 | 1,968 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.008 | 0.790 | 21 | 2,935 | Linear | Full sample |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' parliamentary questions on the environment as the outcome, excluding the Green Party's questions. The analysis uses manual bandwidth selection and a conventional OLS standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.8: LATE for environmental protests - different bandwidth length

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.232 | 0.363 | 4 | 78 | Linear | Before the Greens |
| 0.38∗ | 0.037 | 7 | 165 | Linear | Before the Greens |
| 0.232 | 0.109 | 10 | 204 | Linear | Before the Greens |
| 0.104 | 0.344 | 14 | 315 | Linear | Before the Greens |
| 0.099 | 0.276 | 21 | 467 | Linear | Before the Greens |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' parliamentary questions on the environment as the outcome, excluding the Green Party's questions. The analysis uses manual bandwidth selection and a conventional OLS standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.9: LATE for environmental protests - different bandwidth length

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.133 | 0.073 | 4 | 450 | Linear | After the Greens |
| 0.049 | 0.335 | 7 | 900 | Linear | After the Greens |
| 0.037 | 0.387 | 10 | 1,107 | Linear | After the Greens |
| -0.002 | 0.955 | 14 | 1,653 | Linear | After the Greens |
| -0.009 | 0.757 | 21 | 2,468 | Linear | After the Greens |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' parliamentary questions on the environment as the outcome, excluding the Green Party's questions. The analysis uses manual bandwidth selection and a conventional OLS standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.10: LATE for environmental protests - Binary outcome

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.045∗ | 0.043 | 7 | 4,093 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.043 | 0.078 | 12 | 6,623 | Quadratic | Full sample |
| 0.081∗ | 0.026 | 9 | 1,167 | Linear | Before the Greens |
| 0.027 | 0.281 | 8 | 3,547 | Linear | After the Greens |

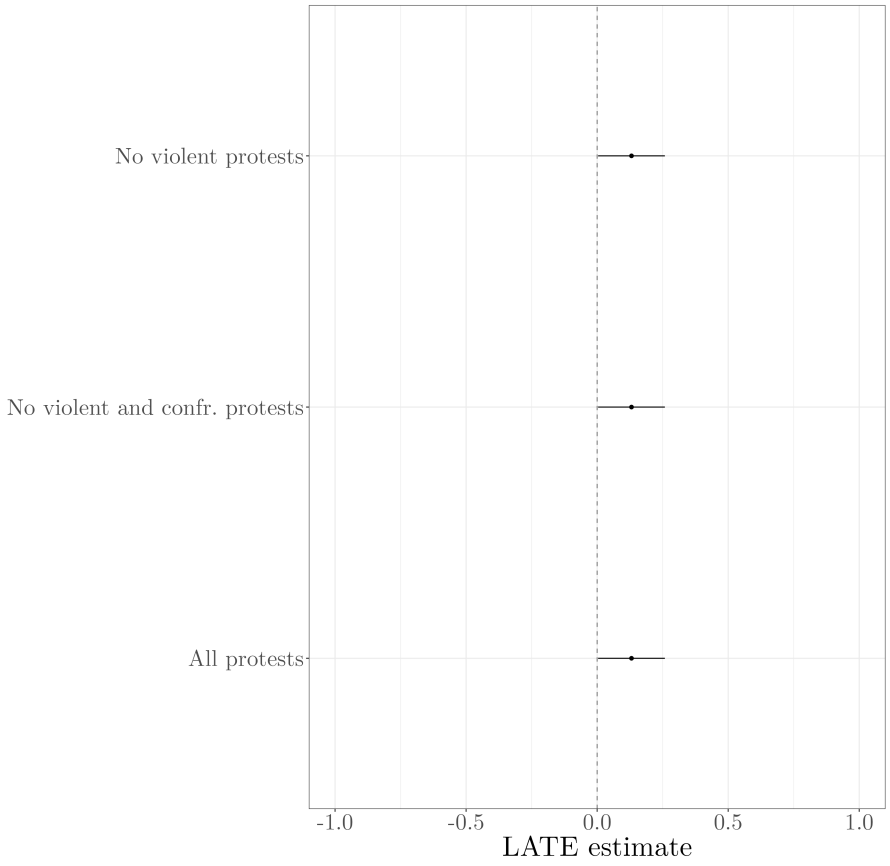
**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily probability of asking parliamentary questions on the environment as the outcome, excluding the Green Party's questions. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.11: LATE for environmental protests - Count outcome

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.044 | 0.576 | 7 | 4,093 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.1 | 0.292 | 10 | 5,611 | Quadratic | Full sample |
| 0.099 | 0.064 | 10 | 1,167 | Linear | Before the Greens |
| 0.009 | 0.923 | 8 | 3,156 | Linear | After the Greens |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily number of parliamentary questions on the environment as the outcome, excluding the Green Party's questions. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Figure A.3: LATE Plot - Responsiveness towards environmental protests: Violent vs. non-violent events




**Note:** *The figure shows the local average treatment effect on the treated estimated from the RDiT models. The outcome variable is daily share of parliamentary question on the environment and displays the effect for different samples: i) all days in which protests took place; ii) excluding days where violend and confrontational protests took place; iii) excluding days where violent protests took place. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.*

Table A.12: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Immigration

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| -0.015 | 0.647 | 9 | 1,650 | Linear | Full sample - All parties |
| -0.061 | 0.198 | 8 | 1,650 | Quadratic | Full sample - All parties |
| -0.037 | 0.233 | 9 | 1,456 | Linear | Before AfD - All parties |
| 0.194∗ | 0.044 | 8 | 175 | Linear | After AfD - All parties |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily share of parliamentary questions on immigration as the outcome. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.13: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Immigration

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| -0.079∗ | 0.025 | 4 | 737 | Linear | Full sample |
| -0.056∗ | 0.035 | 7 | 1,439 | Linear | Full sample |
| -0.028 | 0.249 | 8 | 1,620 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.009 | 0.671 | 10 | 1,863 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.019 | 0.258 | 14 | 2,742 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.008 | 0.550 | 21 | 4,137 | Linear | Full sample |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' parliamentary questions on immigration, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses manual bandwidth selection and a conventional OLS standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.14: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Immigration

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| -0.099** | 0.009 | 4 | 668 | Linear | Before AfD |
| -0.059* | 0.038 | 7 | 1,298 | Linear | Before AfD |
| -0.03 | 0.256 | 9 | 1,456 | Linear | Before AfDe |
| 0.003 | 0.882 | 10 | 1,673 | Linear | Before AfD |
| 0.015 | 0.381 | 14 | 2,459 | Linear | Before AfD |
| 0.011 | 0.440 | 21 | 3,702 | Linear | Before AfD |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' parliamentary questions on immigration, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses manual bandwidth selection and a conventional OLS standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.15: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Immigration

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.015 | 0.875 | 4 | 69 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.018 | 0.796 | 7 | 141 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.025 | 0.704 | 8 | 150 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.102 | 0.085 | 10 | 190 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.079 | 0.113 | 14 | 283 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.006 | 0.887 | 21 | 435 | Linear | After AfD |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' parliamentary questions on immigration, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses manual bandwidth selection and a conventional OLS standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.16: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Immigration - Binary variable

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| -0.008 | 0.673 | 11 | 5,410 | Linear | Full sample |
| -0.036 | 0.240 | 9 | 4,060 | Quadratic | Full sample |
| -0.012 | 0.481 | 10 | 4,161 | Linear | Before AfD |
| 0.005 | 0.969 | 8 | 313 | Linear | After AfD |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily probability of asking parliamentary questions on immigration as the outcome, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.17: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Immigration - Count variable

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| -0.021 | 0.639 | 12 | 5,860 | Linear | Full sample |
| -0.126 | 0.061 | 8 | 4,060 | Quadratic | Full sample |
| -0.012 | 0.690 | 10 | 4,161 | Linear | Before AfD |
| -0.155 | 0.681 | 10 | 349 | Linear | After AfD |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily number of parliamentary questions on immigration as the outcome, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.18: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Right-wing violence

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.091** | 0.003 | 8 | 1,511 | Linear | Full sample - All parties |
| 0.106* | 0.014 | 9 | 1,897 | Quadratic | Full sample - All parties |
| 0.108** | 0.002 | 7 | 1,336 | Linear | Before AfD - All parties |
| -0.024 | 0.481 | 9 | 224 | Linear | After AfD - All parties |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily share of parliamentary questions on far-right violence as the outcome. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.19: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Far-Right Violence

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.087* | 0.043 | 4 | 737 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.085** | 0.003 | 7 | 1,439 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.044* | 0.049 | 10 | 1,863 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.044* | 0.049 | 10 | 1,863 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.016 | 0.341 | 14 | 2,742 | Linear | Full sample |
| 0.01 | 0.431 | 21 | 4,137 | Linear | Full sample |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily share of parliamentary questions on far-right violence as the outcome, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses manual bandwidth selection and a conventional OLS standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.20: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - far-right violence

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.109∗ | 0.023 | 4 | 668 | Linear | Before AfD |
| 0.095∗∗ | 0.002 | 7 | 1,298 | Linear | Before AfD |
| 0.094∗∗ | 0.002 | 7 | 1,336 | Linear | Before AfDe |
| 0.049∗ | 0.043 | 10 | 1,673 | Linear | Before AfD |
| 0.017 | 0.354 | 14 | 2,459 | Linear | Before AfD |
| 0.01 | 0.505 | 21 | 3,702 | Linear | Before AfD |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily share of parliamentary questions on far-right violence as the outcome, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses manual bandwidth selection and a conventional OLS standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.21: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - far-right violence

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| -0.02 | 0.780 | 4 | 69 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.018 | 0.710 | 7 | 141 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.012 | 0.791 | 8 | 164 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.012 | 0.760 | 10 | 190 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.007 | 0.818 | 14 | 283 | Linear | After AfD |
| 0.015 | 0.516 | 21 | 435 | Linear | After AfD |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily share of parliamentary questions on far-right violence as the outcome, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses manual bandwidth selection and a conventional OLS standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.22: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Right-wing violence - binary variable

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.023 | 0.127 | 11 | 4,960 | Linear | Full sample - All parties |
| 0.028 | 0.131 | 14 | 6,310 | Quadratic | Full sample - All parties |
| 0.025 | 0.084 | 11 | 4,989 | Linear | Before AfD - All parties |
| 0.08 | 0.415 | 8 | 313 | Linear | After AfD - All parties |

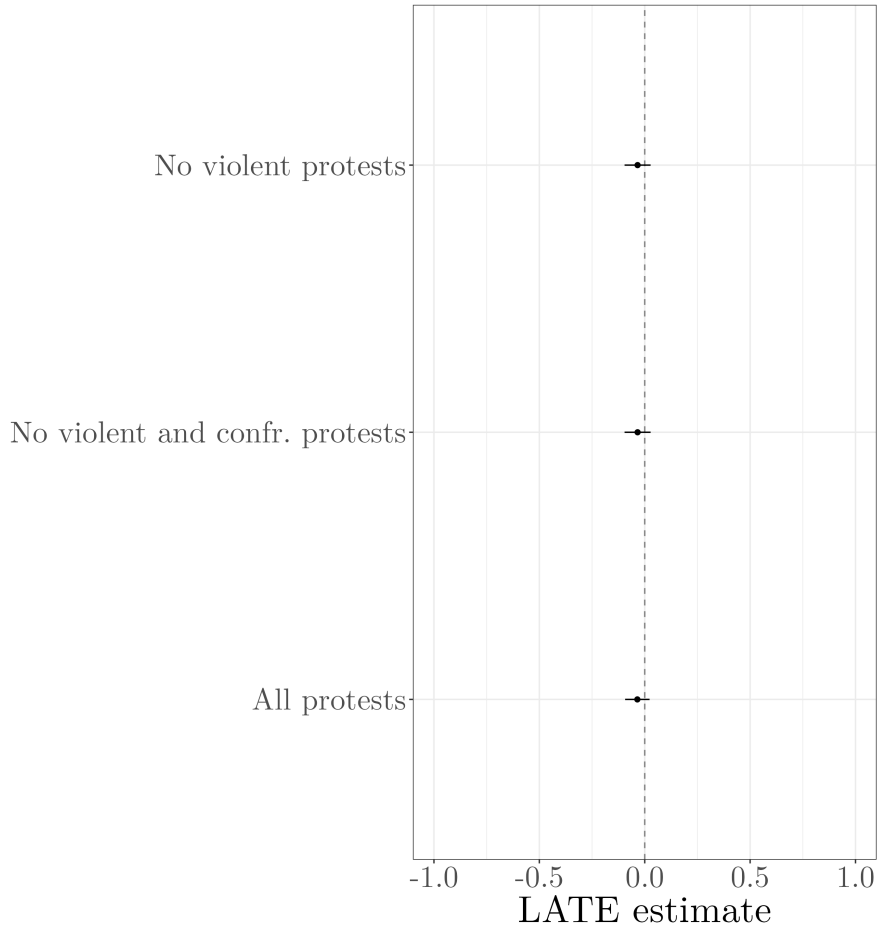
**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily probability of asking parliamentary questions on far-right violence as the outcome, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Table A.23: LATE for Radical-Right Protests - Violence - count variable

| Coeff. | P-values | h | n | Polynomials | Sample |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.05∗ | 0.025 | 10 | 4,510 | Linear | Full sample, all parties |
| 0.048 | 0.084 | 12 | 5,860 | Quadratic | Full sample, all parties |
| 0.056∗∗ | 0.007 | 10 | 4,161 | Linear | Before AfD, all parties |
| 0.13 | 0.439 | 8 | 277 | Linear | After AfD, all parties |

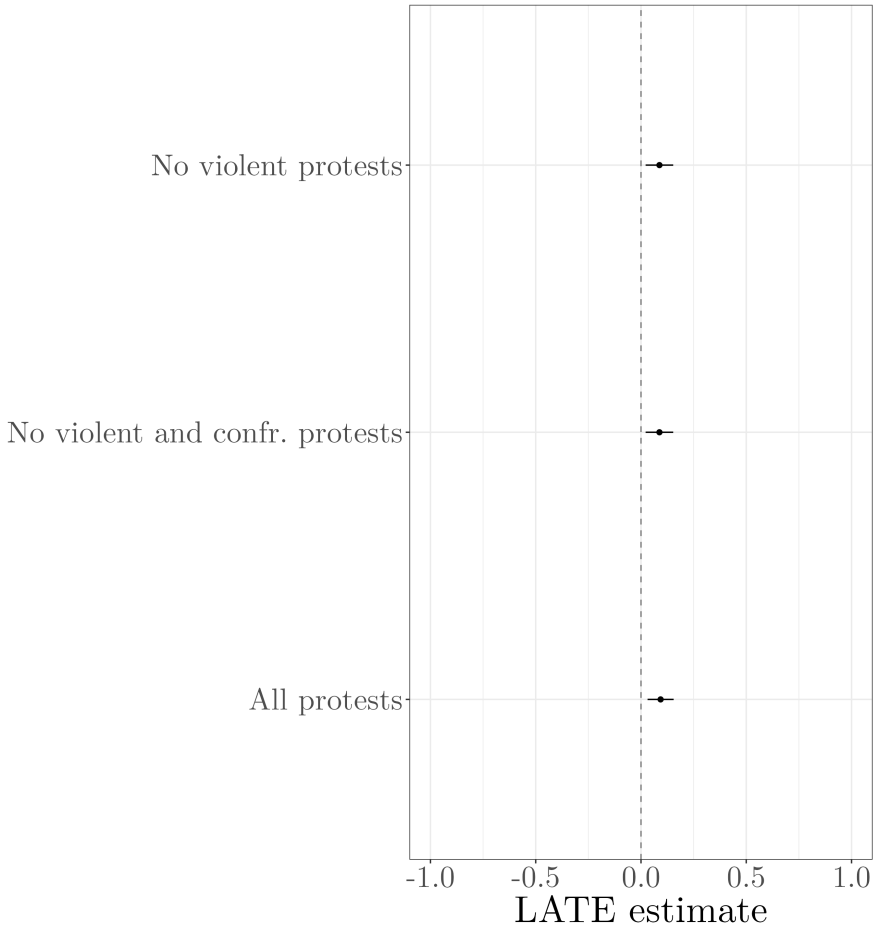
**Note:** *The table shows the results from the regression discontinuity in time analyses with all parties' daily number of parliamentary questions on far-right violence as the outcome, excluding the AfD's questions. The analysis uses the optimal bandwidth selection and robust bias-corrected standard errors. The sample size displayed is the number of observations that fall within the bandwidth. *** p <0.001, ** p <0.01, * p <0.05*

Figure A.4: LATE Plot - Responsiveness towards right-wing protests (immigration): Violent vs. non-violent events




**Note:** *The figure shows the local average treatment effect on the treated estimated from the RDiT models. The outcome variable is daily share of parliamentary question on immigration and displays the effect for different samples: i) all days in which protests took place; ii) excluding days where violend and confrontational protests took place; iii) excluding days where violent protests took place. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.*

Figure A.5: LATE Plot - Responsiveness towards right-wing protests (far-right violence): Violent vs. non-violent events



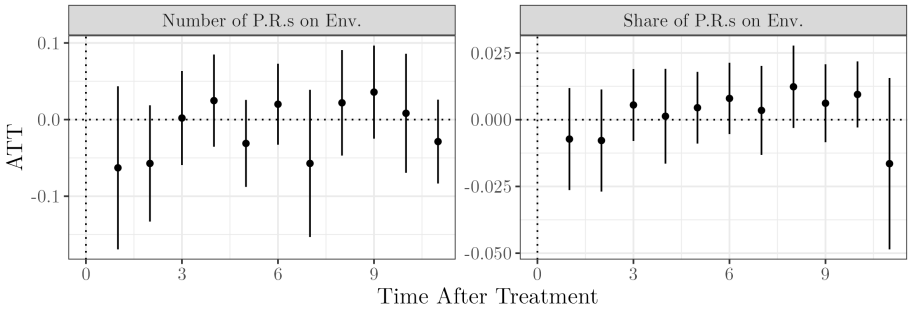

**Note:** *The figure shows the local average treatment effect on the treated estimated from the RDiT models. The outcome variable is daily share of parliamentary question on far-right violence and displays the effect for different samples: i) all days in which protests took place; ii) excluding days where violend and confrontational protests took place; iii) excluding days where violent protests took place. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.*

# Appendix B

# Supplementary Materials - Chapter 5

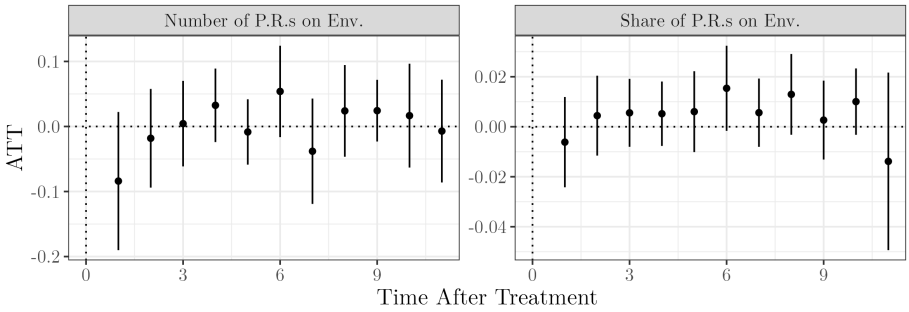
### Main model - different model specifications

Figure B.1: Overall effect of FFF on parties' communications - 2 weeks lag



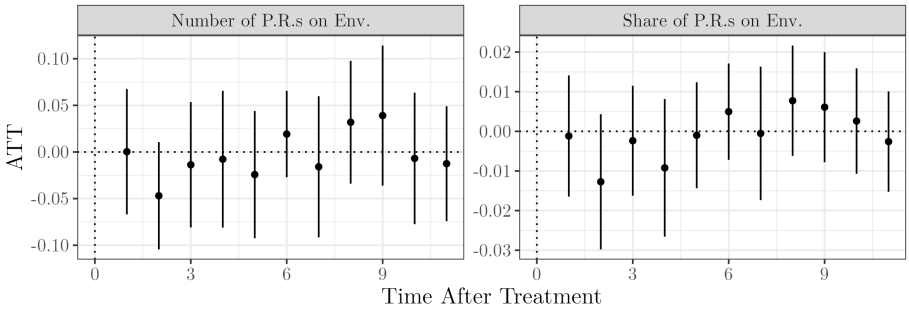

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the two weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.2: Overall effect of FFF on parties' communications - 4 weeks lag



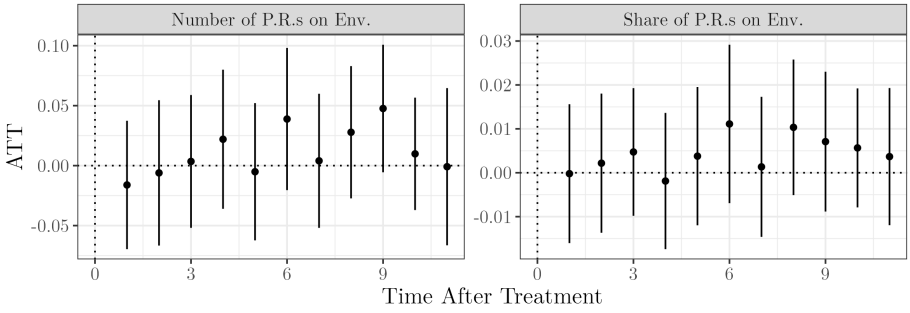

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the four weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.3: Overall effect of FFF on parties' communications - 2 weeks lag - propensity matching



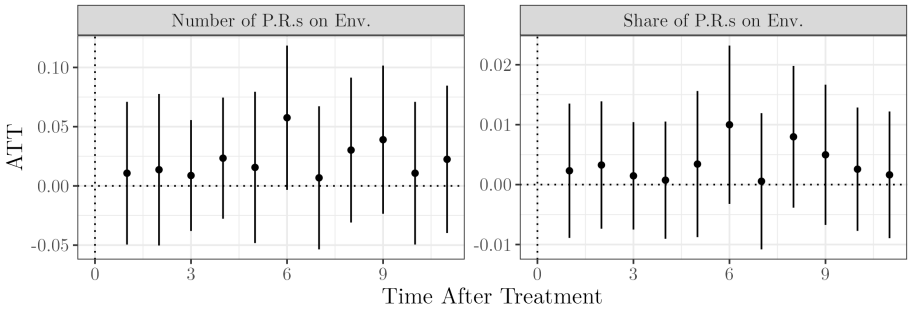

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the two weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.4: Overall effect of FFF on parties' communications - 3 weeks lag - propensity matching




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

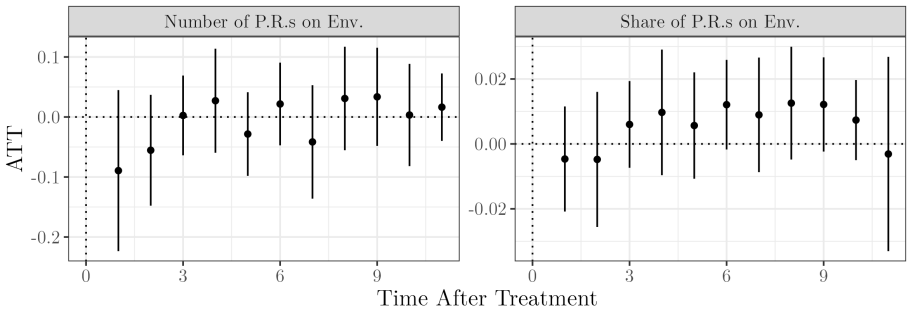
Figure B.5: Overall effect of FFF on parties' communications - 4 weeks lag - propensity matching




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the four weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

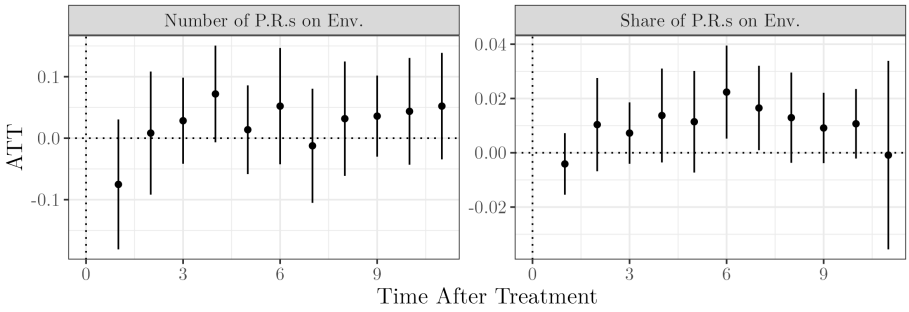
## Opposition parties - different model specifications

Figure B.6: Effect of FFF on opposition parties' communications - 2 weeks lag



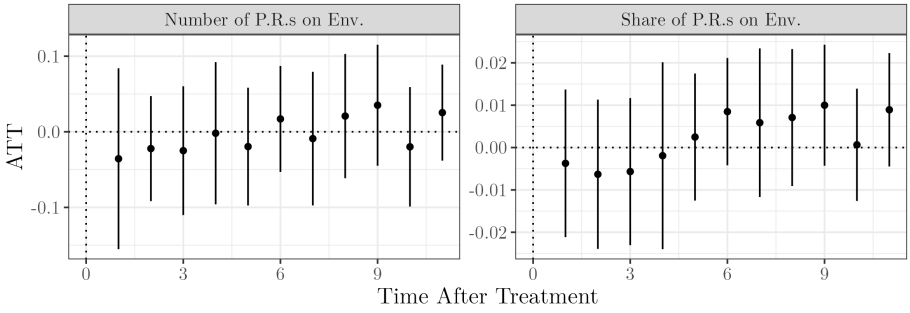

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the two weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.7: Effect of FFF on opposition parties' communications - 4 weeks lag



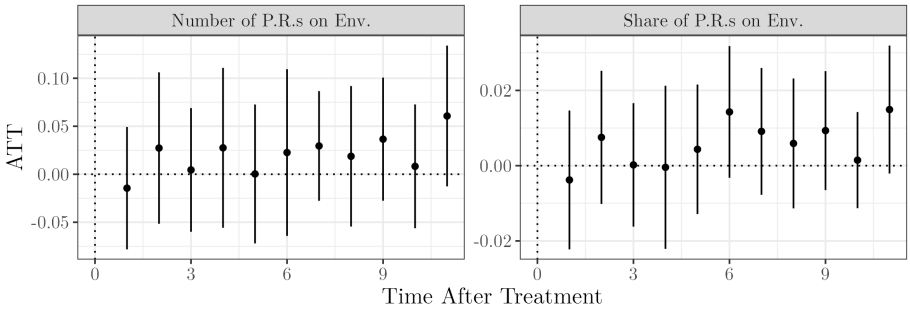

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the four weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.8: Effect of FFF on opposition parties' communications - 2 weeks lag - propensity matching



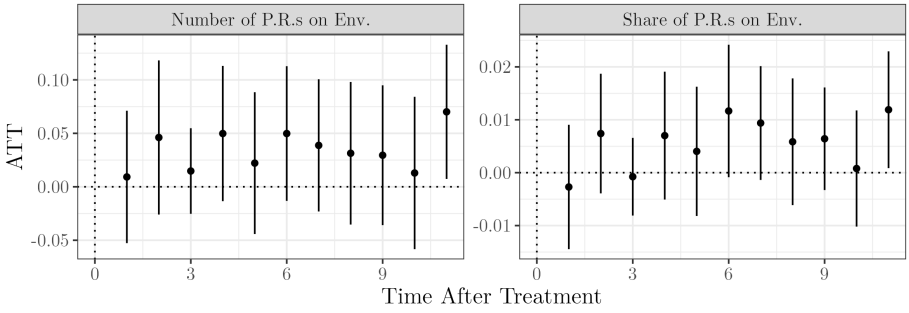

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the two weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.9: Effect of FFF on opposition parties' communications - 3 weeks lag - propensity matching




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

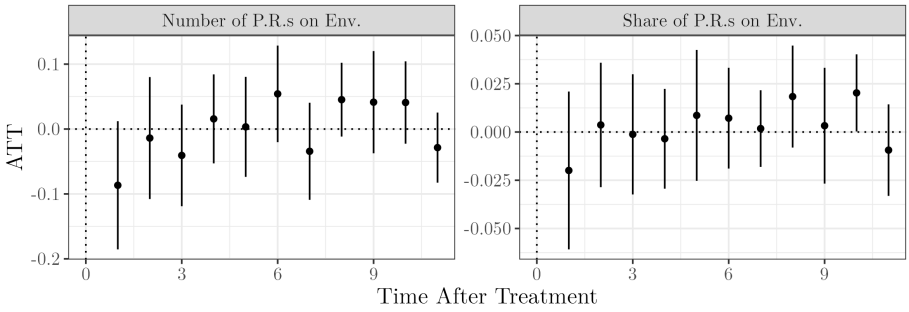
Figure B.10: Effect of FFF on opposition parties' communications - 4 weeks lag - propensity matching




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the four weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

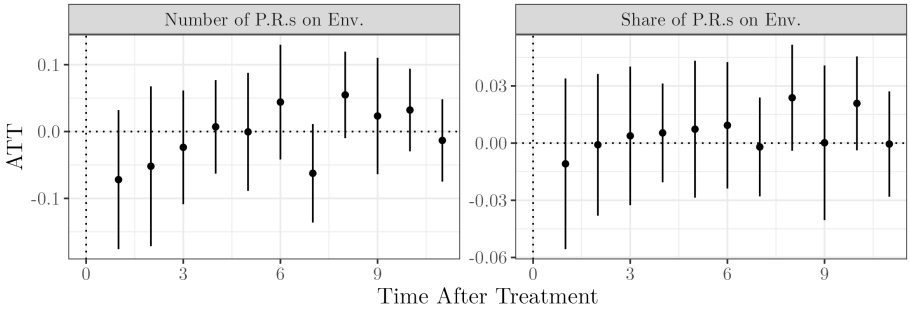
## Government parties - different model specifications

Figure B.11: Effect of FFF on government parties' communications - 2 weeks lag



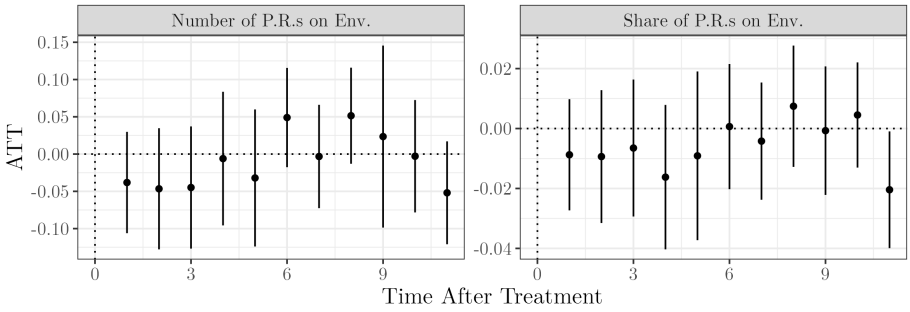

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the two weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.12: Effect of FFF on government parties' communications - 4 weeks lag



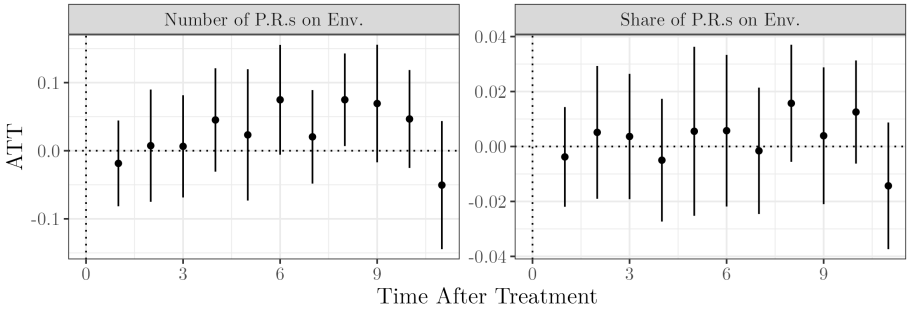

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the four weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.13: Effect of FFF on government parties' communications - 2 weeks lag - propensity matching



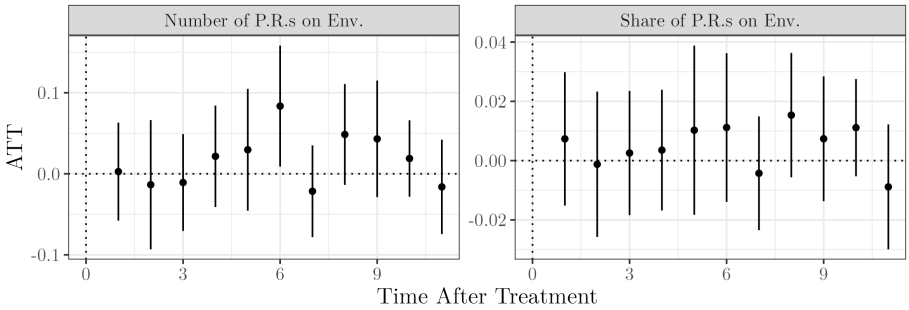

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the two weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.14: Effect of FFF on government parties' communications - 3 weeks lag - propensity matching




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

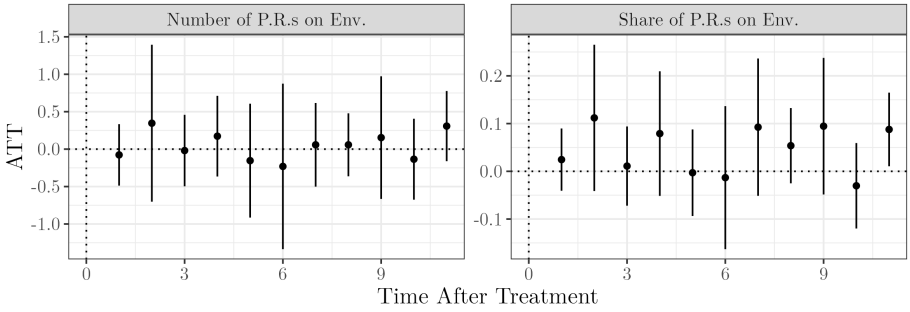
Figure B.15: Effect of FFF on government parties' communications - 4 weeks lag - propensity matching




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the four weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

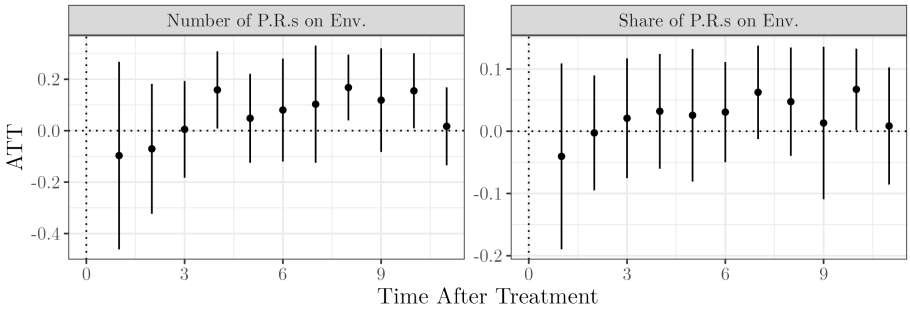
## Opposition/Governmental status by party

Figure B.16: Effect of FFF on the Green party - Opposition



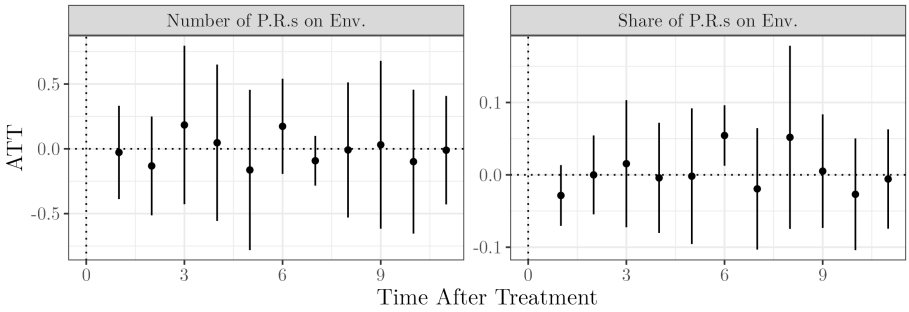

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.17: Effect of FFF on the Green party - Government



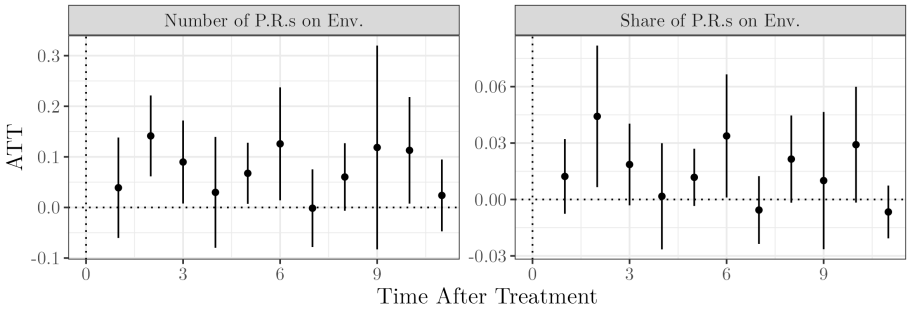

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.18: Effect of FFF on the SPD - Opposition



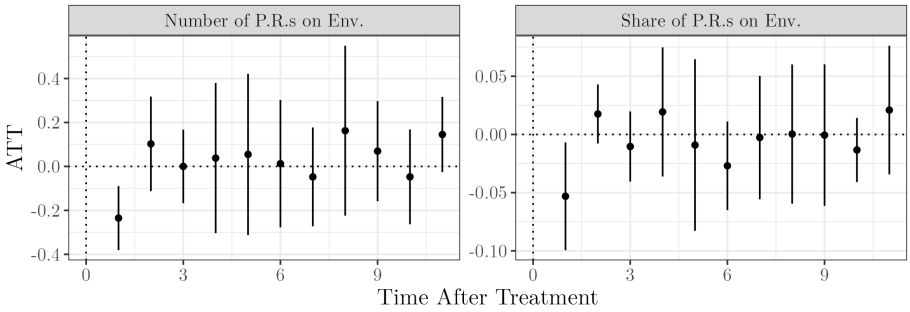

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.19: Effect of FFF on the SPD - Government



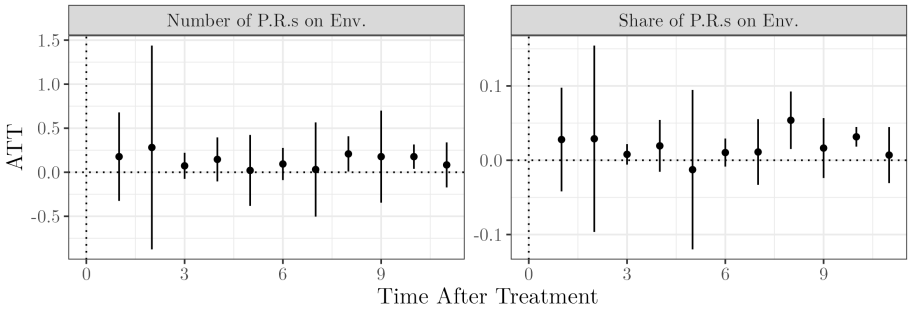

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.20: Effect of FFF on the Left Party - Opposition



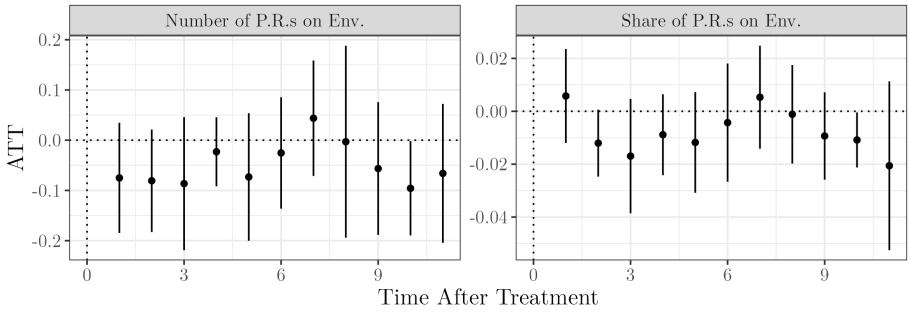

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.21: Effect of FFF on the Left Party - Government



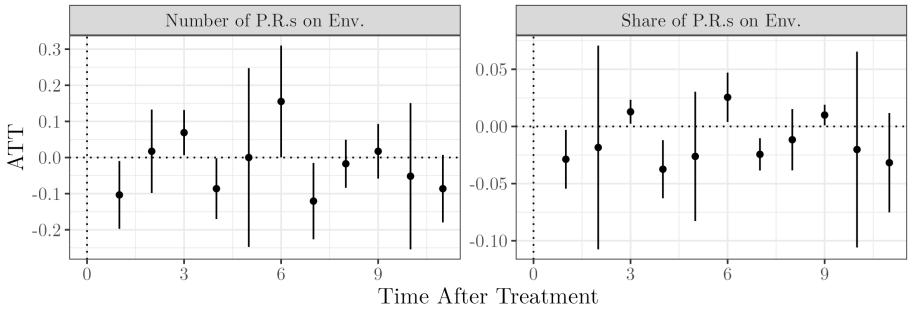

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.22: Effect of FFF on the FDP - Opposition



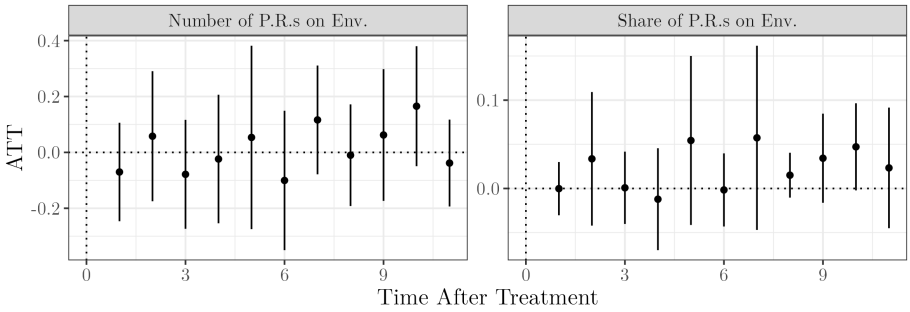

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.23: Effect of FFF on the FDP - Government



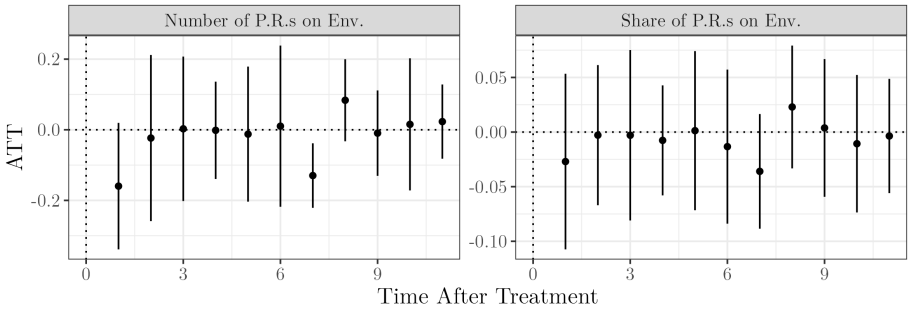

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.24: Effect of FFF on the CDU - Opposition




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

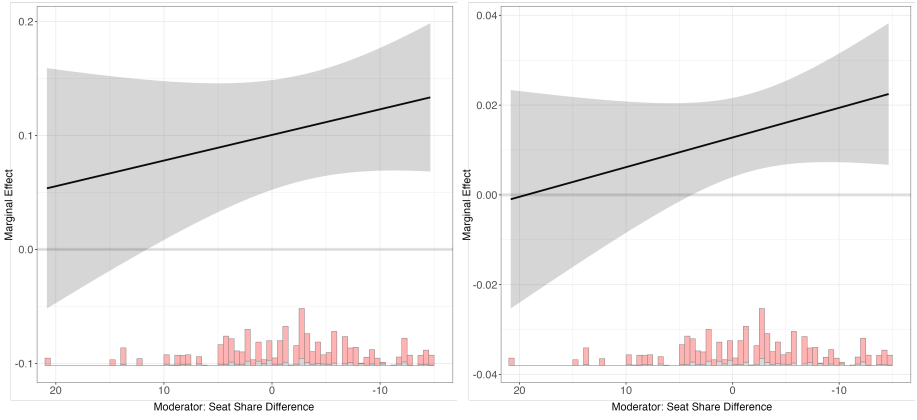
Figure B.25: Effect of FFF on the CDU - Government




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

## Electoral vulnerability - different model specifications

Figure B.26: Marginal effect of FFF - moderated by difference in seat share

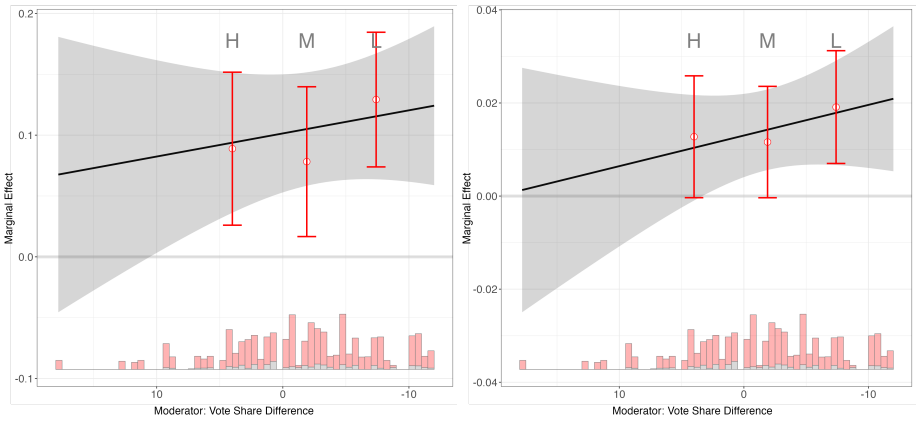



(a) Number of P.R.s on Env.

(b) Share of P.R.s on Env.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on difference in seat share parties experienced in previous elections using a conventional linear interaction model with 95% confidence intervals in grey. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

Figure B.27: Marginal effect of FFF - moderated by difference in vote share - binned estimator

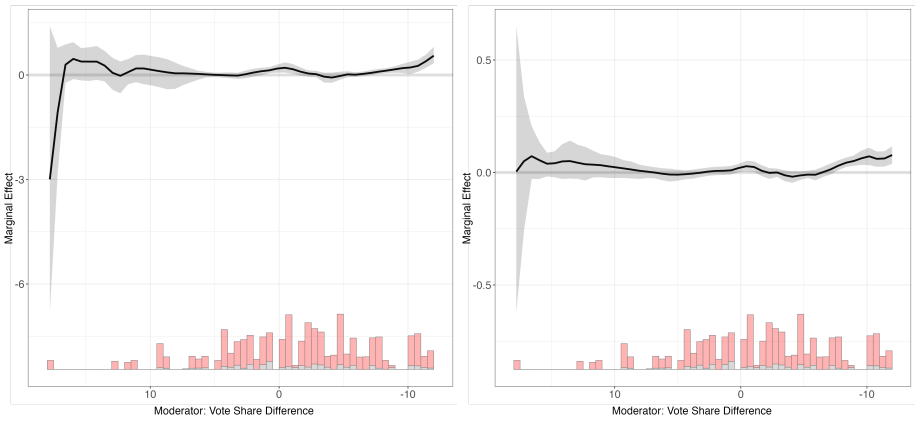



(a) Number of P.R.s on Env.

(b) Share of P.R.s on Env.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on difference in vote share parties experienced in previous elections using a binning estimator with 95% confidence intervals as vertical bars. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

Figure B.28: Marginal effect of FFF - moderated by difference in vote share - kernel smoothing estimator



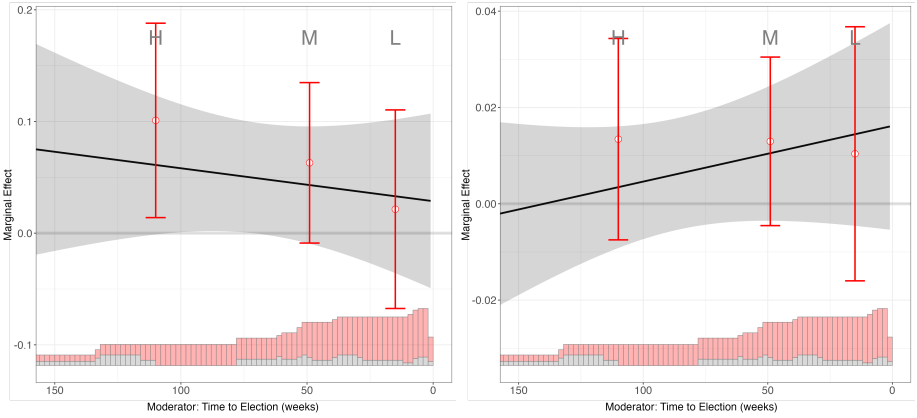

(a) Number of P.R.s on Env.

(b) Share of P.R.s on Env.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on difference in vote share parties experienced in previous elections using a kernel smoothing estimator with 95% confidence intervals in grey. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

## Time to elections - different model specifications

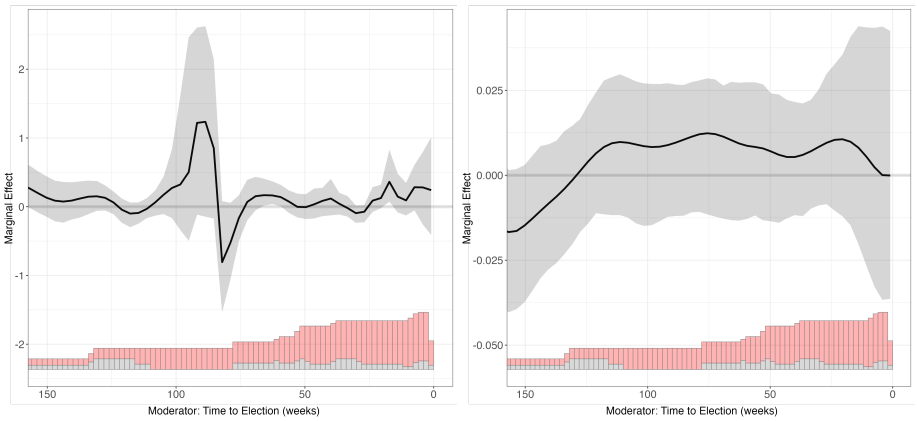
Figure B.29: Marginal effect of FFF - moderated by time to elections - binned estimator




(a) Number of P.R.s on Env. (b) Share of P.R.s on Env.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on temporal proximity to next elections using binning estimator with 95% confidence intervals as vertical bars. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

Figure B.30: Marginal effect of FFF - moderated by time to elections - kernel smoothing estimator

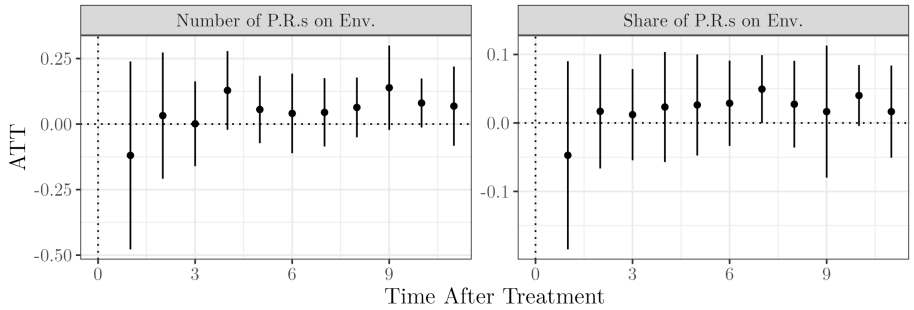



(a) Number of P.R.s on Env. (b) Share of P.R.s on Env.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on temporal proximity to next elections using a kernel smoothing estimator with 95% confidence intervals in grey. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

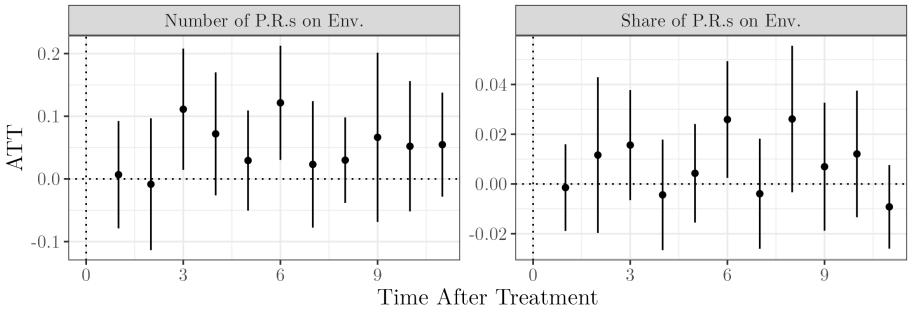
## Additional analysis - Individual parties

Figure B.31: Effect of FFF on the Green party



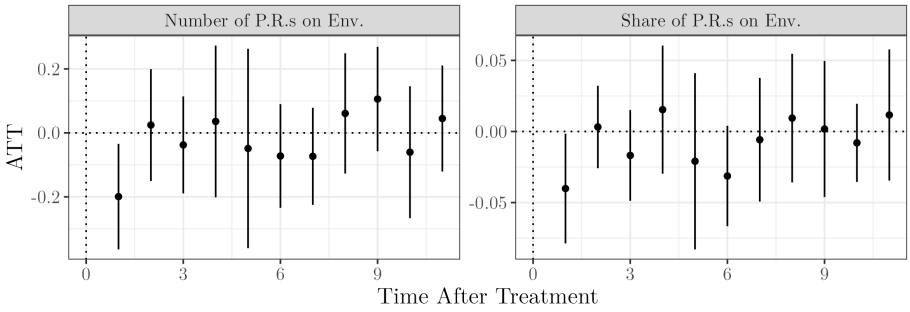

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.32: Effect of FFF on the SPD



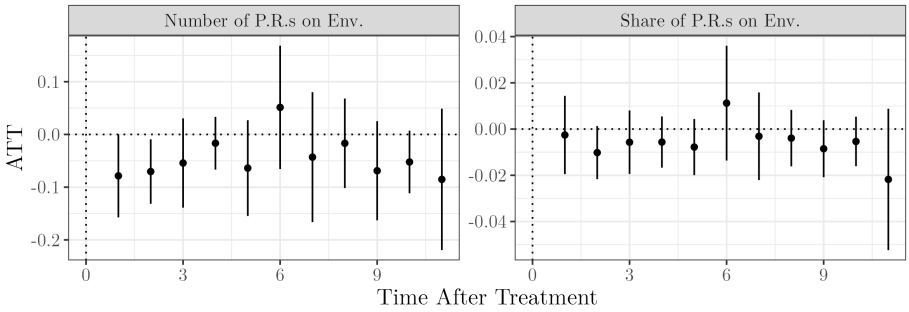

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.33: Effect of FFF on the Left Party



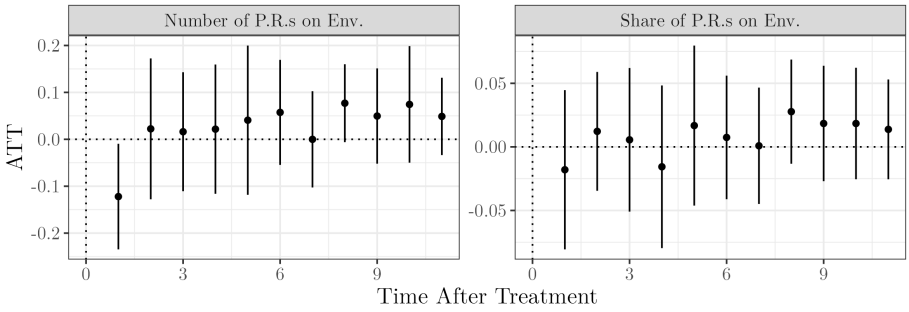

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.34: Effect of FFF on the FDP



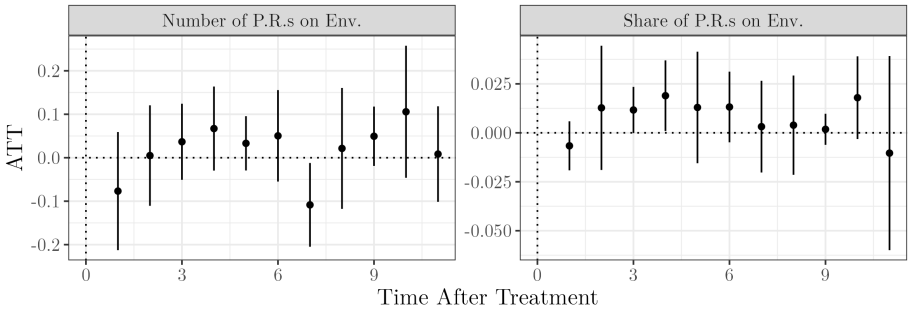

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.35: Effect of FFF on the CDU




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

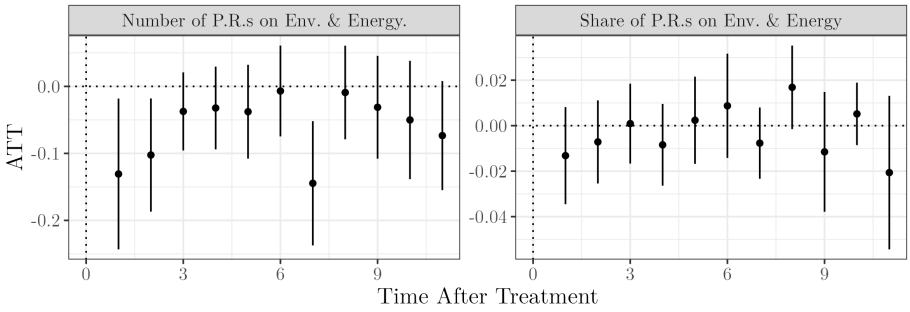
Figure B.36: Effect of FFF on the AfD




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

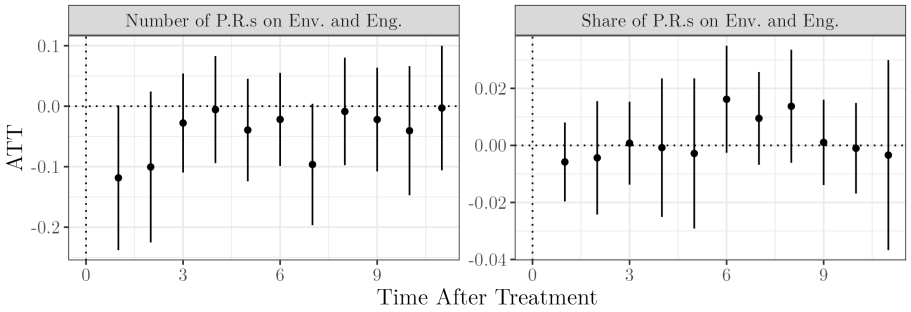
## Additional analysis - Energy and environment as outcome

Figure B.37: Overall effect of FFF on parties' communications - 3 weeks lags



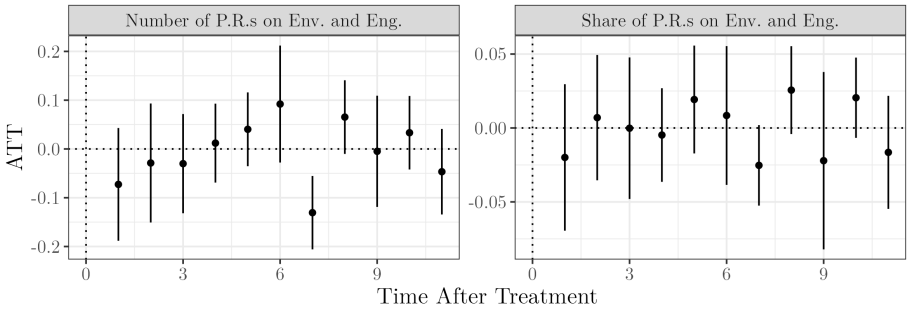

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.38: Effect of FFF on opposition parties' communications - 3 weeks lag



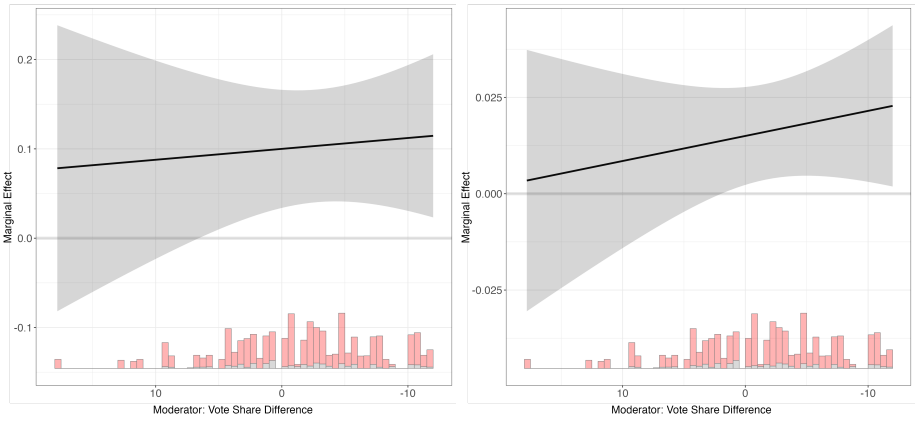

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.39: Effect of FFF on government parties' communications - 3 weeks lag




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

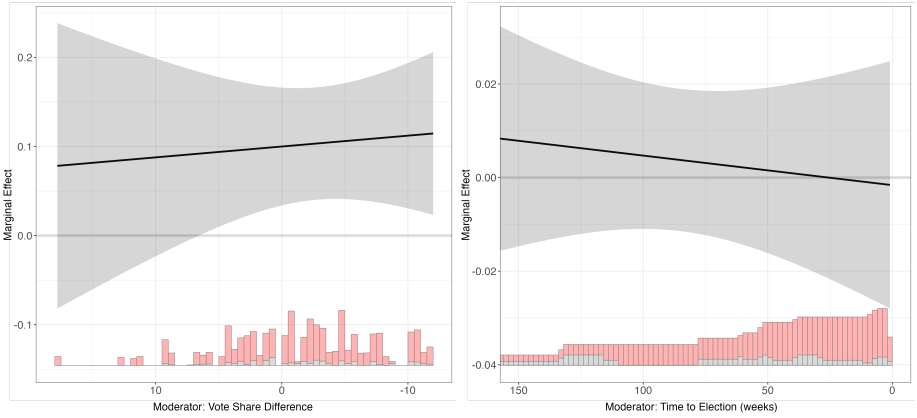
Figure B.40: Marginal effect of FFF - moderated by vote loss




(a) Number of P.R.s on Env. and Eng. (b) Share of P.R.s on Env. and Eng.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on difference in vote share parties experienced in previous elections using a conventional linear interaction model with 95% confidence intervals in grey. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

Figure B.41: Marginal effect of FFF - moderated by time to elections

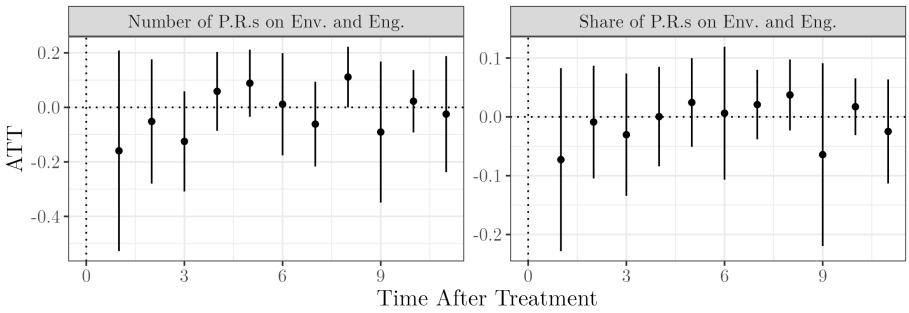



(a) Number of P.R.s on Env. and Eng. (b) Share of P.R.s on Env. and Eng.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on temporal proximity to next elections using a conventional linear interaction model with 95% confidence intervals in grey. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

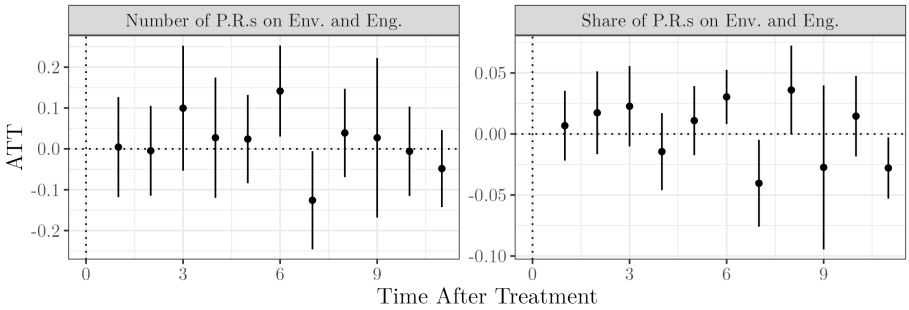
## Individual parties - energy and environment

Figure B.42: Effect of FFF on the Green party



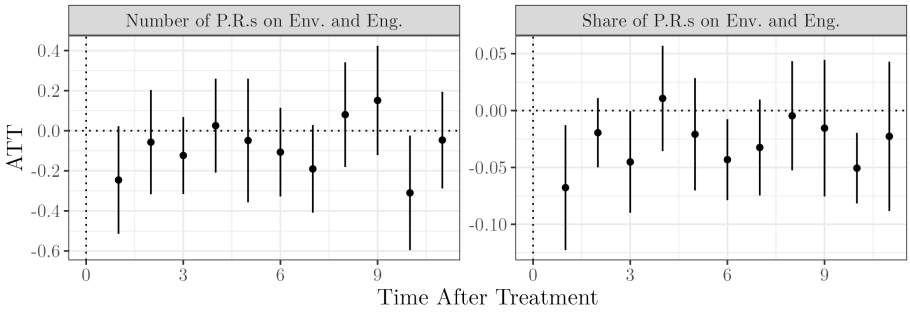

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.43: Effect of FFF on the SPD



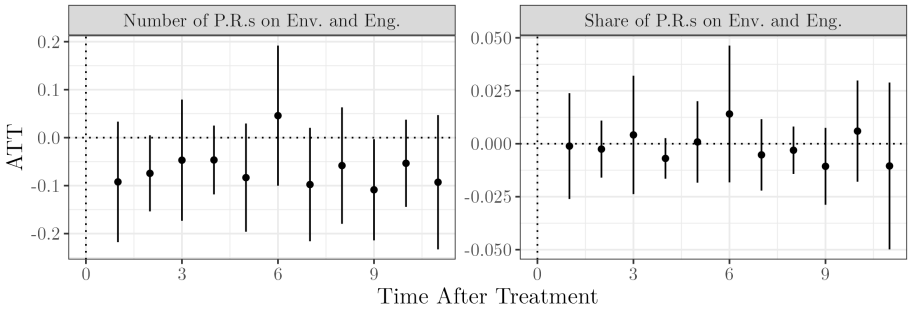

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.44: Effect of FFF on the Left Party



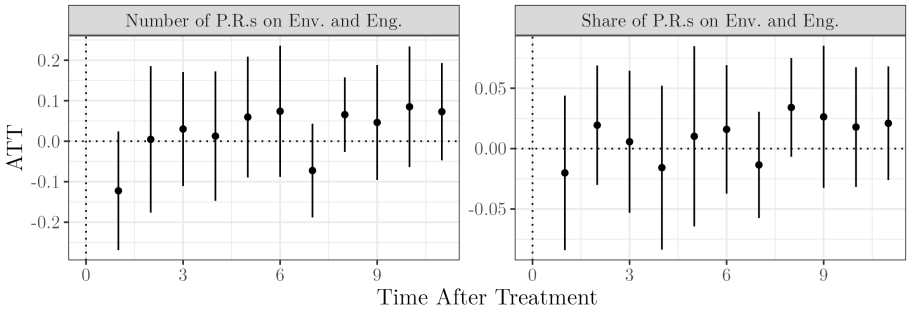

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.45: Effect of FFF on the FDP



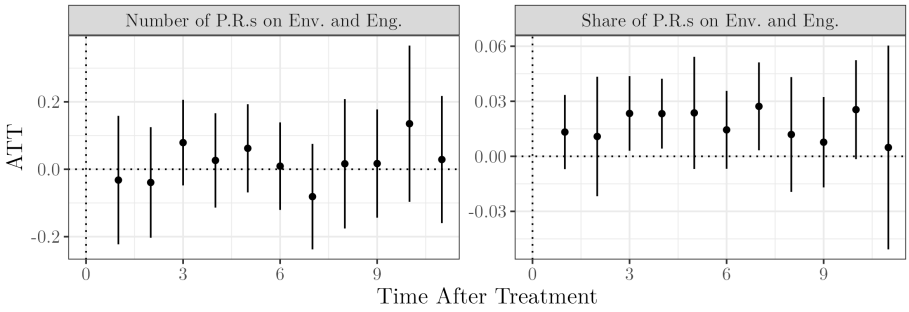

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.46: Effect of FFF on the CDU




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.47: Effect of FFF on the AfD



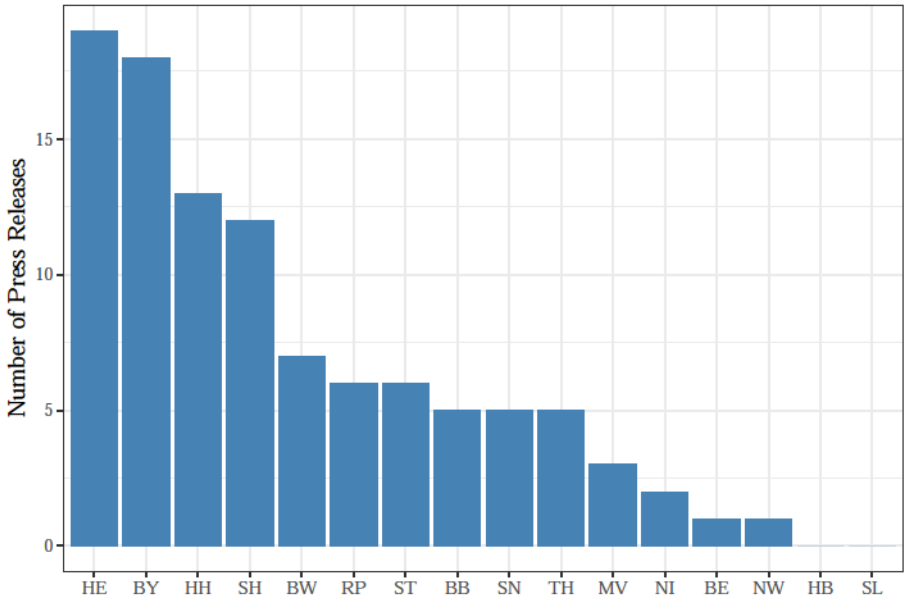

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

| |
|---|
| klimaprotest |
| klimademonstration |
| umweltbewegung |
| jugendbewegung |
| jugendprotest |
| schülerstreik |
| klimastreik |
| fridays for future |
| friday for future |
| fff |
| greta |
| thunberg |

Table B.1: Fridays for Future keywords

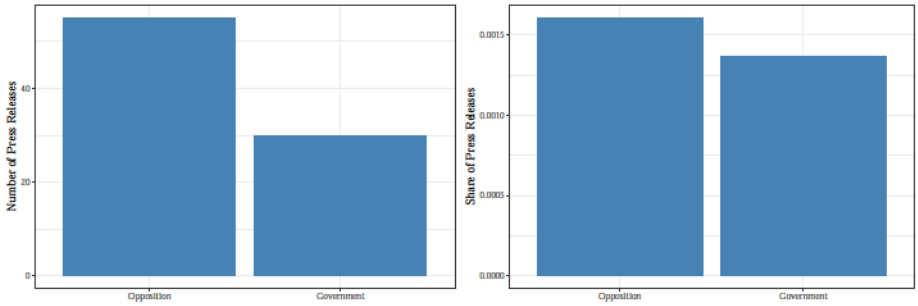
## Additional analysis - Dictionary analysis

Figure B.48: Mentions of FFF across states




**Note:** *The figure displays the total number of mentions of the FFF movement in parties' press releases across states in Germany*

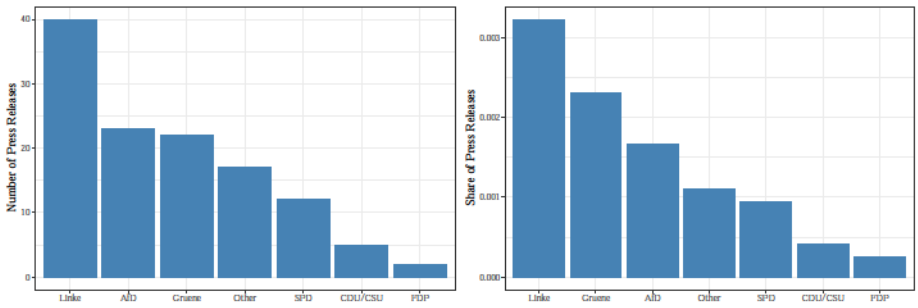
Figure B.49: Mentions of FFF - dependent on opposition status




(a) Number of mentions (b) Share of mentions

**Note:** *The figures displays the total number of mentions of the FFF movement in parties' press releases and the share of parties press releases mentioning the movement for opposition and government parties.*

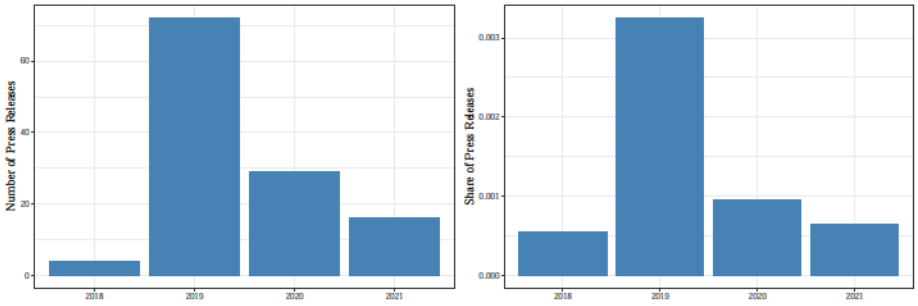
Figure B.50: Mentions of FFF - across parties




(a) Number of mentions (b) Share of mentions

**Note:** *The figures displays the total number of mentions of the FFF movement in parties' press releases and the share of parties press releases mentioning the movement across parties.*

Figure B.51: Mentions of FFF - over years

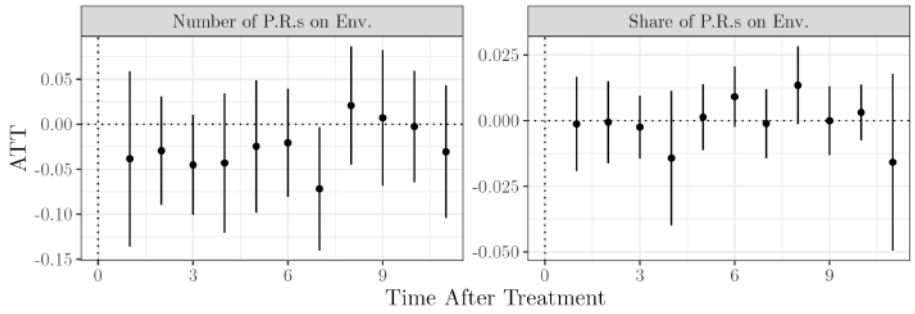



(a) Number of mentions (b) Share of mentions

**Note:** *The figures displays the total number of mentions of the FFF movement in parties' press releases and the share of parties press releases mentioning the movement over time.*

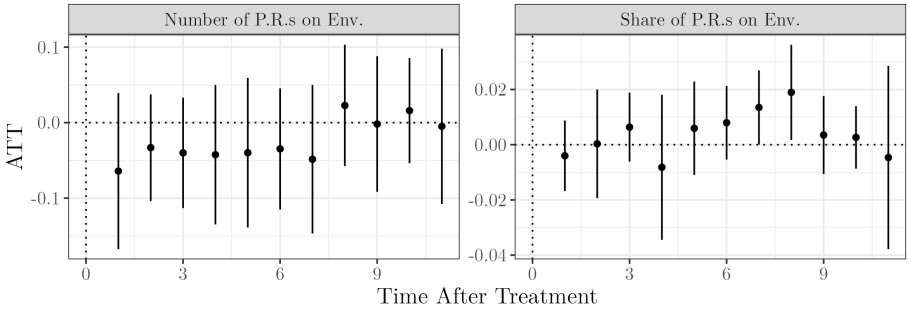
## Additional analysis - Protests only in large cities

Figure B.52: Overall effect of city FFF protests on parties' communications - 3 weeks lag



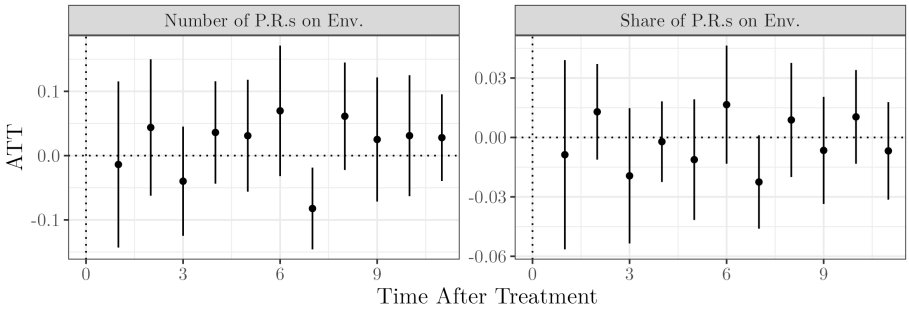

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests in large cities are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.53: Effect of city FFF protests on opposition parties' communications - 3 weeks lag



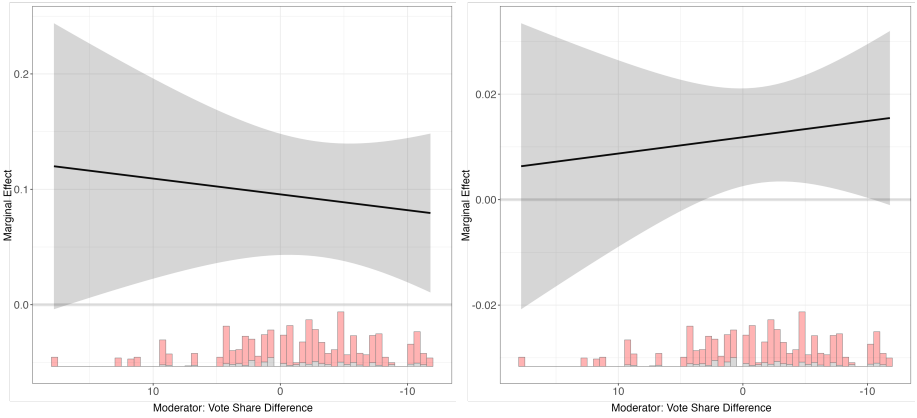

**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests in large cities are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.54: Effect of city FFF protests on government parties' communications - 3 weeks lag




**Note:** *The estimates are based on the matching method that adjust for the treatment histories during the three weeks period prior to the treatment. The estimates for the average effect of FFF protests in large cities are shown for the period of 10 weeks after the protest event with 95% asymptotic confidence intervals as vertical bars.*

Figure B.55: Marginal effect of FFF in large cities - moderated by difference in vote share

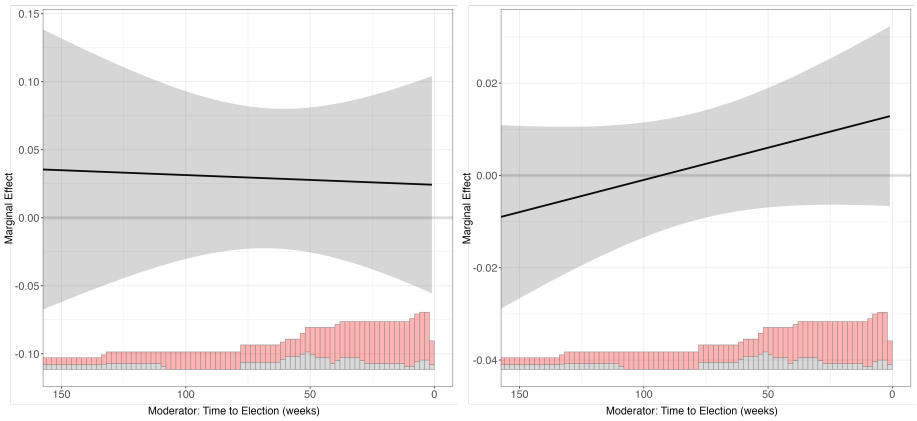



(a) Number of P.R.s on Env.

(b) Share of P.R.s on Env.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on difference in vote share parties experienced in previous elections using a conventional linear interaction model with 95% confidence intervals in grey. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

Figure B.56: Marginal effect of FFF in large cities - moderated by time to elections




(a) Number of P.R.s on Env.

(b) Share of P.R.s on Env.

**Note:** *The figures show the estimated marginal effect of FFF protests dependent on temporal proximity to next elections using a conventional linear interaction model with 95% confidence intervals in grey. The stacked histograms at the bottom of the figures display the distribution and variation in treatment across the moderator.*

# Appendix C

# Supplementary Materials - Chapter 6

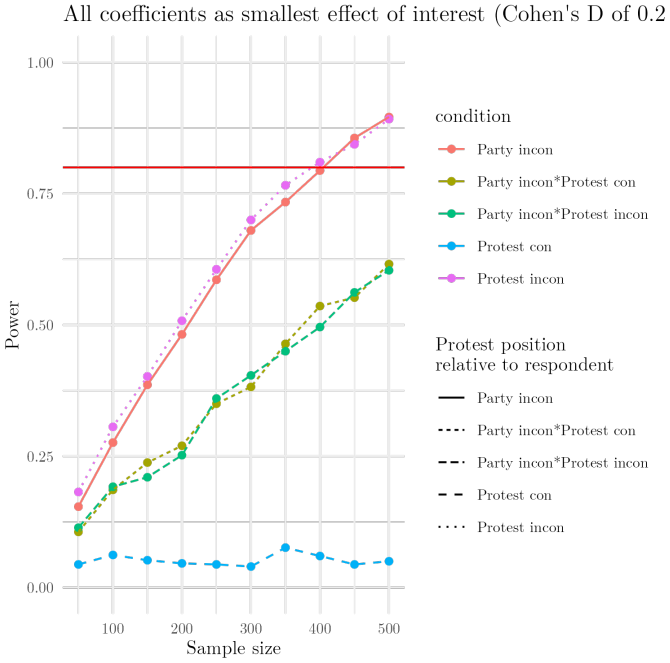
Pre-registration plan, questionnaire and the R analysis scripts can be accessed via this link:

https://box.hu-berlin.de/d/5452ccc9a17f4f6e9b57/

### Sample size rationale

Following standard procedures the experiment aims for a power of 80% with alpha of 0.05. According to descriptive statistics from the German longitudinal electoral survey from 2017, the propensity to vote for the two parties included in the experiment was 5.5 points on average with a pooled standard deviation around 3. Based on this information a power analysis was conducted in R. The experiment was simulated with different effect sizes, ranging from small Cohen's d (0.2) to large Cohen's d (0.8) and varying sample sizes, ranging from 50 respondents per group to 500 respondents per group. Each effect size and sample size combination was simulated 500 times. The code for the function for the simulation can be seen below along with few combination examples. Based

on the simulations, the main effect (ideological incongruence of party on the propensity to vote for the party) requires 400 respondents per group to detect a small effect (Cohen's d of 0.2). The interaction effects are harder to detect and the sample size 2400 (6x400) is only able to detect an effect of Cohen's d of 0.3. This is not necessarily problematic. From a theoretical standpoint slightly larger effect than the 'smallest effect size of interest' can be expected from parties' responsiveness towards protests. The interaction effect of protest position and party position is expected to be motivated by both rational choice and democratic expectations. For this reason the target sample size is 2500.



Larger interaction effects (Cohen's D of 0.3).

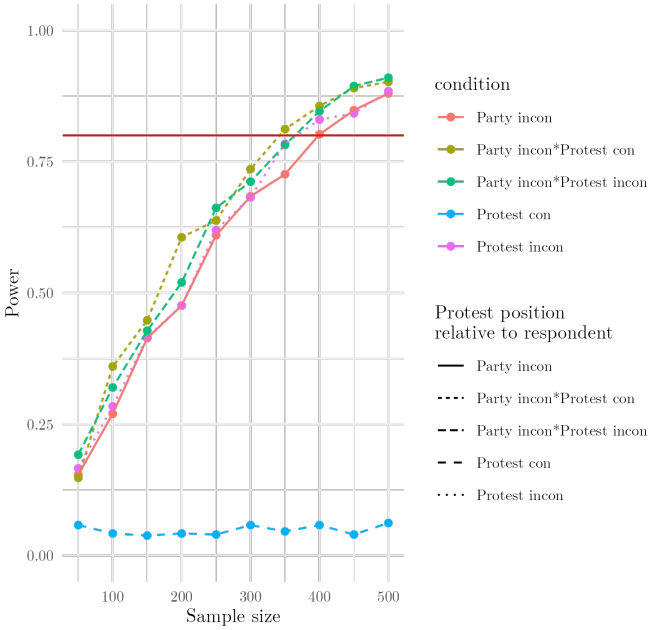
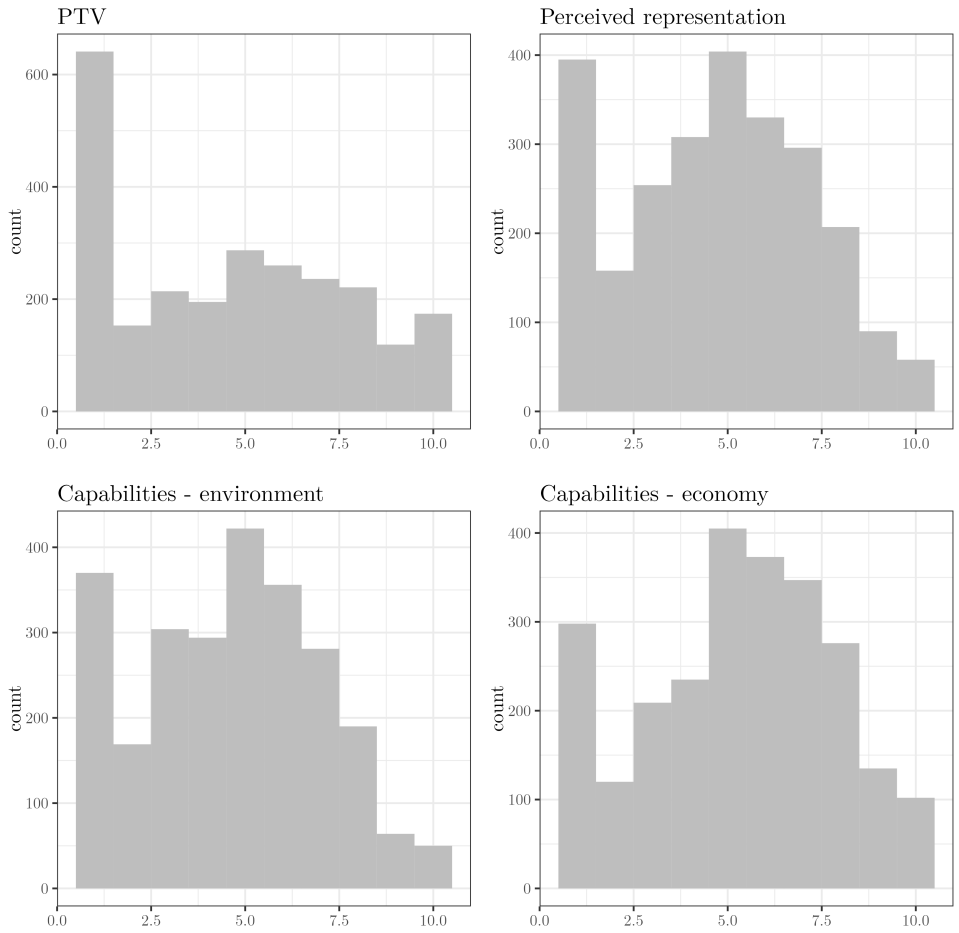
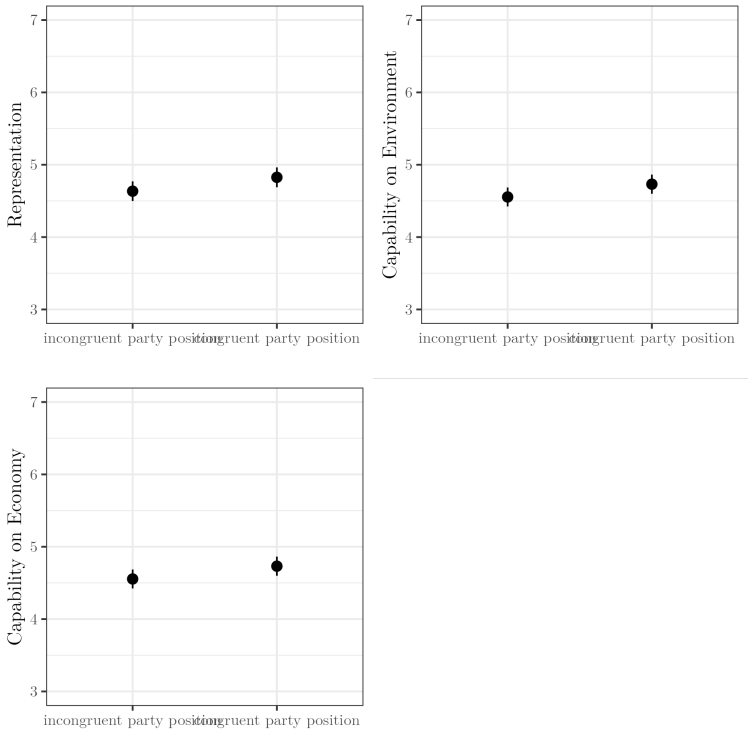


Figure C.1: Distribution of all outcome variables - Full sample




**Note:** *The figures displays the absolute number of respondents for each value on all outcome variables using the full sample of respondents.*

Figure C.2: Average treatment effect for all outcome - Full sample

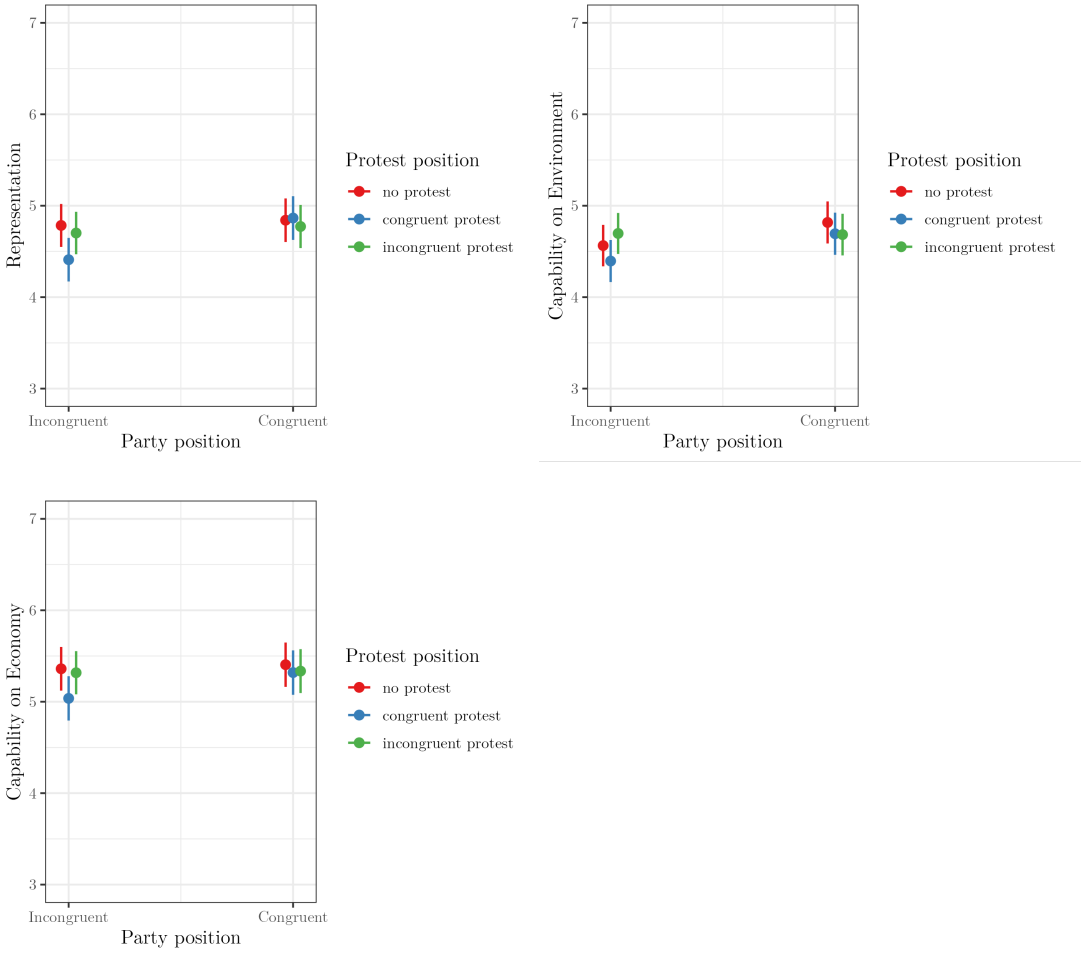



**Note:** *The figures displays the average treatment effect of party position on all outcome variables with 95% confidence intervals using the full sample of respondents.*

| | diff | p adj |
|---|---|---|
| incong. party:no protest-cong. party:no protest | -0.200 | 0.925 |
| cong. party:cong. protest-cong. party:no protest | -0.128 | 0.990 |
| incong. party:cong. protest-cong. party:no protest | -0.541 | 0.091 |
| cong. party:incong. protest-cong. party:no protest | -0.182 | 0.950 |
| incong. party:incong. protest-cong. party:no protest | -0.341 | 0.549 |
| cong. party:cong. protest-incong. party:no protest | 0.072 | 0.999 |
| incong. party:cong. protest-incong. party:no protest | -0.341 | 0.553 |
| cong. party:incong. protest-incong. party:no protest | 0.018 | 1.000 |
| incong. party:incong. protest-incong. party:no protest | -0.141 | 0.982 |
| incong. party:cong. protest-cong. party:cong. protest | -0.413 | 0.341 |
| cong. party:incong. protest-cong. party:cong. protest | -0.054 | 1.000 |
| incong. party:incong. protest-cong. party:cong. protest | -0.213 | 0.903 |
| cong. party:incong. protest-incong. party:cong. protest | 0.360 | 0.497 |
| incong. party:incong. protest-incong. party:cong. protest | 0.201 | 0.922 |
| incong. party:incong. protest-cong. party:incong. protest | -0.159 | 0.970 |

Table C.1: Tukey HDS - Means comparisons - Full sample

Figure C.3: Predicted values for all outcome - Full sample




**Note:** *The figures display the predicted outcome for each combination of protest and party position with a 95% confidence intervals using the full sample of respondents.*

Table C.2: Full sample - Secondary analysis

| | *Dependent variable:* | |
|---|---|---|
| | Perceived Representation | |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | −0.192* | −0.057 |
| | (0.098) | (0.171) |
| Congruent protest | | 0.024 |
| | | (0.172) |
| Incongruent protest | | −0.069 |
| | | (0.171) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | −0.398 |
| | | (0.242) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | −0.014 |
| | | (0.240) |
| Constant | 4.826*** | 4.841*** |
| | (0.070) | (0.121) |
| Observations | 2,500 | 2,500 |
| $R^2$ | 0.002 | 0.004 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.001 | 0.002 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the whole sample of respondents. How well the respondents think the party in the vignette represents public opinion is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.3: Full sample - Secondary analysis

| | *Dependent variable:* | |
|---|---|---|
| | Perceived capability on the environment | |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | $-0.177^{*}$ | $-0.253$ |
| | (0.095) | (0.165) |
| Congruent protest | | $-0.123$ |
| | | (0.166) |
| Incongruent protest | | $-0.133$ |
| | | (0.165) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | $-0.045$ |
| | | (0.234) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | 0.266 |
| | | (0.232) |
| Constant | $4.731^{***}$ | $4.817^{***}$ |
| | (0.068) | (0.117) |
| Observations | 2,500 | 2,500 |
| $R^2$ | 0.001 | 0.003 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.001 | 0.001 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the whole sample of respondents. How capable the respondents think the party in the vignette is in dealing with the environment is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.4: Full sample - Secondary analysis

| | *Dependent variable:* | |
|---|---|---|
| | Perceived capability on the economy | |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | −0.112 | −0.045 |
| | (0.100) | (0.174) |
| Congruent protest | | −0.086 |
| | | (0.175) |
| Incongruent protest | | −0.070 |
| | | (0.174) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | −0.237 |
| | | (0.246) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | 0.027 |
| | | (0.244) |
| Constant | 5.353*** | 5.405*** |
| | (0.071) | (0.124) |
| Observations | 2,500 | 2,500 |
| $R^2$ | 0.001 | 0.002 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.0001 | 0.0002 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the whole sample of respondents. How capable the respondents think the party in the vignette is in dealing with the economy is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.5: No Partisans - Full sample

| | *Dependent variable:* | |
|---|---|---|
| | PTV | |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | −0.237* | −0.311 |
| | (0.142) | (0.245) |
| Congruent protest | | −0.096 |
| | | (0.248) |
| Incongruent protest | | −0.272 |
| | | (0.249) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | −0.073 |
| | | (0.347) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | 0.293 |
| | | (0.348) |
| Constant | 4.877*** | 5.000*** |
| | (0.101) | (0.176) |
| Observations | 1,699 | 1,699 |
| $R^2$ | 0.002 | 0.003 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.001 | −0.0002 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who did not have a strong partisan tie to any party. The PTV for the party of the vignette is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.6: Important issue - Full sample

| | *Dependent variable:* | |
|---|---|---|
| | PTV | |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | −0.338*** | −0.283 |
| | (0.131) | (0.225) |
| Congruent protest | | −0.062 |
| | | (0.227) |
| Incongruent protest | | −0.216 |
| | | (0.228) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | −0.310 |
| | | (0.320) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | 0.138 |
| | | (0.320) |
| Constant | 4.769*** | 4.862*** |
| | (0.093) | (0.161) |
| Observations | 2,103 | 2,103 |
| $R^2$ | 0.003 | 0.005 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.003 | 0.003 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who think the environment or the economy is an important issue. The PTV for the party of the vignette is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.7: Left-Right Position - Full sample

| | *Dependent variable: PTV* | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Left-wing | Left-wing | Right-wing | Right-wing |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) |
| Incongruent party position | −0.258 | −0.253 | −0.270 | 0.100 |
| | (0.180) | (0.312) | (0.247) | (0.440) |
| Congruent protest | | −0.398 | | 0.309 |
| | | (0.320) | | (0.429) |
| Incongruent protest | | −0.180 | | 0.009 |
| | | (0.318) | | (0.410) |
| Incong. party*Cong. protest | | −0.180 | | −0.583 |
| | | (0.442) | | (0.619) |
| Incong. party*Incong. protest | | 0.119 | | −0.500 |
| | | (0.439) | | (0.605) |
| Constant | 4.790*** | 4.987*** | 4.702*** | 4.608*** |
| | (0.129) | (0.231) | (0.172) | (0.287) |
| Observations | 1,051 | 1,051 | 649 | 649 |
| $R^2$ | 0.002 | 0.007 | 0.002 | 0.005 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.001 | 0.003 | 0.0003 | −0.003 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for samples based on the left-right position. The PTV for the party of the vignette is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.8: No partisans - Full sample - Secondary outcomes

| | *Dependent variable:* | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | Representation | Environment | Economy |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Incongruent party position | −0.173 | −0.362* | −0.138 |
| | (0.201) | (0.193) | (0.202) |
| Congruent protest | −0.055 | −0.125 | −0.147 |
| | (0.203) | (0.196) | (0.205) |
| Incongruent protest | −0.199 | −0.236 | −0.180 |
| | (0.204) | (0.197) | (0.205) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | −0.188 | 0.070 | −0.067 |
| | (0.284) | (0.274) | (0.286) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | 0.241 | 0.461* | 0.296 |
| | (0.285) | (0.274) | (0.287) |
| Constant | 5.058*** | 5.011*** | 5.607*** |
| | (0.144) | (0.139) | (0.145) |
| Observations | 1,699 | 1,699 | 1,699 |
| $R^2$ | 0.003 | 0.004 | 0.002 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.0001 | 0.001 | −0.001 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who did not have strong partisan tie to any party. The secondary outcomes are the dependent variables.* *$p<0.1$; **$p<0.05$; ***$p<0.01$

Table C.9: Important Issue - Full sample - Secondary outcomes

| | *Dependent variable:* | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | Representation | Environment | Economy |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Incongruent party position | −0.176 | −0.406** | −0.105 |
| | (0.186) | (0.181) | (0.190) |
| Congruent protest | 0.085 | −0.070 | −0.003 |
| | (0.187) | (0.182) | (0.191) |
| Incongruent protest | −0.103 | −0.211 | −0.083 |
| | (0.189) | (0.183) | (0.192) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | −0.492* | −0.043 | −0.368 |
| | (0.264) | (0.257) | (0.269) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | 0.106 | 0.475* | 0.170 |
| | (0.265) | (0.257) | (0.270) |
| Constant | 4.862*** | 4.841*** | 5.435*** |
| | (0.133) | (0.129) | (0.136) |
| Observations | 2,103 | 2,103 | 2,103 |
| $R^2$ | 0.007 | 0.006 | 0.004 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.005 | 0.003 | 0.002 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who think the economy or the environment is an important issue. The secondary outcomes are the dependent variables.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.10: Robustness-Checks

| | *Dependent variable: PTV* | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Controls | Party fixed-effect | Issue fixed-effect | Full model |
| Incong. party position | −0.196 | −0.201 | −0.200 | −0.197 |
| | (0.205) | (0.205) | (0.205) | (0.205) |
| Cong. protest | −0.100 | −0.129 | −0.138 | −0.115 |
| | (0.207) | (0.206) | (0.215) | (0.215) |
| Incong. protest | −0.175 | −0.182 | −0.197 | −0.197 |
| | (0.205) | (0.205) | (0.224) | (0.224) |
| Women (Ref. Men) | 0.078 | | | 0.079 |
| | (0.119) | | | (0.119) |
| Left-Right | 0.022 | | | 0.022 |
| | (0.030) | | | (0.030) |
| BW (Ref. BY) | −0.069 | | | −0.070 |
| | (0.223) | | | (0.223) |
| HE (Ref. BY) | 0.264 | | | 0.260 |
| | (0.263) | | | (0.264) |
| RP (Ref. BY) | −0.412 | | | −0.417 |
| | (0.304) | | | (0.305) |
| SL (Ref. BY) | 0.752 | | | 0.745 |
| | (0.543) | | | (0.543) |
| SN (Ref.BY) | −0.900*** | | | −0.904*** |
| | (0.298) | | | (0.298) |
| ST (Ref. BY) | −0.900** | | | −0.898** |
| | (0.372) | | | (0.372) |
| NW (Ref. BY) | −0.034 | | | −0.033 |
| | (0.197) | | | (0.197) |
| NI (Ref. BY) | −0.162 | | | −0.159 |
| | (0.243) | | | (0.243) |
| TH (Ref. BY) | −0.308 | | | −0.314 |
| | (0.381) | | | (0.381) |
| BB (Ref. BY) | −0.760** | | | −0.759** |
| | (0.364) | | | (0.364) |
| BE (Ref. BY) | −0.020 | | | −0.016 |
| | (0.326) | | | (0.326) |
| MV (Ref. BY) | −0.944** | | | −0.944** |
| | (0.436) | | | (0.437) |
| SH (Ref. BY) | −0.355 | | | −0.350 |
| | (0.350) | | | (0.350) |
| HB (Ref. BY) | −0.294 | | | −0.292 |
| | (0.676) | | | (0.677) |
| HH (Ref. BY) | 0.255 | | | 0.246 |
| | (0.432) | | | (0.433) |
| SPD (Ref. CDU/CSU) | | 0.065 | | 0.056 |
| | | (0.118) | | (0.118) |
| Env. protest (Ref. No protest) | | | 0.025 | 0.036 |
| | | | (0.147) | (0.147) |
| Incong. party*Cong. protest | −0.215 | −0.214 | −0.214 | −0.217 |
| | (0.291) | (0.291) | (0.291) | (0.291) |
| Incong. party*Incong. protest | 0.036 | 0.043 | 0.042 | 0.038 |
| | (0.288) | (0.288) | (0.288) | (0.288) |
| $R^2$ | 0.016 | 0.003 | 0.003 | 0.017 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.008 | 0.001 | 0.001 | 0.007 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression including different control variables. The PTV for the party of the vignette is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.11: Manipulation checks - overview

| | | N | % |
|---|---|---|---|
| If a party reacted to protest | Yes | 968 | 38.7 |
| | No | 356 | 14.2 |
| | I don't know | 344 | 13.8 |
| Which party reacted to protest | CDUCSU | 385 | 15.4 |
| | SPD | 440 | 17.6 |
| | The Left Party | 18 | 0.7 |
| | The Green Party | 47 | 1.9 |
| | FDP | 13 | 0.5 |
| | AfD | 42 | 1.7 |
| | No Party | 1 | 0.0 |
| | I don't know | 22 | 0.9 |
| How did party react to protest | The party agreed | 490 | 19.6 |
| | The party disagreed | 411 | 16.4 |
| | I don't know | 44 | 1.8 |
| How did party position itself | The party prioritised the eco. | 293 | 11.7 |
| | The party prioritised the env. | 295 | 11.8 |
| | The party had no clear position | 167 | 6.7 |
| | I don't know | 77 | 3.1 |

**Note:** *The table shows the summary statistics of respondents' answers for the manipulation checks.*

Table C.12: Sample differences

| | *Dependent variable:* | |
|---|---|---|
| | Passing manipulation tests - binary | |
| | Demographics | Poltical attitudes |
| Edu.: Middle (Ref. Low) | 0.545*** | 0.457*** |
| | (0.131) | (0.133) |
| Edu.: High (Ref. Low) | 0.937*** | 0.770*** |
| | (0.142) | (0.146) |
| Women (Ref. Men) | −0.039 | −0.054 |
| | (0.082) | (0.084) |
| Age (Categorical) | 0.129*** | 0.130*** |
| | (0.029) | (0.029) |
| BW (Ref. BY) | 0.089 | 0.130 |
| | (0.153) | (0.155) |
| HE (Ref. BY) | −0.084 | −0.037 |
| | (0.182) | (0.184) |
| RP (Ref. BY) | 0.078 | 0.151 |
| | (0.210) | (0.213) |
| SL (Ref. BY) | 0.203 | 0.198 |
| | (0.372) | (0.377) |
| SN (Ref. BY) | −0.313 | −0.190 |
| | (0.207) | (0.211) |
| ST (Ref. BY) | −0.246 | −0.170 |
| | (0.258) | (0.261) |
| NW (Ref. BY) | −0.047 | −0.025 |
| | (0.136) | (0.138) |
| NI (Ref. BY) | −0.201 | −0.170 |
| | (0.169) | (0.171) |
| TH (Ref. BY) | −0.166 | 0.010 |
| | (0.264) | (0.269) |
| BB (Ref. BY) | −0.354 | −0.241 |
| | (0.254) | (0.257) |
| BE (Ref. BY) | −0.165 | −0.098 |
| | (0.226) | (0.228) |
| MV (Ref. BY) | 0.252 | 0.394 |
| | (0.301) | (0.305) |
| SH (Ref. BY) | −0.097 | −0.118 |
| | (0.243) | (0.246) |
| HB (Ref. BY) | 0.092 | 0.283 |
| | (0.464) | (0.469) |
| HH (Ref. BY) | 0.344 | 0.345 |
| | (0.301) | (0.305) |
| SPD (Ref. CDU/CSU) | | −0.019 |
| | | (0.024) |
| The Left Party (Ref. CDU/CSU) | | −0.134 |
| | | (0.130) |
| The Green party (Ref. CDU/CSU) | | −0.231 |
| | | (0.199) |
| FDP (Ref. CDU/CSU) | | 0.439*** |
| | | (0.150) |
| AfD (Ref. CDU/CSU) | | −0.0001 |
| | | (0.160) |
| Other Party (Ref. CDU/CSU) | | −0.345** |
| | | (0.155) |
| Invalid ballot (Ref. CDU/CSU) | | 0.045 |
| | | (0.196) |
| Didn't vote (Ref. CDU/CSU) | | −1.038** |
| | | (0.446) |
| Log Likelihood | −1,687.063 | −1,668.333 |
| Akaike Inf. Crit. | 3,414.125 | 3,394.667 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression with the likelihood of passing the manipulation checks as a binary dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.13: No Partisans - Passed checks

| | *Dependent variable:* | |
|---|---|---|
| | PTV | |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | $-0.695^{***}$ | $-0.773^{**}$ |
| | (0.213) | (0.332) |
| Congruent protest | | $-0.248$ |
| | | (0.365) |
| Incongruent protest | | $-0.738^{**}$ |
| | | (0.360) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | $-0.407$ |
| | | (0.515) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | 0.635 |
| | | (0.513) |
| Constant | $5.095^{***}$ | $5.394^{***}$ |
| | (0.150) | (0.237) |
| Observations | 794 | 794 |
| $R^2$ | 0.013 | 0.023 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.012 | 0.017 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who did not have a strong partisan tie to any party and who passed the manipulation checks. The PTV for the party of the vignette is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.14: Important issue - Passed checks

| | *Dependent variable:* | |
|---|---|---|
| | PTV | |
| | (1) | (2) |
| Incongruent party position | $-0.710^{***}$ | $-0.760^{**}$ |
| | (0.188) | (0.297) |
| Congruent protest | | $-0.295$ |
| | | (0.322) |
| Incongruent protest | | $-0.669^{**}$ |
| | | (0.328) |
| Incongruent party*Congruent protest | | $-0.378$ |
| | | (0.454) |
| Incongruent party*Incongruent protest | | 0.525 |
| | | (0.455) |
| Constant | $5.014^{***}$ | $5.302^{***}$ |
| | (0.135) | (0.214) |
| Observations | 1,032 | 1,032 |
| $R^2$ | 0.014 | 0.022 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.013 | 0.017 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who think the environment or the economy is an important issue and who passed the manipulation checks. The PTV of the party in the vignette is the dependent variable.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Table C.15: Direct effect of protests

| | *Dependent variable: PTV* | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | CDU/CSU | SPD | Greens | FDP | Left | AfD |
| | (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) | (5) | (6) |
| Incongruent Party | −0.423** | −0.092 | 0.204 | 0.065 | 0.254* | −0.353* |
| | (0.177) | (0.172) | (0.184) | (0.151) | (0.154) | (0.181) |
| Congruent protest | −0.472** | 0.002 | 0.273 | −0.213 | −0.180 | −0.412* |
| | (0.215) | (0.209) | (0.223) | (0.184) | (0.187) | (0.220) |
| Incongruent protest | −0.270 | 0.173 | 0.267 | −0.232 | −0.217 | −0.494** |
| | (0.212) | (0.206) | (0.220) | (0.181) | (0.185) | (0.217) |
| Constant | 5.077*** | 4.763*** | 3.737*** | 3.899*** | 3.280*** | 3.478*** |
| | (0.167) | (0.161) | (0.173) | (0.142) | (0.145) | (0.170) |
| Observations | 1,170 | 1,170 | 1,170 | 1,170 | 1,170 | 1,170 |
| $R^2$ | 0.009 | 0.001 | 0.003 | 0.002 | 0.004 | 0.008 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.006 | −0.002 | 0.0002 | −0.001 | 0.001 | 0.006 |

**Note:** *The table shows the results from the OLS regression for the sample of respondents who passed the manipulation checks. The PTV of all the German parties are the dependent variables.* $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$